Copilot: The Workplace AI Guide

Master Copilot Across Word, Excel, PowerPoint, Outlook, and Teams

Ken Tannenbaum

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Finnoybu Press

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2026 Edition

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About the Author

Ken Tannenbaum is a technology strategist and writer who has spent two decades helping people make sense of emerging technologies. He has worked with organizations ranging from Fortune 500 companies to scrappy startups on technology adoption, digital transformation, and – most recently – the practical integration of AI into everyday work and life.

Ken writes about technology the way he wishes someone had explained it to him: clearly, honestly, and with enough specificity to actually be useful. He believes the best technology books are the ones that save readers more time than they spent reading them.

He lives and works in the United States.

Dedication

To every worker who has ever wished their computer would just do the thing already – your day has come.

And to Microsoft, for finally making Clippy's dream a reality. He would be so proud.

The AI for Everyone Series

This book is part of the **AI for Everyone** series by Finnoybu Press, designed to help real people use AI tools effectively.

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AI Disclosure

This book was written with the assistance of AI tools, which is exactly what you should expect from a book about using AI effectively. The author used AI for research assistance, draft generation, and editorial review throughout the writing process. Every word was reviewed, edited, and approved by a human author who takes full responsibility for the content.

The prompts, examples, and recommendations in this book come from extensive hands-on testing with Microsoft Copilot across all platforms and plan tiers. When I tell you a particular approach works well, it is because I have used it myself. When I tell you something does not work, that comes from experience too.

Using AI to write a book about AI is not irony – it is proof of concept.

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Introduction

What This Book Covers

Microsoft Copilot is one of the most ambitious AI products ever shipped. It is embedded in Windows, in Edge, in Microsoft 365, in Teams, in GitHub, and in a standalone app you can use right now for free. It can write your emails, analyze your spreadsheets, build your presentations, generate images, search the web, summarize meetings, and hold a conversation about nearly anything.

The problem is not whether Copilot can help you. The problem is that nobody has explained – clearly, practically, and without marketing fluff – how to actually use it well.

That is what this book does.

We start at the very beginning: what Copilot is, which plan is right for you, and how to set it up. Then we move through everyday use cases – writing, research, productivity, and personal tasks – before diving into Copilot inside each Microsoft 365 app: Word, Excel, PowerPoint, Outlook, and Teams. From there, we cover advanced features like image generation with Designer, Pages and Notebooks, Think Deeper mode, and Copilot Vision. We close with prompting techniques that will make everything work better, specialized chapters for students, businesses, and developers, and a clear-eyed look at what Copilot gets wrong, how to stay safe, and how to use AI responsibly.

Who This Book Is For

This book is for anyone who uses – or is thinking about using – Microsoft Copilot. You do not need any technical background. You do not need to understand how AI works under the hood. You need to be someone who wants to get more done with less effort, and who would appreciate a guide that respects your time and intelligence.

If you are a student, a teacher, a manager, an accountant, a marketer, a writer, a small business owner, or someone who just wants to understand what all the fuss is about – this book is for you.

If you are already an experienced Copilot user looking for advanced techniques, enterprise deployment strategies, and developer workflows, the companion volume *Copilot: The Power User Guide* picks up where this book leaves off.

How to Read This Book

You have two options. The first is to read it straight through, front to back. The chapters build on each other, and by the end you will have a thorough understanding of Copilot and a solid set of skills.

The second option is to jump to whatever you need right now. Each chapter is designed to be useful on its own. If you just want to learn how to use Copilot in Excel, go straight to Chapter 11. If you want better prompts, start at Chapter 19. The table of contents and appendices are designed to help you find what you need quickly.

Either approach works. This book will meet you where you are.

A Note on AI Assistance

This book was written with the assistance of AI tools. The full disclosure is in the front matter, but the short version is: AI helped with research, drafting, and review. Every word was reviewed, edited, and approved by a human author. The prompts and examples come from real, hands-on testing. When I say something works, I have tried it myself.

Let us get started.

Chapter 1: What Is Microsoft Copilot?

You have probably heard the buzz. Artificial intelligence is everywhere now – in the news, in conversations at work, in the apps on your phone. But if you have not actually sat down and used an AI assistant, you might be wondering what all the fuss is about. That is exactly where Microsoft Copilot comes in, and that is exactly why you are reading this book.

Microsoft Copilot is an AI-powered assistant built by Microsoft. You can talk to it in plain English (or dozens of other languages), ask it questions, have it write things for you, help you think through problems, generate images, summarize documents, and much more. It lives inside the apps you probably already use – Windows, Microsoft Edge, Word, Excel, PowerPoint, Outlook, and Teams – and it is also available as a standalone website and mobile app.

If you have never used an AI tool before, do not worry. This book assumes zero prior experience. By the end of this chapter, you will understand what Copilot is, where it came from, and why it matters for your daily life and work.

The Simple Explanation

Think of Copilot as an incredibly knowledgeable assistant who is always available and never gets tired. You type or speak a question, and it responds with helpful, human-sounding answers. Need a thank-you email drafted? Ask Copilot. Want to understand a complicated news story? Ask Copilot. Trying to plan a vacation itinerary? Ask Copilot.

Unlike a search engine, which gives you a list of links and leaves you to figure things out, Copilot reads through information and gives you a direct, synthesized answer. It can also create things – write essays, compose emails, generate images, build tables, brainstorm ideas, and even write code.

At its core, Copilot is powered by large language models, which are a type of artificial intelligence that has been trained on enormous amounts of text from books, websites, articles, and other sources. These models learned patterns in human language so well that they can generate new text that reads as if a person wrote it. Microsoft partners with a company called OpenAI to use their most advanced models – specifically the GPT-5 family of models – to power Copilot.

A Brief History: How We Got Here

Microsoft has been trying to build a useful AI assistant for years. If you used Windows 10, you might remember Cortana, the voice assistant that could set reminders and answer basic questions. Cortana was a solid first attempt, but it never quite reached the level of usefulness that people wanted.

Everything changed in late 2022 and early 2023 when OpenAI released ChatGPT, which captured the world's imagination with its ability to hold natural conversations. Microsoft, which had invested billions of dollars in OpenAI, moved quickly. In February 2023, they launched an AI-powered version of their Bing search engine, initially called "Bing Chat."

Bing Chat was impressive. It could answer questions using real-time information from the web, hold extended conversations, and generate images. But the name was limiting – it tied the experience to Bing, which many people did not use as their primary search engine.

So in late 2023, Microsoft made a smart move: they rebranded the entire experience as "Microsoft Copilot." The new name signaled something important. This was not just a search tool. It was an AI companion – a copilot – designed to work alongside you in everything you do on your computer.

From there, things moved fast. Microsoft embedded Copilot into Windows 11, into the Edge browser, and most importantly, deep into Microsoft 365 – the suite of productivity tools that includes Word, Excel, PowerPoint, Outlook, and Teams. By 2025 and into 2026, Copilot gained what Microsoft calls "agentic capabilities," meaning it can take actions on your behalf, not just answer questions. It can draft documents, manage your calendar, summarize meeting recordings, and even automate multi-step workflows.

Where You Can Use Copilot

One of Copilot's biggest strengths is that it meets you where you already are. Here are the main places you will find it:

Copilot on the Web. Visit copilot.microsoft.com in any browser. This is the simplest way to start. You get a chat interface where you can type questions, have conversations, generate images, and more. No installation required.

The Windows App. If you are running Windows 10 or 11, there is a dedicated Copilot app. You can pin it to your taskbar for quick access. It works just like the web version but feels more integrated with your desktop.

Microsoft Edge. The Edge browser has Copilot built into a sidebar. You can ask it questions about the webpage you are currently viewing, get summaries of articles, or have a general conversation – all without leaving the page you are on.

Mobile Apps. Copilot is available as a free app on both iOS (iPhone and iPad) and Android. The mobile app supports voice conversations, making it easy to talk to Copilot hands-free.

Inside Microsoft 365. This is where Copilot really shines for professionals. If you have a Microsoft 365 subscription with Copilot, it appears inside Word, Excel, PowerPoint, Outlook, and Teams. In Word, it can draft and rewrite documents. In Excel, it can analyze data and create charts. In PowerPoint, it can build entire presentations. In Outlook, it can summarize long email threads and draft replies. In Teams, it can summarize meetings you missed.

What Can Copilot Actually Do?

Let us get concrete. Here is a sampling of what you can do with Copilot today:

Answer questions. Ask anything from "What is the capital of Mongolia?" to "Explain quantum computing like I am ten years old" to "What are the pros and cons of buying versus leasing a car?"

Search the web with citations. Copilot can search Bing to find current information and provide links to its sources. This is called "search grounding," and it means you can verify the information Copilot gives you.

Write and edit text. Need a cover letter? A birthday toast? A business proposal? A complaint letter to your landlord? Tell Copilot what you need, and it will draft it. You can then ask it to revise the tone, shorten it, make it more formal, or adjust it however you like.

Generate images. Copilot includes Microsoft Designer, which uses AI image generation (powered by DALL-E) to create pictures from text descriptions. Describe what you want – "a cozy cabin in the woods during autumn" – and it will generate the image.

Summarize and analyze. Paste in a long article, a contract, or meeting notes, and ask Copilot to summarize the key points. It can pull out action items, identify themes, or highlight potential issues.

Brainstorm and plan. Use Copilot as a thinking partner. Ask it to help you brainstorm names for a business, plan a weekly meal schedule, outline a presentation, or think through a difficult decision.

Have extended conversations. Copilot remembers context within a conversation. You can build on previous messages, refine your requests, and have a back-and-forth dialogue just like you would with a knowledgeable colleague.

Work inside your documents. With the right subscription, Copilot can work directly inside your Word documents, Excel spreadsheets, PowerPoint presentations, Outlook emails, and Teams chats. This is where the "copilot" metaphor really comes alive – it works alongside you in the tools you already use.

What Copilot Is Not

Setting expectations is important, especially if this is your first experience with AI. Here is what Copilot is not:

It is not infallible. Copilot can and does make mistakes. It might present incorrect information confidently, misunderstand your question, or generate text that sounds right but is factually wrong. Always verify important information, especially anything involving health, legal, or financial matters.

It is not a person. Copilot does not have feelings, opinions, or consciousness. When it says "I think" or "I believe," those are language patterns, not genuine thoughts. It is a tool – an extraordinarily capable one, but a tool nonetheless.

It is not a replacement for expertise. Copilot can help you draft a legal document, but it is not a lawyer. It can explain medical symptoms, but it is not a doctor. Think of it as a brilliant research assistant, not a licensed professional.

It does not learn from your conversations permanently. Copilot can remember context within a single conversation, but it does not carry memories from one conversation to the next (unless you use specific features designed for that purpose, which we will cover later).

It is not free of limitations. There are things Copilot will decline to do – generating harmful content, providing instructions for dangerous activities, or creating certain types of images. These guardrails are intentional.

How Is Copilot Different from Other AI Assistants?

You might be wondering how Copilot compares to other AI tools you have heard about, like ChatGPT, Google Gemini, or Claude. That is a fair question.

The honest answer is that the underlying AI capabilities are similar across these tools – they are all powered by large language models, and they can all handle basic conversation, writing, and question-answering tasks competently.

Where Copilot stands apart is integration. No other AI assistant is as deeply embedded in the Microsoft ecosystem. If your work life revolves around Word, Excel, PowerPoint, Outlook, and Teams – and for hundreds of millions of people worldwide, it does – then Copilot has a unique advantage. It can work with your actual documents, your actual emails, your actual meeting recordings. It understands the context of your work because it lives inside the tools where your work happens.

Copilot also benefits from Bing search integration, which means it can access current information from the web and provide citations. And its image generation capabilities through Microsoft Designer are included at no extra cost for many users.

For people who live in the Microsoft ecosystem, Copilot is the most natural and powerful AI assistant available.

The Technology Behind the Curtain

You do not need to understand the technical details to use Copilot effectively, but a little context helps.

Copilot is powered by OpenAI's GPT-5 family of models. "GPT" stands for Generative Pre-trained Transformer, which describes the type of AI architecture used. The "5"

indicates it is the fifth major generation. Microsoft uses several variants, including GPT-5.2 and GPT-5.4, each optimized for different tasks.

These models were trained on vast amounts of text data, learning patterns in language, facts about the world, reasoning strategies, and more. When you ask Copilot a question, it does not look up the answer in a database. Instead, it generates a response word by word, predicting what the most helpful and relevant next word should be based on everything it learned during training.

This is why Copilot can be so flexible – it is not following a script. It is generating fresh responses tailored to your specific request. But it is also why it can occasionally produce errors – it is making predictions, not retrieving verified facts.

When Copilot uses Bing search grounding, it supplements its built-in knowledge with real-time information from the web. This combination of deep training and live search results is what makes it so useful for both general knowledge questions and current events.

Why This Matters for You

Here is the bottom line: Microsoft Copilot is one of the most accessible and practical AI tools available today. It is free to start using, it works on devices you already own, and it integrates with software you probably already use.

Whether you want to save time on writing tasks, get help understanding complex topics, boost your productivity at work, or simply explore what AI can do, Copilot is an excellent place to start.

In the next chapter, we will walk through the different Copilot plans available so you can figure out which one makes sense for your needs and budget. Then we will get you set up and running. By the end of this book, you will be using Copilot with confidence – and wondering how you ever got by without it.

Chapter 2: Choosing the Right Plan

One of the first questions people ask about Microsoft Copilot is, “Do I have to pay for it?” The short answer is no – you can start using Copilot right now without spending a dime. But the longer answer is that Microsoft offers several different plans, and the one that is right for you depends on how you plan to use it.

This chapter breaks down every Copilot plan available in 2026, explains what you get with each one, and helps you decide which tier makes sense for your situation. We will keep it straightforward – no marketing jargon, just honest guidance.

The Free Tier: More Than You Might Expect

The free version of Copilot is genuinely useful. This is not a crippled trial version designed to frustrate you into upgrading. It is a fully functional AI assistant that millions of people use every day without paying a cent.

Here is what you get with free Copilot:

- **Chat conversations** with GPT-5 class models
- **Bing search grounding** so Copilot can find current information and cite sources
- **Image generation** through Microsoft Designer (with daily limits)
- **Access on all platforms** – web, Windows app, Edge sidebar, iOS, and Android
- **Voice conversations** on mobile
- **Basic file and image analysis** – you can upload a photo or document and ask questions about it

The free tier does have limitations. You get a limited number of messages per day with the more powerful models, and you may be shifted to a lighter model during peak usage times. You also do not get access to Copilot inside Microsoft 365 apps, and some advanced features like Think Deeper mode have daily usage caps.

But here is the important thing: if you are new to AI and just want to explore, the free tier is more than enough to get started. You can use it for weeks or months before you need to think about upgrading.

Best for: Casual users, anyone exploring AI for the first time, students, anyone who wants a capable AI assistant without commitment.

Microsoft 365 Premium: The Bundle Approach

At $19.99 per month, Microsoft 365 Premium is not specifically a "Copilot plan" – it is Microsoft's premium personal subscription that bundles everything together. You get the full Microsoft 365 suite (Word, Excel, PowerPoint, Outlook, OneNote, OneDrive with 1 TB of storage) plus enhanced Copilot capabilities.

What the Premium bundle adds beyond free Copilot:

- **Higher usage limits** for chat conversations and image generation
- **Priority access** to the latest and most powerful models
- **Copilot in Microsoft 365 apps** – this is the big one. Copilot appears inside Word, Excel, PowerPoint, Outlook, and OneNote, working directly with your documents
- **Pages** – a collaborative AI canvas where you can work with Copilot on longer projects
- **Notebooks** – extended context windows for working with longer documents
- **All the standard Microsoft 365 benefits** – the desktop apps, 1 TB OneDrive storage, and more

If you already pay for Microsoft 365 Personal or Family, the upgrade to Premium may make financial sense. You are essentially adding full Copilot capabilities for the difference in price.

Best for: Individuals who already use or want Microsoft 365 and want Copilot integrated into their productivity apps.

Copilot Pro: Standalone Power

Copilot Pro costs $20 per month and is designed for people who want the enhanced Copilot experience without necessarily needing a full Microsoft 365 subscription – or who already have one and want to add Copilot on top.

What Copilot Pro includes:

- **Priority access to the latest models** during peak times, so you are never bumped to a lighter model
- **Higher daily limits** on messages and image generation
- **Think Deeper mode** with generous daily allowances for extended reasoning
- **Copilot in Microsoft 365 apps** (if you also have a Microsoft 365 subscription)
- **Advanced image generation** features in Designer
- **Earlier access to new features** as Microsoft rolls them out

Here is the key distinction: Copilot Pro gives you the enhanced AI capabilities, but it does not include the Microsoft 365 apps themselves. If you want Copilot inside Word and Excel, you need both a Microsoft 365 subscription and Copilot Pro (or the Premium bundle mentioned above).

Best for: Power users who rely heavily on AI assistance, professionals who want guaranteed access to the best models, and anyone who already has Microsoft 365 and wants to supercharge it with Copilot.

Microsoft 365 Copilot for Business: The Workplace Solution

Now we move into business territory. Microsoft 365 Copilot for Business is priced at $18 to $21 per user per month (on top of an existing Microsoft 365 business subscription) and is designed for small to mid-sized businesses.

This tier includes everything from the consumer plans plus:

- **Copilot deeply integrated into business Microsoft 365** – Word, Excel, PowerPoint, Outlook, Teams, and more

- **Access to organizational data** – Copilot can search across your company's SharePoint sites, emails, Teams messages, and documents to find relevant information
- **Meeting intelligence** – Copilot can attend Teams meetings, take notes, identify action items, and generate meeting summaries
- **Business-grade security and compliance** – your data stays within your organization's Microsoft 365 tenant and is not used to train AI models
- **Admin controls** – IT administrators can manage who has access and set usage policies
- **Copilot Studio access** – basic ability to customize and extend Copilot with company-specific knowledge

The business tier is purchased and managed by your organization, not by you individually. If your company uses Microsoft 365 and is considering Copilot, this is likely the tier they would choose.

Best for: Small and mid-sized businesses that run on Microsoft 365 and want to boost team productivity.

Microsoft 365 Copilot Enterprise: The Full Package

At $30 per user per month (again, on top of an existing Microsoft 365 enterprise subscription), the Enterprise tier is the most comprehensive Copilot offering. It includes everything in the Business tier plus:

- **Enterprise-grade data protection** with the most stringent security and compliance controls
- **Microsoft 365 Graph grounding** – Copilot can reason across your entire organization's data, understanding relationships between people, documents, emails, meetings, and more
- **Advanced Copilot Studio** – full access to build custom copilots, plugins, and agents tailored to your organization's specific workflows
- **Agentic capabilities** – Copilot can take multi-step actions on behalf of users, automating complex workflows
- **Usage analytics and reporting** for administrators
- **Priority support** from Microsoft

This tier is designed for large organizations with complex needs and strict compliance requirements. If you work at a company with hundreds or thousands of employees, this is likely the version your IT department would deploy.

Best for: Large enterprises with complex data environments, strict compliance needs, and the desire to build custom AI solutions.

A Quick Word About GitHub Copilot

You may have heard about "GitHub Copilot" and wondered if it is the same thing. It is not. GitHub Copilot is a separate product designed specifically for software developers. It helps programmers write code by suggesting completions, generating functions, and explaining existing code.

GitHub Copilot has its own pricing structure with five tiers: Free, Pro ($10/month), Pro+ ($39/month for individuals), Business ($19/user/month), and Enterprise ($39/user/month). Note that Pro+ and Enterprise share the same $39 price point, but they serve different audiences – Pro+ is for individual developers who want premium features, while Enterprise is a per-user organizational plan with compliance controls, fine-tuned models, and admin management. Chapter 24 covers GitHub Copilot in detail.

Unless you are a software developer, you do not need to worry about GitHub Copilot. This book focuses on the general-purpose Microsoft Copilot that anyone can use.

How to Decide: A Practical Framework

Still not sure which plan is right for you? Walk through these questions:

Question 1: Are you just curious about AI? Start with the free tier. There is zero risk, and you will get a solid feel for what Copilot can do. You can always upgrade later.

Question 2: Do you use Microsoft 365 (Word, Excel, PowerPoint, Outlook)? If yes, and you want Copilot to work inside those apps, you need either Microsoft 365 Premium ($19.99/month) or a combination of Microsoft 365 plus Copilot Pro ($20/month). The Premium bundle is usually the simpler and more cost-effective choice for individuals.

Question 3: Do you use Copilot heavily every day? If you find yourself hitting the free tier's limits regularly – running out of daily messages, getting bumped to a less powerful model, or wanting more Think Deeper conversations – Copilot Pro is worth considering.

Question 4: Is this for your business? Talk to your IT department or Microsoft sales representative about the Business ($18-21/user/month) or Enterprise ($30/user/month) tiers. These are organizational decisions, not individual ones.

Question 5: Do you want to try before you commit? Microsoft frequently offers free trials of Copilot Pro and Microsoft 365 Premium. Check the current offers at copilot.microsoft.com before committing to a paid plan.

A Note on Plan Names and Pricing

Plan names, pricing, and feature bundles described in this chapter reflect the state of things as of early 2026. Microsoft reorganizes its consumer and business offerings regularly – sometimes renaming plans, adjusting price points, or shifting features between tiers. Before making a purchasing decision, check the current plans at copilot.microsoft.com and microsoft.com/microsoft-365.

The Bottom Line on Pricing

Here is a candid assessment. The free tier of Copilot is surprisingly good, and most casual users will be perfectly happy with it. If you use Microsoft 365 for work and want Copilot integrated into your documents and email, the Premium bundle at $19.99 per month is solid value – you are getting the full Office suite plus AI capabilities.

Copilot Pro at $20 per month is best justified if you are a heavy user who relies on AI assistance throughout the day and wants guaranteed access to the most powerful models.

The business and enterprise tiers are in a different category entirely. They are not impulse purchases – they are organizational investments. But for companies that run on Microsoft 365, the productivity gains can be substantial.

One last piece of advice: start free, use Copilot for a few weeks, and then decide if you want more. There is no penalty for starting at the bottom and working your way up.

The next chapter will walk you through setting up your account, regardless of which plan you choose.

Chapter 3: Setting Up Your Account

You have decided to give Microsoft Copilot a try – great. Now let us get you set up. This chapter walks you through the process of creating or connecting your account, installing the apps you need, and configuring Copilot so it is ready to use on every device you own.

The good news is that setup is straightforward. If you already have a Microsoft account – and you probably do, even if you do not realize it – you are already halfway there.

Do You Already Have a Microsoft Account?

Before you create anything new, check whether you already have a Microsoft account. If you have ever used any of the following, you have one:

- A Hotmail, Outlook.com, or Live.com email address
- Xbox Live or an Xbox console
- Windows with a sign-in (not a local-only account)
- Microsoft 365, OneDrive, or Skype
- A Microsoft Store purchase

If any of those ring a bell, you already have a Microsoft account. You can sign in to Copilot with those same credentials – no new account needed.

If you use a work or school computer, you likely also have a Microsoft organizational account (sometimes called a "work or school account"). This is separate from your personal Microsoft account, and it matters because Copilot's behavior and available features can differ depending on which account you use. We will cover this in more detail shortly.

Creating a New Microsoft Account

If you do not have a Microsoft account, creating one takes about two minutes:

1. Open any web browser and go to **account.microsoft.com**.
2. Click **Create a Microsoft account** (or **Sign up**).

3. You can use an existing email address (like your Gmail or Yahoo address) or create a new Outlook.com email address for free.
4. Choose a password. Make it strong – at least 12 characters with a mix of letters, numbers, and symbols.
5. Microsoft will send a verification code to your email or phone. Enter the code to confirm your account.
6. Fill in basic profile information (name, country, date of birth).
7. You are done.

That is it. You now have a Microsoft account that works with Copilot, OneDrive, Outlook.com, and every other Microsoft service.

A note about security: I strongly recommend setting up two-factor authentication on your Microsoft account right away. Go to account.microsoft.com, navigate to Security settings, and enable it. This adds a second verification step when you sign in – typically a code sent to your phone – and it dramatically reduces the risk of someone else accessing your account.

Accessing Copilot on the Web

The fastest way to start using Copilot is through your web browser:

1. Go to **copilot.microsoft.com**.
2. You will see the Copilot chat interface. You can start chatting immediately without signing in, but your conversations will not be saved.
3. Click **Sign in** in the upper right corner and enter your Microsoft account credentials.
4. Once signed in, your conversations will be saved to your account, and you will have access to all the features included in your plan.

That is literally all it takes. You can bookmark this page and come back anytime.

If you are using the free tier, you are ready to go right now. If you want to upgrade to a paid plan, look for the upgrade option in the interface – it will guide you through selecting a plan and entering payment information.

Setting Up Copilot on Windows

If you are running Windows 11, Copilot is either already installed or can be installed quickly:

On Windows 11 (version 23H2 and later):

1. Look for the Copilot icon in your taskbar – it looks like a stylized ribbon or wave shape. If you see it, click it and sign in with your Microsoft account.
2. If you do not see the icon, open the Microsoft Store (search for "Microsoft Store" in the Start menu), search for "Microsoft Copilot," and install the app.
3. Once installed, you can pin it to your taskbar for quick access. Right-click the Copilot icon in the Start menu and select **Pin to taskbar**.
4. Sign in with your Microsoft account, and you are set.

On Windows 10:

Copilot is available as a downloadable app from the Microsoft Store. Search for "Microsoft Copilot," install it, and sign in. The experience is similar to the web version, running in its own window.

Keyboard shortcut: On many Windows 11 systems, you can open Copilot quickly by pressing **Windows key + C** (though this shortcut may vary depending on your system configuration and Windows version). Check your keyboard settings if this does not work.

Setting Up Copilot in Microsoft Edge

If you use Microsoft Edge as your web browser, Copilot is built right into the sidebar:

1. Open Microsoft Edge.
2. Look for the Copilot icon in the upper right corner of the browser, near the address bar. It uses the same wave-shaped icon.
3. Click it to open the Copilot sidebar.
4. Sign in with your Microsoft account if prompted.

The Edge sidebar version of Copilot is particularly useful because it can interact with the webpage you are currently viewing. You can ask it to summarize an article, explain

something on the page, or answer questions about what you are reading – all without leaving the page.

If you do not see the Copilot icon in Edge, make sure your browser is up to date. Go to **Settings** > **About Microsoft Edge** and install any available updates.

Setting Up Copilot on Your Phone

Copilot is available as a free app for both iPhone and Android:

On iPhone or iPad: 1. Open the App Store. 2. Search for "Microsoft Copilot." 3. Download and install the app. 4. Open it and sign in with your Microsoft account.

On Android: 1. Open the Google Play Store. 2. Search for "Microsoft Copilot." 3. Download and install the app. 4. Open it and sign in with your Microsoft account.

The mobile app supports text chat, voice conversations (tap the microphone icon to talk to Copilot), and image input (use your camera to show Copilot something and ask about it). It is the same Copilot, optimized for your phone's screen.

Setting Up Copilot in Microsoft 365

If you have a Microsoft 365 subscription with Copilot capabilities (Microsoft 365 Premium, Copilot Pro added to a Microsoft 365 subscription, or a business/enterprise plan), Copilot will appear inside your Office apps:

In Word, Excel, PowerPoint, and Outlook (desktop apps):

1. Make sure your Microsoft 365 apps are up to date. Open any Office app, go to **File** > **Account** > **Update Options** > **Update Now**.
2. Sign in with the Microsoft account that has Copilot access. Go to **File** > **Account** and verify you are signed in with the correct account.
3. Look for the Copilot icon in the ribbon (the toolbar at the top of the application). In Word, it typically appears in the Home tab. In Excel, it appears in the Home tab as well.
4. Click the Copilot icon to open the Copilot pane.

If you do not see the Copilot icon, several things might be going on:

- Your apps may need updating. Microsoft 365 apps update automatically, but sometimes updates are delayed.
- You may be signed in with the wrong account. If you have both a personal and work account, make sure the account with Copilot access is the active one.
- Your subscription may not include Copilot. Double-check your subscription status at account.microsoft.com.
- If this is a work account, your IT administrator may not have enabled Copilot for your organization yet.

In the web versions of Office (Word Online, Excel Online, etc.):

1. Go to **microsoft365.com** and sign in.
2. Open any document in Word Online, Excel Online, or PowerPoint Online.
3. Look for the Copilot icon in the toolbar. It works the same way as in the desktop apps.

In Microsoft Teams:

1. Open Teams (desktop app or web version).
2. Look for the Copilot icon in the left sidebar or in the chat area.
3. During meetings, Copilot can be activated to transcribe and summarize the discussion. Look for the Copilot option in the meeting controls.

Configuring Your Preferences

Once you are signed in, take a few minutes to configure Copilot to work the way you want:

Conversation history. By default, Copilot saves your conversations so you can return to them later. You can manage your history by clicking on your profile icon and looking for conversation history or privacy settings. If you prefer not to have conversations saved, you can disable this.

Search personalization. Copilot uses Bing for web searches, and it can personalize results based on your location and search history. You can adjust this in the settings – decide whether you want personalized results or prefer more generic responses.

Tone and style. While you cannot set a permanent tone preference, you will learn in later chapters how to guide Copilot's communication style through your prompts.

Notifications. If you are using Copilot in Microsoft 365, you can configure whether Copilot proactively suggests things (like email replies in Outlook) or waits for you to ask.

Personal Account vs. Work Account: What Is the Difference?

This is a common source of confusion, so let us clear it up.

Personal Microsoft account (the one you use for Outlook.com, Xbox, or personal Microsoft 365): When you use Copilot with this account, you get the consumer version. Your conversations are private to you. The features available depend on your personal subscription level (free, Premium, or Pro).

Work or school account (the one your employer or school gave you, typically ending in your organization's domain): When you use Copilot with this account, you get the business or enterprise version. Copilot can access your organization's data – emails, files in SharePoint, Teams conversations – which makes it more powerful in a work context. However, your IT administrator controls what Copilot can access and what features are available.

You can switch between accounts in most Copilot interfaces. Look for your profile icon or avatar and click it to see account-switching options. Some people use Copilot with both accounts – their personal account for personal tasks and their work account for professional tasks.

Troubleshooting Common Setup Issues

Here are solutions to the most common problems people encounter during setup:

"I cannot sign in." Make sure you are using the correct email address and password. If you have forgotten your password, click "Forgot password" and follow the recovery steps. If you have two-factor authentication enabled, make sure you have access to your authentication method (phone, authenticator app, etc.).

"Copilot is not available in my country." As of 2026, Copilot is available in most countries, but some features may be limited in certain regions. Check Microsoft's official documentation for the most current availability information.

"I signed in but I do not see premium features." Make sure your subscription is active. Go to account.microsoft.com and check your subscriptions page. If you just subscribed, try signing out and back in – sometimes it takes a few minutes for the subscription to activate.

"Copilot in Word/Excel is not showing up." Update your Microsoft 365 apps, verify you are signed in with the correct account, and make sure your subscription includes Copilot. If this is a work account, contact your IT administrator.

"The mobile app is not working." Make sure your phone's operating system is up to date, and check that you have a stable internet connection. Copilot requires an internet connection to work – it does not function offline.

A Quick Security Checklist

Before you start using Copilot regularly, take care of these security basics:

1. **Enable two-factor authentication** on your Microsoft account.
2. **Use a strong, unique password** – not one you use for other services.
3. **Be cautious about what you share.** Do not paste passwords, social security numbers, credit card numbers, or other highly sensitive information into Copilot conversations.
4. **Review your privacy settings.** Visit your Microsoft privacy dashboard at account.microsoft.com/privacy to see what data Microsoft collects and adjust your preferences.
5. **Log out on shared computers.** If you use Copilot on a public or shared computer, always sign out when you are done.

You Are Ready to Go

At this point, you should have Copilot set up on at least one device and be signed in with your Microsoft account. If you have a paid subscription, you should also have access to the premium features included in your plan.

In the next chapter, we will look under the hood at the different AI models and conversation modes that power Copilot. Understanding these will help you get better results from every interaction – you will know when to use the quick, snappy mode versus when to engage Copilot's deep reasoning capabilities.

Chapter 4: Understanding Copilot's Models and Modes

Now that you have Copilot set up, you might be tempted to jump right in and start chatting. And you absolutely can – Copilot works great right out of the box. But taking a few minutes to understand what is happening behind the scenes will make you a much more effective user. Knowing which model is handling your request and which conversation mode to choose is the difference between getting a decent answer and getting a great one.

This chapter explains the AI models that power Copilot, the three conversation modes you can choose from, and when to use each one. Think of it as learning how to shift gears before you start driving.

What Are AI Models, and Why Do They Matter?

When you send a message to Copilot, your words are processed by an AI model – a piece of software that has been trained on enormous amounts of text to understand and generate human language. The model reads your input, figures out what you are asking, and generates a response.

Not all models are created equal. Some are smaller and faster, optimized for quick responses. Others are larger and more powerful, capable of more nuanced reasoning but slower to respond. Microsoft uses several different models from OpenAI's GPT-5 family, and understanding the differences helps you get the best results.

GPT-5.2: The Everyday Workhorse

GPT-5.2 is the baseline model in the GPT-5 family. It is highly capable – far more advanced than the models that powered the first versions of Copilot in 2023 – and it handles the vast majority of tasks with ease. When you ask Copilot a straightforward question, draft a quick email, or brainstorm ideas, GPT-5.2 is likely doing the work.

This model is fast. Responses come back in seconds, and for most everyday tasks, the quality is excellent. Think of GPT-5.2 as the reliable everyday car that gets you where you need to go comfortably and efficiently.

GPT-5.4: The Premium Engine

GPT-5.4 is the more powerful sibling. It brings improvements in reasoning, accuracy, nuance, and the ability to handle complex instructions. When a task requires more sophistication – writing a detailed analysis, handling a multi-part question, working with complex data, or producing polished creative writing – GPT-5.4 excels.

If you are on a paid plan, Copilot will use GPT-5.4 more frequently, and you will get priority access to it during busy periods. Free users may be served GPT-5.2 when demand is high to ensure everyone can access the service.

GPT-5.4 Thinking: The Deep Reasoner

GPT-5.4 Thinking is a specialized variant designed for extended reasoning. Instead of generating a quick response, this model "thinks" through problems step by step before answering. It takes longer – sometimes 30 seconds or more – but the quality of reasoning is substantially better for complex tasks.

This is the model behind Copilot's "Think Deeper" mode, which we will cover shortly. It is particularly valuable for:

- Math and logic problems
- Multi-step planning
- Complex analysis and comparison
- Technical problem-solving
- Any question where a thoughtful, carefully reasoned answer is more important than a fast one

You can think of GPT-5.4 Thinking as the specialist you bring in when the stakes are high and you want someone to really think it through.

The Three Conversation Modes

Copilot offers three conversation modes that you can select before or during a conversation. Each mode tells Copilot how to approach your request. Here is what they are and when to use each one.

Auto Mode: Let Copilot Decide

Auto is the default mode, and for most people most of the time, it is the right choice. When you use Auto mode, Copilot analyzes your message and decides on its own how to handle it. Simple questions get quick responses. Complex questions get more thoughtful treatment. Copilot decides whether to search the web, which model to use, and how much reasoning to apply.

When to use Auto mode: - Most of the time - When you are not sure which mode would be best - When your requests vary in complexity throughout a conversation - When you want Copilot to "just figure it out"

Auto mode is smart about adapting. If you ask, "What time is it in Tokyo?" it will give you a quick answer. If you follow up with, "Help me plan a two-week itinerary for Japan with a mix of cultural sites and nature experiences," it will shift to a more thoughtful approach. You do not have to manage the gears – Copilot does it for you.

Quick Response Mode: Speed Over Depth

Quick Response mode prioritizes speed. It tells Copilot to get you an answer as fast as possible, without spending extra time on reasoning or searching. Responses are shorter, more direct, and arrive almost instantly.

When to use Quick Response mode: - Simple factual questions: "What year was the Eiffel Tower built?" - Quick translations: "How do you say 'thank you' in Japanese?" - Basic calculations: "What is 15% of 340?" - Simple definitions: "What is photosynthesis?" - When you want a fast answer and do not need depth or nuance - When you are in a hurry and a "good enough" answer is fine

When not to use Quick Response mode: - Complex questions that require analysis - Tasks where accuracy is critical - Creative writing where quality matters - Multi-step problems

Think of Quick Response as the express lane at the grocery store. It is faster, but it is designed for small, simple transactions.

Think Deeper Mode: Maximum Reasoning Power

Think Deeper mode is the opposite of Quick Response. It engages GPT-5.4 Thinking, the extended reasoning model, and tells Copilot to take its time and really work through your request carefully. You will see a "thinking" indicator while Copilot processes, and responses can take 30 seconds to a minute or more.

The results, however, are noticeably better for the right kinds of tasks.

When to use Think Deeper mode: - Complex analytical questions: "Compare the economic policies of these three countries and analyze which approach would work best for a small island nation." - Math and logic problems: "Walk me through this statistics problem step by step." - Strategic planning: "I am starting a small bakery. Help me think through the financial considerations for my first year." - Debugging arguments: "Here is my business proposal. What are the weaknesses in my reasoning?" - Legal or technical document analysis: "Review this contract clause and explain what it means in plain language." - Any time you want Copilot to think carefully rather than respond quickly

When Think Deeper is overkill: - Simple questions with straightforward answers - Quick tasks like drafting a short email - Casual conversation or brainstorming where speed matters more than depth

Think Deeper is like asking someone to sit down, take out a notepad, and really work through a problem instead of giving you an off-the-cuff answer. The answer takes longer, but it is more thorough and more reliable.

A note on availability: Think Deeper mode uses significantly more computational resources than the other modes. On the free plan, you have a limited number of Think Deeper queries per day. Paid plans offer more generous allowances, with Copilot Pro users getting the highest limits.

How to Switch Between Modes

Switching modes is simple:

On the web (copilot.microsoft.com): Look for the mode selector near the text input area, usually displayed as a dropdown or a set of buttons. Click to switch between Auto, Quick Response, and Think Deeper.

On the Windows app: Same approach – look for the mode selector near where you type your messages.

On mobile: The mode selector is typically accessible via an icon near the text input field. Tap it to see your options.

Mid-conversation: You can switch modes at any point during a conversation. If you start in Auto mode and realize you need deeper reasoning, switch to Think Deeper for your next message. The conversation context is preserved.

Choosing the Right Mode: A Decision Framework

Here is a simple framework for choosing the right mode:

1. **Start with Auto.** It handles most situations well and adapts automatically.
2. **Switch to Quick Response** when you need fast, simple answers and do not want to wait.
3. **Switch to Think Deeper** when accuracy, thoroughness, or careful reasoning matters more than speed.

Over time, you will develop an intuition for which mode fits which situation. Do not overthink it – the difference between modes is real but not dramatic for most everyday tasks. The biggest gains from Think Deeper come on genuinely complex problems.

How Web Search Grounding Works

Regardless of which mode you use, Copilot has the ability to search the web using Bing. This is called "search grounding," and it is one of Copilot's most important features.

When you ask a question that benefits from current information – news, prices, weather, recent events, factual data – Copilot will automatically search the web, read through relevant results, and incorporate that information into its response. It will also provide citations – numbered references that link to the sources it used – so you can verify the information yourself.

This is a big deal. Without web search, AI models can only draw on what they learned during training, which means they can be out of date or lack specific factual information. With web search grounding, Copilot can give you current, verifiable information.

You do not need to tell Copilot to search the web. In Auto mode, it decides automatically whether a web search would be helpful. But you can explicitly ask it to search: "Search the web for the latest reviews of the Samsung Galaxy S26" or "What does the New York Times say about the new climate bill?"

When Copilot uses web search, you will typically see numbered citations in its response, like [1], [2], [3]. Click or tap these to see the source URLs. Always check sources when accuracy matters.

Pages: The Collaborative AI Canvas

If you have a paid plan, you have access to Pages – a feature that takes AI conversations beyond the chat format. A Page is like a document that you and Copilot create together. Instead of a back-and-forth chat, you get an editable canvas where Copilot's output appears as formatted text that you can edit, rearrange, and build upon.

Pages are particularly useful for:

- Longer writing projects where you want to iterate on a document
- Research summaries that you want to organize and refine
- Planning documents where you want to keep adding sections
- Collaborative work where you want to share the output with others

Think of Pages as a bridge between a chat conversation and a real document. You get the AI assistance of a chat but the editability and structure of a word processor.

Notebooks: Extended Context

Notebooks are another feature available on paid plans that let you work with longer inputs. In a standard chat, there are limits on how much text you can include in a single message. Notebooks extend that limit significantly, allowing you to paste in longer documents, articles, or data sets and ask Copilot to work with them.

If you need to analyze a lengthy report, summarize a long article, or work with a large amount of text, Notebooks are the right tool.

Putting It All Together

Here is a practical example of how understanding models and modes makes you more effective:

Imagine you are researching a major purchase – say, a new car. You might start in Auto mode and ask, "What are the most reliable midsize SUVs in 2026?" Copilot searches the web and gives you a solid overview with citations.

Then you want more detail. You switch to Think Deeper and ask, "Compare the Toyota RAV4, Honda CR-V, and Mazda CX-50. Consider reliability, resale value, fuel efficiency, technology features, and total cost of ownership over five years. Which one is the best value?"

Copilot takes a minute to think it through and gives you a detailed, well-reasoned comparison. You notice it cites several automotive review sites and consumer reports.

Later, you want a quick fact: "What is the cargo space of the RAV4 in cubic feet?" You switch to Quick Response and get your answer in two seconds.

Same conversation, three different modes, each one appropriate for the task at hand. That is how understanding models and modes makes you a more effective Copilot user.

What You Will Learn Next

Now that you understand the engine under the hood, it is time to start driving. In Chapter 5, we will have your first real conversations with Copilot. You will learn how to write effective prompts, how to refine Copilot's responses, and how to develop the back-and-forth dialogue that gets you the best results. This is where Copilot goes from interesting to genuinely useful.

Chapter 5: Your First Conversations

You are set up, you understand the different modes, and you are ready to start talking to Copilot. This is where things get fun. But there is a skill to having productive conversations with an AI assistant, and learning that skill early will save you frustration and help you get dramatically better results.

This chapter teaches you how to write effective prompts, how to refine responses, and how to develop the back-and-forth dialogue that turns Copilot from a novelty into a genuinely useful tool.

Your Very First Message

Let us start simple. Open Copilot on whatever device you prefer – the website, the Windows app, the mobile app, or the Edge sidebar. Make sure you are signed in, and type something like:

> What can you help me with?

Copilot will respond with an overview of its capabilities. This is a perfectly fine way to start, but it is also a bit like walking into a restaurant and asking, "What do you serve?" You will get a general answer, but you would get better results by looking at the menu and ordering something specific.

So let us try something more concrete:

> I need to write a thank-you note to my neighbor who watched my dog while I was on vacation. She has two cats and was a little nervous about watching a large dog. Make it warm and genuine.

Now Copilot has something to work with. It knows the purpose (thank-you note), the context (dog-sitting, neighbor has cats, was nervous), and the tone (warm, genuine). It will generate a note that you can use as-is or modify to fit your voice.

That is the fundamental pattern: give Copilot enough context to produce something useful on the first try.

The Anatomy of a Good Prompt

A "prompt" is simply the message you send to Copilot. The quality of your prompt directly affects the quality of the response. Here is what makes a prompt effective:

Be Specific About What You Want

Vague prompts get vague responses. Compare these:

Vague: "Tell me about dogs." **Specific:** "What are the best dog breeds for families with young children who live in apartments? I want a breed that is good with kids, does not need a huge yard, and does not shed excessively."

The second prompt gives Copilot clear criteria to work with. The response will be focused, practical, and immediately useful.

Provide Context

Copilot does not know your situation unless you tell it. The more relevant context you provide, the better the response:

Without context: "Help me write an email." **With context:** "Help me write an email to my team of six people announcing that we are switching from Slack to Microsoft Teams. Some people will be resistant to the change. I want to acknowledge their concerns while explaining the benefits. Keep the tone professional but empathetic."

Specify the Format

If you want your response in a particular format, say so:

- "Give me a bulleted list of..."
- "Explain this in three short paragraphs."
- "Create a table comparing..."
- "Write this as a step-by-step guide with numbered instructions."
- "Summarize this in two sentences."

Specify the Tone

Copilot can adapt its writing style to suit your needs:

- "Write this in a casual, conversational tone."
- "Keep it formal and professional."
- "Make it friendly but not too informal."
- "Write it as if you are explaining to a five-year-old."
- "Use an academic tone with precise language."

Specify the Audience

Who is this for? Telling Copilot the intended audience helps it calibrate complexity, vocabulary, and tone:

- "Explain this for someone with no technical background."
- "Write this for experienced project managers."
- "My audience is high school students."
- "This is for a board of directors presentation."

The Power of Follow-Up Messages

Here is something many people miss when they first start using AI: the conversation does not end with Copilot's first response. In fact, the first response is often just the starting point.

Copilot remembers everything that has been said in the current conversation. You can build on previous messages, ask for changes, and refine the output through follow-up messages. This is called "iterating," and it is one of the most powerful techniques you can learn.

Here is an example of how iteration works:

You: "Write a short bio for me. I am a marketing manager with 12 years of experience, I specialize in digital marketing and brand strategy, and I have an MBA from the University of Michigan."

Copilot: *[Generates a professional bio]*

You: "Good start, but make it warmer and less corporate. Add that I am passionate about mentoring junior marketers and that I volunteer as a marketing consultant for local nonprofits."

Copilot: *[Revises the bio with a warmer tone and the additional details]*

You: "Perfect. Now create a shorter version of this – just two to three sentences – that I can use for a conference speaker introduction."

Copilot: *[Creates a condensed version]*

You: "Great. Now make an even shorter version for my X (formerly Twitter) bio. Under 160 characters."

Copilot: *[Creates an ultra-short version]*

Notice what happened. You started with a general request, then refined it through four messages. Each version built on the last. You did not have to re-explain your background each time – Copilot remembered the context. This is how experienced users work with Copilot.

Common Follow-Up Phrases That Work Well

Keep these phrases in your back pocket. They are incredibly useful for refining Copilot's responses:

- **"Make it shorter." / "Make it longer."**
- **"Make it more formal." / "Make it more casual."**
- **"Can you simplify this?"**
- **"Add more detail about [specific topic]."**
- **"Remove the part about [specific thing]."**
- **"Rewrite this as bullet points." / "Rewrite this as a narrative."**
- **"Give me three alternative versions."**
- **"What did you mean by [specific phrase]?"**
- **"Can you give me an example?"**
- **"That is not quite what I meant. I was looking for [clarification]."**

- **"Keep everything the same but change the tone to be more [adjective]."**

Starting a New Conversation

Each conversation with Copilot is independent. When you start a new conversation (by clicking "New chat" or the equivalent), Copilot starts fresh with no memory of previous conversations.

This is important to understand. If you had a great conversation yesterday about planning a trip to Italy, and you start a new chat today and say, "Tell me more about the hotels," Copilot will have no idea what you are talking about. You would need to re-establish the context.

When to start a new conversation: - When you are switching to a completely different topic - When the current conversation has gotten long and Copilot seems to be losing track of earlier details - When you want a fresh perspective without the influence of previous messages

When to continue an existing conversation: - When you are still working on the same topic or task - When you want to build on something Copilot already generated - When you need Copilot to remember context from earlier in the discussion

Asking Questions Effectively

Copilot excels at answering questions, but the way you ask matters. Here are some patterns that consistently produce good results:

The "Explain Like I Am a Beginner" Pattern

> "Explain how blockchain works. Assume I have no technical background."

This tells Copilot to avoid jargon and use simple analogies.

The "Compare and Contrast" Pattern

> "Compare renting versus buying a home. Include financial considerations, lifestyle factors, and long-term implications. Present this as a pros and cons list for each option."

This produces structured, balanced analysis.

The "Devil's Advocate" Pattern

> "I am thinking about quitting my job to start a freelance business. Give me the strongest arguments against doing this."

This is great for stress-testing decisions. Copilot will not just tell you what you want to hear.

The "Step-by-Step" Pattern

> "Walk me through how to set up a monthly household budget, step by step. I have never done this before."

This produces clear, sequential instructions.

The "Summarize This" Pattern

You can paste a long article, email thread, or document into the chat and ask:

> "Summarize the key points of this article in five bullet points."

This is one of Copilot's most practically useful capabilities.

What to Do When Copilot Gets It Wrong

Copilot will sometimes give you incorrect information, misunderstand your question, or produce something that is not quite what you wanted. This is normal. Here is how to handle it:

Correct it directly. If Copilot makes a factual error, just tell it:

> "That is not right. The Battle of Gettysburg was in 1863, not 1864. Please correct your response."

Copilot will acknowledge the correction and adjust.

Clarify your intent. If the response is off-base, the problem might be ambiguity in your original prompt:

> "I think you misunderstood my question. I was not asking about the history of the company. I wanted to know about their current product lineup."

Ask it to try again. Sometimes the simplest approach is the best:

> "That response was not quite what I was looking for. Can you try again with a different approach?"

Check the sources. When Copilot cites web sources (those numbered references like [1], [2]), click through to verify. If the sources do not support what Copilot said, let it know.

Know when to be skeptical. Be especially cautious with: - Specific numbers, statistics, and dates - Legal, medical, or financial advice - Claims about specific people or organizations - Anything that sounds too specific to be generated from general knowledge

Working with Files and Images

Copilot can work with files and images you share with it. You can:

Upload an image and ask about it: > "What kind of plant is this?" (with a photo attached) > "Can you read the text in this screenshot?" > "What is wrong with the layout of this design?"

Paste text from a document: Copy text from any source – a PDF, a website, a Word document – and paste it into the chat along with your question.

Upload a file directly: In most Copilot interfaces, you can click an attachment icon to upload a file. Copilot can read and analyze documents, spreadsheets, and other file types.

Practical Exercises to Build Your Skills

The best way to get comfortable with Copilot is to practice. Here are five exercises to try right now:

Exercise 1: Simple Question Ask Copilot something you have been curious about. Notice how it provides context and nuance beyond a simple factual answer.

Exercise 2: Write Something Ask Copilot to draft something you actually need – an email, a social media post, a message to a friend. Then use follow-up messages to refine it until it sounds like you.

Exercise 3: Explain a Concept Pick something you have always found confusing – insurance deductibles, how Wi-Fi works, the difference between a Roth and traditional IRA – and ask Copilot to explain it in simple terms.

Exercise 4: Summarize Something Find a long article online, copy the text, paste it into Copilot, and ask for a summary. Compare the summary to the original and notice how well it captures the key points.

Exercise 5: Iterate Ask Copilot to write a short paragraph about your hometown. Then spend five follow-up messages refining it – change the tone, add details, make it shorter, change the audience. This exercise will teach you the power of iteration.

A Note on Privacy in Conversations

Everything you type to Copilot is sent to Microsoft's servers for processing. While Microsoft has privacy protections in place, you should be thoughtful about what you share:

- Do not share passwords, social security numbers, or financial account numbers.
- Be cautious with confidential business information unless you are using an enterprise plan with data protection guarantees.
- Remember that your conversations may be stored (check your privacy settings if this concerns you).
- If you are using a work account, your organization's data policies apply.

What You Will Learn Next

You now have the foundational skills to have productive conversations with Copilot. In the next chapter, we will focus on one of the most common and valuable use cases: writing. Whether you need emails, reports, creative content, or anything else involving words on a page, Chapter 6 will show you how to use Copilot as your personal writing assistant.

Chapter 6: Writing with Copilot

If there is one thing that Copilot does exceptionally well, it is writing. Whether you need to dash off a quick email, draft a formal report, compose a heartfelt letter, or create content for a website, Copilot can help you write faster, more clearly, and with less stress.

This chapter covers how to use Copilot for all kinds of writing tasks – from everyday communication to polished professional documents. You will learn techniques for getting great first drafts, refining tone and style, overcoming writer's block, and using Copilot inside Word for those who have Microsoft 365 integration.

Why Copilot Is a Great Writing Partner

Let us be honest: writing is hard for most people. Not because they lack ideas, but because turning ideas into clear, well-organized text takes time and effort. This is exactly where Copilot excels.

Copilot can generate a solid first draft in seconds. That draft might not be perfect – you will almost always want to revise and personalize it – but it gives you something to work with instead of a blank page. And that is enormous. The hardest part of writing is often getting started. Copilot removes that barrier completely.

Beyond first drafts, Copilot can also edit your existing writing, suggest improvements, change the tone, restructure arguments, fix grammar, and help you say what you mean more clearly. Think of it as having a patient, always-available writing coach.

Everyday Email

Email is probably the most common writing task for most people, and it is where Copilot can save you the most time on a daily basis.

Drafting Emails from Scratch

Tell Copilot who you are writing to, what you need to communicate, and what tone you want:

> "Write a professional email to my colleague Sarah asking if she can cover my shift on Friday. I have a doctor's appointment I cannot reschedule. Keep it friendly and brief."

Copilot will produce a ready-to-send email. Review it, tweak anything that does not sound like you, and send it.

For more complex emails:

> "Write an email to my client, David Chen at Meridian Corp, following up on our meeting last Tuesday. We discussed three options for their website redesign. Remind him of the options (basic refresh, full redesign, and phased approach), and recommend the phased approach because it balances cost and impact. Ask him to schedule a follow-up call next week. Professional but warm tone."

The more context you provide, the better the draft. Notice how specifying the recipient, the background, the content, the recommendation, and the tone gives Copilot everything it needs.

Improving Emails You Have Already Written

You can also paste in an email you have drafted and ask Copilot to improve it:

> "Here is an email I wrote. Can you make it more concise and professional? [paste your email]"

Or:

> "This email sounds too aggressive. Can you soften the tone while keeping the same message? [paste your email]"

Handling Difficult Emails

Some emails are genuinely hard to write – delivering bad news, addressing a complaint, navigating a sensitive situation. Copilot is surprisingly good at these:

> "I need to email a client to let them know their project will be delivered two weeks late due to supply chain issues. I want to be honest and apologetic without making excuses. Offer a 10% discount on their next order as a goodwill gesture."

Copilot will handle the delicate balance of honesty, accountability, and customer retention.

Professional Documents

Reports and Memos

For longer professional documents, give Copilot an outline of what you need:

> "Write a one-page memo to the leadership team summarizing last quarter's sales performance. Key points: total revenue was $2.4 million (up 12% from last year), our strongest product line was the Pro series (45% of revenue), customer retention improved to 87%, and our main challenge was slow growth in the enterprise segment. Include a brief recommendation section suggesting we hire a dedicated enterprise sales rep."

Proposals and Pitches

> "Draft a project proposal for implementing a new customer feedback system. We are a mid-sized e-commerce company with about 50,000 orders per month. The proposal should cover the problem (we currently have no systematic way to collect customer feedback), the proposed solution (implementing a post-purchase survey system), expected benefits, estimated timeline of three months, and rough budget of $25,000-$35,000."

Resumes and Cover Letters

Copilot is excellent at resume and cover letter writing because it can tailor the content to specific job postings:

> "Write a cover letter for a marketing coordinator position at Nike. Here is my background: five years of experience in digital marketing, strong skills in social media management and content creation, Bachelor's degree in Communications from Oregon State, previously worked at a small athletic apparel startup. Here is the job posting: [paste job posting]"

By providing both your background and the actual job posting, Copilot can highlight the most relevant aspects of your experience and match the language and priorities of the employer.

Creative Writing

Copilot is not just for professional communication. It can also help with creative writing projects.

Getting Started with Creative Writing

If you are working on a story, poem, or creative project, Copilot can help you brainstorm, outline, and draft:

> "I want to write a short story about an elderly woman who discovers that her local library is closing. She decides to fight to keep it open. Give me a basic plot outline with five scenes."

Or:

> "Write the opening paragraph of a mystery novel set in a small coastal town in Maine during winter. Make the atmosphere eerie and the prose literary."

Overcoming Writer's Block

This is one of Copilot's most valuable creative applications. When you are stuck, try:

> "I am writing an essay about the importance of public libraries, and I have hit a wall after my second paragraph. Here is what I have so far: [paste your text]. Can you suggest three different ways I could continue from here?"

Copilot will give you options. You do not have to use any of them exactly – they are springboards to get your own ideas flowing again.

Poetry and Verse

> "Write a poem about the changing of seasons, focusing on the transition from autumn to winter. Use vivid imagery and a reflective tone. Free verse, about 16 lines."

You can then refine: "I love the imagery in the first stanza, but the ending feels too abrupt. Can you expand the final four lines?"

Editing and Refining Your Own Writing

One of the most practical uses of Copilot is improving text you have already written. This is different from having Copilot write from scratch – you are starting with your own words and using Copilot to polish them.

Grammar and Clarity

> "Edit this paragraph for grammar, clarity, and flow. Keep my voice and style, but fix any errors and make the writing cleaner: [paste your text]"

Tone Adjustment

> "Rewrite this email to sound more confident and assertive. Right now it sounds too apologetic: [paste your text]"

Simplification

> "This paragraph is too complex. Simplify the language so that a general audience can understand it without losing the key information: [paste your text]"

Structural Feedback

> "Here is the outline for my presentation. Does the flow make sense? Are there any gaps in the logic? Suggest improvements: [paste outline]"

Writing in Copilot for Word

If you have a Microsoft 365 subscription with Copilot, the writing experience gets even better because Copilot works directly inside Word.

Drafting in Word

When you open a new Word document, you will see an option to "Draft with Copilot" (it usually appears as a prompt at the top of the blank document or accessible via the Copilot button in the ribbon). Click it and describe what you want:

> "Write a two-page employee handbook section on our work-from-home policy. Include eligibility, equipment, expectations, and communication requirements."

Copilot generates the content directly in your document. You can keep it, discard it, or regenerate it.

Rewriting Sections

Select any text in your Word document, and you can ask Copilot to rewrite it. Right-click or use the Copilot button and choose "Rewrite." Copilot will offer alternative versions that you can accept, reject, or cycle through.

Summarizing Documents

Open a long document in Word and ask Copilot to summarize it:

> "Summarize this document in five key bullet points."

This is invaluable when you receive a long report and need to quickly understand the main points.

Changing Tone Across a Document

> "Make this entire document sound more professional and less casual."

Copilot will revise the language throughout.

Generating Content from References

If you have a reference document – like meeting notes or research data – you can tell Copilot to use it:

> "Using the meeting notes in this document, draft a follow-up email summarizing the decisions made and the action items assigned."

Tips for Better Writing Results

After spending time working with Copilot on writing tasks, here are the patterns that consistently produce the best results:

Give examples of what you like. If you have a sample of the writing style you want, share it:

> "Here is an example of the writing style I want: [paste example]. Now write a blog post about sustainable gardening in that same style."

Specify length. Copilot defaults to medium-length responses. If you want something specific, say so:

> "Write this in exactly 150 words." "Keep this under three paragraphs." "Make this a detailed, comprehensive guide of about 1,000 words."

Iterate aggressively. Your first prompt will rarely produce a perfect result. Plan to spend two or three follow-up messages refining the output. This is normal and efficient.

Use Copilot for structure, then add your voice. A great workflow is to have Copilot generate the structure and key points, then go through and add your personal touches, anecdotes, and voice. This combines AI efficiency with human authenticity.

Do not accept the first draft blindly. Always read what Copilot produces. Look for factual claims that need verification, language that does not sound like you, and sections that need more or less detail.

What Copilot Cannot Do (Yet) in Writing

A few honest limitations:

- **It does not know your personal voice perfectly.** It can mimic styles you describe, but it will not automatically sound like you. You will need to provide guidance and make edits.
- **It can produce generic content.** If your prompt is generic, the output will be too. The more specific and detailed your instructions, the more distinctive the result.
- **Long-form writing requires multiple rounds.** Copilot handles individual sections well, but writing an entire book or lengthy report in one prompt will not produce great results. Work section by section.
- **Creative writing can feel formulaic.** Copilot is good at competent creative writing, but truly original, distinctive literary prose still requires a human touch. Use it as a starting point, not a finishing point.

A Practical Workflow

Here is a workflow that many productive Copilot users follow for writing tasks:

1. **Start with Copilot.** Describe what you need and get a first draft.
2. **Evaluate.** Read the draft critically. What works? What does not?
3. **Refine with follow-ups.** Use two or three follow-up messages to adjust tone, length, detail, and structure.
4. **Copy and personalize.** Copy the result into your final destination (email, document, website) and make personal adjustments.
5. **Proofread.** Give it a final read. You are responsible for everything that goes out under your name.

What You Will Learn Next

Writing is just one side of the coin. The other is understanding the world around you – researching topics, learning new skills, and making sense of information. In Chapter 7, we will explore how to use Copilot as a research and learning tool, turning it into your personal tutor, analyst, and fact-finder.

Chapter 7: Research and Learning

One of the most transformative ways to use Microsoft Copilot is as a research and learning tool. Traditional research means opening multiple browser tabs, scanning through articles, trying to figure out which sources are reliable, and piecing together an understanding from fragments of information. Copilot does not eliminate that process entirely, but it makes it dramatically faster and more efficient.

In this chapter, you will learn how to use Copilot to research topics, learn new skills, understand complex subjects, and verify the information you receive. Whether you are a student working on a paper, a professional staying current in your field, or simply a curious person who wants to understand the world better, these techniques will serve you well.

Copilot as a Research Assistant

Think of Copilot not as a search engine, but as a research assistant. A search engine gives you links. A research assistant reads those links, synthesizes the information, and gives you a clear summary with the key points highlighted. That is what Copilot does when it combines its trained knowledge with real-time web search.

Here is a basic research workflow:

Step 1: Ask a Broad Question

Start with a general question to get an overview:

> "What is the current state of electric vehicle adoption in the United States? Give me an overview of market share, growth trends, and the major challenges."

Copilot will search the web, pull in recent data, and give you a synthesized overview with citations.

Step 2: Drill Down Into Specifics

Once you have the big picture, ask follow-up questions to explore areas that interest you:

> "Tell me more about the charging infrastructure challenge. How many public charging stations are there, and how does that compare to what is needed?"
>
> "Which states are leading in EV adoption, and what policies are driving their success?"
>
> "What are the most common consumer objections to buying an electric vehicle?"

Step 3: Get Multiple Perspectives

Good research considers different viewpoints:

> "What do critics of rapid EV adoption argue? What are the strongest counterarguments to aggressive EV mandates?"
>
> "How does the environmental case for EVs look when you factor in battery manufacturing and electricity generation from fossil fuels?"

Step 4: Summarize and Organize

Once you have gathered enough information:

> "Based on our conversation, create a structured summary of the key findings about EV adoption in the US. Organize it by: current state, growth drivers, major challenges, and outlook for the next five years. Include the most important statistics."

This gives you a clean, organized document that captures your research.

Learning New Concepts

Copilot is an exceptionally patient teacher. Unlike a human tutor, it never gets frustrated, it can explain things in multiple ways, and it is available at two in the morning when you suddenly want to understand how the stock market works.

The “Explain It Simply” Approach

When you encounter a concept you do not understand, start with a simple explanation:

> “Explain compound interest like I am a complete beginner. Use a real-world example with specific numbers.”

If the explanation is still too complex, just say so:

> “That is still a little confusing. Can you break it down even further and use a more basic example?”

Copilot will adjust. Keep asking until it clicks.

The “Build Up My Understanding” Approach

For complex topics, ask Copilot to start simple and gradually increase complexity:

> “I want to understand how machine learning works. Start with the absolute basics – assume I know nothing about AI or programming – and then gradually build up to more technical concepts. Start with part one.”

After Copilot gives you the first part:

> “That made sense. Give me part two, building on what you just explained.”

This layered approach is much more effective than trying to understand everything at once.

The “Analogy” Approach

Analogies are powerful learning tools, and Copilot is good at generating them:

> “Explain how encryption works using an analogy from everyday life.”
>
> “I do not understand the difference between a recession and a depression. Can you explain it using a simple analogy?”

If the first analogy does not resonate, ask for a different one:

> “That analogy does not quite click for me. Can you try a different comparison?”

The "Quiz Me" Approach

Active learning – where you test yourself rather than passively reading – is one of the most effective study techniques. Copilot can help:

> "I have been studying the American Civil War. Quiz me on the major battles, key figures, and causes. Ask me one question at a time and tell me if I get it right."

Copilot will ask questions, evaluate your answers, and provide explanations when you get something wrong. This is surprisingly effective for studying.

Researching Products and Purchases

Making a major purchase – a car, a laptop, a home appliance – usually involves hours of research. Copilot can compress that research significantly.

The Comparison Approach

> "I am looking for a laptop for college. My budget is $800 to $1,200. I need it for writing papers, browsing the web, light photo editing, and occasional video calls. No gaming. Compare the top three options available right now with pros and cons for each."

The Decision Framework Approach

> "I am trying to decide between buying and leasing a car. My situation: I drive about 12,000 miles per year, I keep cars for about five years, and my budget is around $400 per month. Walk me through the financial comparison and tell me which option makes more sense."

The "What Should I Ask" Approach

When you are about to make a purchase but are not sure what factors to consider:

> "I am buying my first home. What are the ten most important questions I should ask my real estate agent and what should I look for during a home inspection?"

This is incredibly useful because it helps you identify what you do not know – the questions you did not know to ask.

Verifying Information: The Critical Skill

This is perhaps the most important section in this chapter. Copilot is a powerful research tool, but it is not infallible. Learning to verify information is essential.

Check the Citations

When Copilot provides information grounded in web search, it includes numbered citations. Always click through to the sources, especially for:

- Statistics and specific numbers
- Claims about organizations, people, or policies
- Medical or legal information
- Financial data
- Anything you plan to rely on for an important decision

Cross-Reference Important Claims

For anything that matters, ask Copilot to find multiple sources:

> "You mentioned that the average cost of a wedding in the US is $35,000. Can you find two or three additional sources that confirm or contradict that number?"

Ask Copilot About Its Confidence

You can directly ask Copilot how confident it is:

> "How confident are you in this answer? Are there any aspects where the information might be outdated or uncertain?"

Copilot will often give you an honest assessment of where its knowledge might be limited.

Watch for Hallucination Red Flags

"Hallucination" is when an AI generates information that sounds plausible but is simply not true. Here are warning signs to watch for:

- **Very specific statistics without citations.** If Copilot gives you a precise number like "42.7% of Americans…" but does not cite a source, be cautious.
- **Detailed claims about specific people.** AI models can sometimes confuse biographical details or attribute accomplishments to the wrong person.
- **Information about very recent events.** There can be a lag between when something happens and when Copilot's web search picks it up accurately.
- **Technical or scientific claims that seem too neat.** Real science is messy. If an explanation seems too clean and simple, dig deeper.

The solution is not to distrust everything Copilot says – most of the time, it is accurate. The solution is to verify the things that matter.

Using Think Deeper for Complex Research

When you are researching something that requires careful analysis rather than just finding facts, Think Deeper mode is valuable:

> "I am considering investing in rental property versus index funds for retirement. Analyze both options considering: initial capital requirements, ongoing time commitment, historical returns, tax implications, risk profile, and liquidity. Use Think Deeper to work through this carefully."

Think Deeper will take longer but will provide a more thorough, well-reasoned analysis than a quick response would.

Research for Students

If you are a student, Copilot can be an incredible study aid – but you need to use it ethically.

What You Should Do

- **Use Copilot to understand concepts.** Ask it to explain topics you are studying.
- **Use it to find sources.** Ask Copilot to help you find relevant research papers, articles, and books on your topic.
- **Use it to quiz yourself.** Have Copilot test your knowledge before an exam.

- **Use it to check your reasoning.** Paste in your argument and ask, "Is my reasoning sound? What am I missing?"
- **Use it to brainstorm.** Generate ideas for papers and projects, then develop them yourself.
- **Use it to learn study techniques.** "What are the most effective ways to study for a biology exam?"

What You Should Not Do

- **Do not submit Copilot's output as your own work** unless your instructor specifically allows it. This is plagiarism at most institutions.
- **Do not rely on Copilot for citations in academic papers** without verifying them. It can suggest sources, but you need to confirm they exist and say what Copilot claims they say.
- **Do not use it as a substitute for understanding.** Getting Copilot to write your essay and submitting it teaches you nothing. Using Copilot to understand the material and then writing the essay yourself is learning.

Always check your school's AI use policy. Policies vary widely, and it is your responsibility to know the rules.

Research for Professionals

Professionals can use Copilot to stay current in their field, prepare for meetings, and make better decisions:

Industry Research

> "Give me an overview of the major trends in the healthcare industry for 2026. Focus on technology adoption, regulatory changes, and workforce challenges. Cite your sources."

Competitive Analysis

> "I work for a mid-sized accounting firm. What are the major cloud-based accounting platforms our clients are likely asking about? Compare QuickBooks Online, Xero, and FreshBooks in terms of features, pricing, and market position."

Meeting Preparation

> "I have a meeting tomorrow with a potential client in the manufacturing sector. Give me a quick briefing on the biggest challenges facing US manufacturers right now, including supply chain issues, labor shortages, and technology adoption."

Understanding Regulations

> "Explain the key provisions of the latest data privacy regulations in California. How do they affect small businesses that collect customer email addresses?"

Remember: for legal and regulatory questions, always verify with a qualified professional. Copilot is a starting point, not legal counsel.

Building a Personal Knowledge Base

Here is a power technique: use Copilot conversations to build your own knowledge base.

After a productive research session, ask Copilot to create a summary document:

> "Based on everything we discussed about renewable energy investment, create a comprehensive reference document I can save. Include key statistics, important distinctions, and practical decision factors. Format it with clear headings so I can scan it quickly later."

Copy this into a document or note-taking app. Over time, you will build a personal library of well-organized research on topics that matter to you.

Using Pages for Research Projects

If you have access to Pages (available on paid plans), it is an ideal tool for research projects. Instead of a chat that scrolls away, a Page gives you an editable canvas where you can organize your findings, rearrange sections, and build a structured research document collaboratively with Copilot.

Start a research conversation in chat, then move the results to a Page when you want to organize and refine them.

Practical Research Exercises

Try these exercises to build your research skills with Copilot:

Exercise 1: Learn something new. Pick a topic you have always been curious about but never had time to explore. Spend 15 minutes with Copilot exploring it. Start broad, then drill down into what interests you most.

Exercise 2: Research a purchase. Use Copilot to research your next significant purchase. Ask it to compare options, identify key decision factors, and present a recommendation.

Exercise 3: Verify a claim. Find a surprising statistic or claim online. Ask Copilot to verify it and find supporting or contradicting evidence.

Exercise 4: Study a complex topic. Choose something you find confusing – the tax code, geopolitics, a scientific concept. Ask Copilot to explain it step by step, using the "build up my understanding" approach.

What You Will Learn Next

Now that you know how to write and research with Copilot, it is time to broaden the scope. Chapter 8 covers everyday productivity – using Copilot for planning, organizing, problem-solving, and all the small tasks that fill your days. This is where Copilot stops being a tool you use occasionally and starts becoming a daily habit.

Chapter 8: Everyday Productivity

The previous chapters showed you how to use Copilot for writing and research – two of its most powerful applications. But Copilot is not just for big, structured tasks. It is also remarkably useful for the dozens of small tasks, decisions, and organizational challenges that fill your everyday life.

This chapter is about making Copilot a daily habit – something you reach for naturally whenever you need to plan, organize, calculate, decide, or solve a problem. By the end, you will see Copilot as less of a special-purpose tool and more of a general-purpose assistant that helps you move through your day more efficiently.

Planning and Scheduling

Trip Planning

Copilot is an excellent travel planner. Instead of spending hours juggling multiple travel websites, you can start with a conversation:

> "I am planning a five-day trip to Portugal in September for two people. We enjoy food, history, and beaches. Our budget is moderate – not backpacking, but not luxury either. Create a day-by-day itinerary with suggestions for where to stay, what to see, and where to eat."

Copilot will generate a detailed itinerary. Then refine it:

> "We do not want to change cities every night. Can you revise this so we have two bases – Lisbon and the Algarve – and do day trips from each?"
>
> "What is the best way to get from Lisbon to the Algarve? Compare driving, train, and flying."
>
> "What should we pack for Portugal in September?"

Meal Planning

> "Create a weekly meal plan for a family of four. Two adults, one picky eight-year-old who only likes pasta and chicken, and one toddler. We want healthy

> meals that can be prepared in 30 minutes or less on weeknights. Include a grocery list."

Follow up with:

> "My toddler is allergic to dairy. Can you adjust the plan and grocery list to eliminate all dairy?"

Event Planning

> "I am organizing a surprise 40th birthday party for my wife. Budget is $2,000, about 30 guests, and I need to do it within three weeks. She loves Italian food and live music. Give me a step-by-step planning checklist with a timeline."

Organization and Decision-Making

Organizing Your Life

Copilot can help you create systems and structures for organizing just about anything:

> "I am overwhelmed by clutter in my house. Give me a realistic, room-by-room decluttering plan that I can do over four weekends. Start with the areas that will have the biggest visual impact."

> "I have 200 unread emails in my inbox. Give me a strategy for getting to inbox zero and keeping it that way going forward."

Making Decisions

When you are stuck on a decision, Copilot can help you think it through systematically:

> "I have been offered a job in another city. Higher salary ($15,000 more) but I would have to relocate away from family. Help me create a decision framework – what factors should I weigh, and how should I think about this?"

> "I need to choose between three daycares for my daughter. Here are the key facts about each: [list details]. Help me compare them and identify which questions I should ask during my visits."

Copilot will not make the decision for you – nor should it. But it can help you organize your thinking, identify factors you might have overlooked, and see the trade-offs more clearly.

Creating Lists and Checklists

> "Create a packing list for a week-long business trip to a cold climate. I have meetings every day and one formal dinner."
>
> "What are all the things I need to do when moving to a new apartment? Give me a comprehensive checklist organized by timeline: one month before, two weeks before, one week before, moving day, and first week after."
>
> "I am going camping for the first time. Create a complete gear and supply checklist for a two-night car camping trip in summer."

Math, Calculations, and Everyday Numbers

You do not need to be a math person to benefit from Copilot's ability to work with numbers:

Financial Calculations

> "If I save $500 per month in a retirement account earning an average of 7% annually, how much will I have in 25 years?"
>
> "I am comparing two job offers. Job A pays $85,000 with a 15-minute commute. Job B pays $95,000 but has a 50-minute commute. If I value my commute time at $30 per hour, which job is actually worth more?"
>
> "Help me figure out how much house I can afford. My household income is $110,000, we have $40,000 saved for a down payment, and our monthly debt payments are $600."

Everyday Math

> "I am splitting a restaurant bill between six people. The total is $247.83 before tip. We want to leave 20%. How much does each person owe?"
>
> "I am remodeling my kitchen and need to tile a backsplash area that is 8 feet wide and 18 inches tall. The tiles are 4 inches square. How many tiles do I need, and how many extra should I buy for cuts and mistakes?"

> "Convert this recipe from six servings to four servings: [paste recipe]."

Understanding Your Bills

> "Here are the line items on my electric bill: [paste details]. Can you explain what each charge means and tell me if anything looks unusual?"

Cooking and Recipes

Copilot is a surprisingly useful kitchen companion:

> "What can I make for dinner with chicken breast, broccoli, rice, soy sauce, and garlic? Give me two quick options."
>
> "I have a dinner party on Saturday and one guest is vegan, one is gluten-free, and one has a nut allergy. Suggest a three-course menu that accommodates everyone without making separate dishes for each person."
>
> "Give me a recipe for homemade pizza dough that is beginner-friendly. Include tips for someone who has never worked with yeast before."
>
> "I found a recipe that calls for tamarind paste, but I do not have any. What can I substitute?"

Health and Wellness

Copilot can be a helpful wellness companion, with an important caveat: it is not a doctor, and it should never replace professional medical advice.

Fitness

> "Create a beginner-friendly workout plan for someone who has not exercised in years. Three days per week, no equipment, 30 minutes per session. Focus on building a sustainable habit rather than intensity."
>
> "I sit at a desk all day and my back hurts. What are some stretches I can do at my desk every hour?"

Understanding Health Information

> "My doctor said my LDL cholesterol is 145 and recommended lifestyle changes before considering medication. Explain what LDL cholesterol is,

what that number means, and what lifestyle changes are most effective for lowering it."

"I am reading a medical report and I do not understand some of the terms. Can you explain these in plain language: [paste terms]?"

Important: Always discuss health information with your doctor. Copilot can help you understand medical concepts, but it cannot diagnose conditions, recommend treatments, or replace a conversation with a healthcare professional.

Home and Car Maintenance

"My dishwasher is leaving a white film on my glasses. What are the most likely causes and how do I fix it?"

"My car's check engine light came on. I went to AutoZone and they said the code is P0420. What does that mean, how serious is it, and what should I expect to pay for the repair?"

"I want to paint my living room this weekend. I have never painted a room before. Give me a complete step-by-step guide, including what supplies to buy."

"What regular maintenance should I be doing on my home? Create a seasonal checklist for spring, summer, fall, and winter."

Personal Finance

"Explain the difference between a Roth IRA and a Traditional IRA. Which one makes more sense for someone who is 30, earns $75,000 per year, and expects to earn more in the future?"

"I have $8,000 in credit card debt across three cards. Here are the balances and interest rates: [list them]. What is the fastest way to pay them off?"

"Create a monthly budget template for a single person earning $4,500 per month after taxes. Include categories for all common expenses."

"I am thinking about refinancing my mortgage. Current rate is 5.5%, remaining balance is $280,000 with 22 years left. If I can get 4.2%, is it worth refinancing? What would I save?"

Image Generation with Microsoft Designer

Copilot includes image generation capabilities through Microsoft Designer, powered by DALL-E. You can create images – from social media graphics to birthday cards to logo concepts – simply by describing what you want. Image generation is included in both free and paid plans, though paid plans offer more generations per day and additional customization options.

We will cover image generation in depth in Chapter 15, including how to write effective image prompts, work with style options, iterate on results, and use Designer's full feature set. For now, know that it is available and remarkably easy to use: just describe the image you want in the Copilot chat, and Designer will create it.

Using Copilot with Your Phone

The mobile app opens up some unique everyday uses:

Camera integration. Point your phone's camera at something and ask Copilot about it: - Take a photo of a plant and ask, "What kind of plant is this and how do I care for it?" - Photograph a menu in a foreign language and ask for a translation. - Snap a picture of a math problem from your kid's homework and ask for help solving it. - Take a photo of a product in a store and ask for reviews and price comparisons.

Voice conversations. Use the microphone to talk to Copilot hands-free – useful when you are cooking, driving (as a passenger, of course), or just prefer speaking to typing.

Quick lookups. The mobile app is perfect for on-the-go questions: restaurant recommendations, directions clarification, unit conversions, and more.

Creating Routines and Habits

Here is a way to make Copilot a natural part of your daily routine:

Morning. Ask Copilot for a briefing: "Give me a quick summary of the top news stories today" or "What is the weather forecast for today and this week?"

Work hours. Use Copilot for drafting emails, preparing for meetings, and answering questions that come up during the day.

Evening. Use Copilot for personal tasks: recipe ideas, help with homework (yours or your kids'), planning weekend activities, or just satisfying curiosity about something you heard or read.

As needed. Anytime you encounter something confusing, need to make a decision, or want to save time on a task, open Copilot and ask.

The key is building the habit of reaching for Copilot when you need help. The more you use it, the more natural it becomes, and the more time you save.

Practical Exercises

Exercise 1: Plan something. Use Copilot to plan your next weekend. Ask it to suggest activities based on your interests, weather, and budget.

Exercise 2: Solve a household problem. Think of something in your home that is broken, messy, or inefficient. Ask Copilot for a solution.

Exercise 3: Do some math. Use Copilot to work through a financial calculation you have been putting off – whether to refinance, how much to save for a goal, or how to split a complicated expense.

Exercise 4: Generate an image. Create an image using Designer – describe what you want and see what Copilot produces. Chapter 15 covers image generation in depth.

Exercise 5: Use your phone camera. Download the Copilot mobile app if you have not already, and use the camera feature to ask about something in the real world.

What You Will Learn Next

So far, we have focused on personal and general-purpose uses of Copilot. In the next chapter, we will shift to the professional domain – how Copilot transforms your work life when it is integrated into Microsoft 365. If you use Word, Excel, PowerPoint, Outlook, or Teams at work, Chapter 9 will show you how Copilot can make you meaningfully more productive.

Chapter 9: Work and Professional Use

Everything we have covered so far works in any context – personal, academic, or professional. But this chapter focuses specifically on how Copilot transforms your work life when it is integrated into the Microsoft 365 tools that millions of professionals use every day. If your workplace runs on Word, Excel, PowerPoint, Outlook, and Teams, this chapter will show you how Copilot can make you substantially more productive.

We will walk through each major Microsoft 365 application, showing you practical ways to use Copilot in your actual work. We will also cover features like meeting intelligence, organizational data access, and agentic capabilities that take Copilot beyond simple chat and into genuine workplace transformation.

A note about what is ahead: This chapter is a preview of what Copilot can do across the Microsoft 365 suite. We will go deep into each app in Chapters 10-14 – Word, Excel, PowerPoint, Outlook, and Teams each get a full chapter of their own. Here, the goal is to give you the big picture: a tour of the possibilities so you can see how the pieces fit together before we dive into the details.

Before We Start: What You Need

To use Copilot inside Microsoft 365 apps at work, your organization needs one of the following:

- **Microsoft 365 Copilot for Business** ($18-21 per user per month, added to a Microsoft 365 business subscription)
- **Microsoft 365 Copilot Enterprise** ($30 per user per month, added to a Microsoft 365 enterprise subscription)

Your IT administrator controls the rollout, so if you do not see Copilot in your work apps, talk to your IT department.

If you are an individual using Microsoft 365 Premium or Copilot Pro with a personal subscription, you will have Copilot in your apps as well, though without the organizational data features that business and enterprise plans provide.

Copilot in Word: Your Writing Amplifier

Copilot in Word goes beyond the standalone chat experience. It works inside your documents, with your content, in your workflow. You can draft entire documents from a description, rewrite selected text for tone or conciseness, summarize 40-page reports into five bullet points, convert meeting notes into formal summaries, and even reference other files in your organization.

> "Draft a project status report for Q1 2026. Include a risks section and next steps."
>
> "Summarize this document in five key bullet points."

On business and enterprise plans, Copilot can pull from your SharePoint files and shared documents – a cross-file awareness that makes organizational Copilot fundamentally more powerful than standalone AI. Chapter 10 covers Copilot in Word in full detail.

Copilot in Excel: Making Sense of Your Data

If you work with spreadsheets, Copilot in Excel might be the feature that changes your work life the most. Instead of memorizing formula syntax, you describe what you need in plain English. Copilot can analyze your data, create complex formulas, build charts, identify patterns and outliers, and sort or filter your spreadsheets – all from natural language requests.

> "Create a formula that calculates commission: 5% under $50K, 7% for $50-100K, 10% over $100K."
>
> "Create a bar chart comparing quarterly revenue by region."

The full walkthrough – including formula generation, data analysis, and visualization – is in Chapter 11.

Copilot in PowerPoint: Presentations in Minutes

Creating presentations is one of the most time-consuming professional tasks. Copilot in PowerPoint can reduce hours of work to minutes. It can generate a complete slide deck from a text description, build a presentation from an existing Word document,

add speaker notes, condense a 25-slide deck to 15, and reorganize your slides into a more logical flow.

> "Create a 10-slide presentation about our new employee wellness program."
>
> "Turn this white paper into a 15-slide executive summary presentation."

Chapter 12 covers the full range of PowerPoint capabilities.

Copilot in Outlook: Email Under Control

Email overload is one of the biggest productivity killers in modern work. Copilot in Outlook attacks this problem directly. It can summarize long email threads, draft replies in the right tone, prioritize your inbox by urgency, and review your outgoing messages for tone and clarity before you send them.

> "Summarize this email thread. What was decided, and are there any action items for me?"
>
> "Draft a polite decline to this vendor's proposal. Leave the door open for future opportunities."

Chapter 13 walks through every Outlook scenario in detail.

Copilot in Teams: Meeting Intelligence

Copilot in Microsoft Teams is transformative for anyone who spends a significant portion of their day in meetings. During meetings, it transcribes in real time, identifies who said what, and tracks topics and action items. After meetings, it generates clean summaries, lists action items with owners, and lets you catch up on meetings you missed – all from a single question.

> "I missed the marketing strategy meeting this morning. What were the key decisions? Are there any action items for me?"

Copilot also summarizes busy Teams chat channels, so you can catch up on hundreds of messages in seconds. Chapter 14 covers Teams in depth.

Working Across Microsoft 365: The Graph Advantage

On business and enterprise plans, Copilot has access to the Microsoft Graph – the layer that connects all your organization's data across Microsoft 365. This means Copilot can draw connections across emails, files, chats, meetings, and contacts.

Practical examples:

> "Find all the documents related to the Anderson account that were shared in the last month." "What did our team discuss about the Q2 budget across emails and Teams chats?" "Who in our organization has expertise in data analytics?" "Summarize everything I need to know before my meeting with Jennifer Park tomorrow – pull from our recent emails, shared documents, and any relevant Teams discussions."

This cross-application intelligence is something no standalone AI chatbot can provide. It is the deepest reason why Copilot in Microsoft 365 is fundamentally different from using a general-purpose AI tool.

Agentic Capabilities: Copilot Takes Action

One of the most significant developments in 2025 and 2026 is the emergence of agentic capabilities – the ability for Copilot to take actions on your behalf rather than just generating text.

Examples of agentic behavior:

- Copilot can draft an email, create a meeting invitation, and add agenda items – all from a single natural language request
- It can monitor a SharePoint folder for new documents and automatically summarize them
- It can help automate routine workflows – like sending a weekly status report compiled from data across multiple sources

Agentic capabilities are still evolving and expanding. The key principle is that Copilot is moving from being a tool you ask questions to being a tool that can execute tasks for you, with your approval and oversight.

Data Security and Privacy at Work

If you are using Copilot at work, data security is understandably a concern. Here is what you should know:

Your data stays within your organization. On business and enterprise plans, Copilot accesses your organizational data through the same security boundaries that already protect your Microsoft 365 environment. It can only see data that you have permission to access.

Microsoft does not train on your data. Your organization's data is not used to train the underlying AI models. Your confidential business information stays confidential.

Admin controls are robust. Your IT team can control which users have access to Copilot, what data sources it can draw from, and what actions it can take.

Conversations are logged. In enterprise environments, Copilot conversations may be subject to your organization's data retention and compliance policies. Check with your IT department if you have questions about how conversations are stored and managed.

Getting the Most Out of Copilot at Work

Here are professional-specific tips that go beyond what we covered in earlier chapters:

Use it for meeting prep. Before any important meeting, ask Copilot to brief you on the topic, summarize relevant documents, and suggest questions to ask.

Use it for status updates. Instead of spending 30 minutes writing a weekly status update, tell Copilot what you accomplished and let it draft the report.

Use it for onboarding. If you are new to a team or project, ask Copilot to summarize the project's history, key documents, and recent decisions.

Use it to translate jargon. Received a technical document outside your expertise? Ask Copilot to explain it in terms you understand.

Use it to prepare for difficult conversations. "I need to give constructive feedback to a team member about missing deadlines. Help me plan what to say in a way that is direct but supportive."

Track your productivity gains. Pay attention to how much time Copilot saves you each week. This data is useful for making the case to your organization to expand Copilot access.

Common Workplace Scenarios

Let us walk through a realistic workday to see how Copilot fits in:

8:00 AM: You open Outlook and ask Copilot to summarize your overnight emails and flag anything urgent. Two minutes instead of 20.

8:30 AM: You join a Teams meeting. Copilot transcribes and tracks action items. After the meeting, you get a clean summary in 30 seconds instead of spending 15 minutes writing up your notes.

10:00 AM: Your manager asks for a quick analysis of last quarter's sales data. You open the Excel file, ask Copilot to highlight the top trends and create a summary chart. Ten minutes instead of an hour.

11:00 AM: You need to respond to a complex client email. You ask Copilot to draft a response based on the email thread, your internal pricing document, and the proposal you sent last month. Five minutes of editing instead of 30 minutes of drafting.

2:00 PM: You need to create a presentation for a stakeholder update. You tell Copilot in PowerPoint to build a deck based on your project status document. Twenty minutes of refinement instead of two hours of creation.

4:00 PM: A colleague asks you to review a 30-page contract. You open it in Word and ask Copilot to summarize the key terms, flag any unusual clauses, and identify the main obligations. Fifteen minutes instead of an hour.

That is a day where Copilot saved you roughly three to four hours. Multiply that across a week, a month, a year – the impact is significant.

Looking Forward

Microsoft is investing billions of dollars in Copilot, and the pace of improvement is rapid. Features that seem impressive today will be baseline expectations tomorrow. Agentic capabilities will expand, models will become more accurate, and the integration across Microsoft 365 will deepen.

The most important thing you can do right now is start using Copilot. The skills you build today – crafting effective prompts, iterating on results, understanding which tool to use for which task – will only become more valuable as the technology improves.

You now have a strong foundation for using Copilot across your professional work. In the chapters ahead, we will dive deeper into each Microsoft 365 app, explore advanced features like Pages, Think Deeper, and image generation, and cover specialized use cases that will take your Copilot skills even further.

Chapter 10: Copilot in Word

If you spend any meaningful amount of time writing – reports, proposals, memos, blog posts, anything – then Copilot in Word is about to become your favorite feature in all of Microsoft 365. This is where Copilot stops feeling like a chatbot and starts feeling like a coworker who happens to be a very fast writer.

In this chapter, you will learn how to use Copilot to draft documents from scratch, rewrite existing text, summarize long documents, and get coaching on your writing. By the end, we will walk through a complete real-world workflow: creating a project proposal from start to finish.

How Copilot Shows Up in Word

When you open a document in Word with a Microsoft 365 Copilot license, you will notice Copilot in two places.

First, there is the Copilot button in the ribbon (on the Home tab). Clicking it opens the Copilot side panel, which works like a chat interface right inside your document. You can ask questions about the document, request summaries, or have a conversation about your content.

Second – and this is the one most people miss at first – there is an inline Copilot prompt that appears when you are working inside the document itself. In a blank document, you will see a small Copilot icon with the text "Draft with Copilot" near the top of the page. In an existing document, you can place your cursor where you want new content and summon Copilot by clicking the icon that appears in the left margin, or by pressing Alt+I on Windows.

These two entry points serve different purposes. The side panel is for conversation, analysis, and document-level tasks. The inline prompt is for generating and inserting content directly into your document.

Drafting Documents from Prompts

The most powerful feature in Copilot for Word is drafting. You can describe what you want, and Copilot will generate a full document – or a section of one – in seconds.

To draft a new document, open a blank Word file and click the "Draft with Copilot" prompt that appears. Then type your instructions. For example:

> Write a two-page project proposal for migrating our company's file storage from on-premises servers to SharePoint Online. Include sections for executive summary, current challenges, proposed solution, timeline, and estimated costs.

Copilot will generate a complete draft based on your prompt. The output will not be perfect – it never is – but it gives you a strong starting point that you can refine.

Here are some tips for better drafts:

Be specific about structure. Tell Copilot what sections you want, how long the document should be, and what format to use. "Write a report" gives you something generic. "Write a three-page report with an executive summary, three key findings, and a recommendation section" gives you something useful.

Mention your audience. "Write this for a non-technical executive audience" produces very different output than "write this for the engineering team." Copilot adjusts vocabulary, detail level, and tone based on who you say will read it.

Reference other files. This is one of Copilot's strongest advantages over standalone AI tools. You can reference files stored in your Microsoft 365 environment by typing "/" in the prompt and selecting a file. For example: "Draft a summary report based on /Q1 Sales Data.xlsx and /Customer Feedback Survey.docx." Copilot will pull information from those files and weave it into your draft.

Specify tone. Words like "formal," "friendly," "persuasive," or "neutral" make a real difference. If you do not specify, Copilot defaults to a fairly generic professional tone that may or may not match your needs.

After Copilot generates a draft, you will see options to **Keep it**, **Regenerate**, or **Discard**. You can also refine the draft by typing additional instructions in the prompt

box – for example, “Make the executive summary shorter” or “Add a section about risk mitigation.”

Rewriting and Transforming Text

Drafting from scratch is great, but most of your time in Word is probably spent revising existing text. Copilot handles this well.

To rewrite text, select the passage you want to change, then right-click and choose Copilot from the context menu, or click the Copilot icon that appears near your selection. You will see several options:

- **Rewrite:** Copilot generates alternative versions of the selected text. It typically offers three variations, and you can pick the one you like or discard all of them.
- **Auto Rewrite:** Copilot rewrites the text with no additional input from you. This is useful when you just want a fresh take on a paragraph.
- **Rewrite with instructions:** You tell Copilot how to change the text. For example, “Make this more concise,” “Simplify for a general audience,” or “Make this sound more confident.”

Rewriting is particularly useful for these common scenarios:

Adjusting tone. You wrote an email in a hurry and it sounds too blunt. Select it, ask Copilot to “rewrite this in a warmer, more collaborative tone,” and you get a version that says the same thing without the edge.

Simplifying complex text. You pasted in a paragraph from a technical specification and need to include it in a report for stakeholders. Ask Copilot to “rewrite this so a non-technical reader can understand it.”

Expanding bullet points. You have a list of brief notes and need full paragraphs. Select the bullets and ask Copilot to “expand each bullet point into a full paragraph with examples.”

Condensing long passages. The opposite problem – you wrote too much. Select the section and ask Copilot to “reduce this to half its current length while keeping all key points.”

One important note: Copilot's rewrites are suggestions. They appear as alternatives you can accept or reject. Your original text is preserved until you explicitly choose to replace it.

Summarizing Documents

If someone sends you a 30-page report and you need to understand it in five minutes, the Copilot side panel is your best friend.

Open the Copilot panel and try prompts like:

- "Summarize this document in five bullet points."
- "What are the three main arguments in this document?"
- "Give me a one-paragraph executive summary."
- "What decisions does this document recommend?"

Copilot reads the entire document and generates a summary based on your request. This works with documents you have authored and documents others have shared with you, as long as they are stored in your Microsoft 365 environment (OneDrive or SharePoint).

You can also ask targeted questions about the document's content:

- "What does this document say about the project timeline?"
- "Are there any risks mentioned?"
- "What budget figures are included?"

These questions are grounded in the actual document content, so the answers are typically accurate. That said, always verify critical details – Copilot can occasionally miss nuance or misinterpret context, especially in documents with complex formatting or ambiguous language.

Summarization works best on well-structured documents. If the source document is disorganized, Copilot's summary may reflect that disorder. Garbage in, garbage out still applies, even with AI.

Coaching on Tone and Clarity

Copilot in Word includes a coaching feature that goes beyond simple rewriting. Instead of changing your text for you, it offers suggestions and explains why.

To access coaching, open the Copilot side panel and ask something like:

- "How can I improve the tone of this document?"
- "Review this document for clarity and suggest improvements."
- "Is this document persuasive enough for a board presentation?"

Copilot will analyze your writing and provide feedback. It might tell you that your opening paragraph buries the lead, that certain sections use too much jargon, or that your conclusion does not clearly state what you want the reader to do next.

This is different from rewriting because you remain in control. Copilot gives you the diagnosis, and you decide how to treat it. For many writers, this is more valuable than automated rewrites because it helps you improve your own skills over time.

Coaching is particularly useful when you are writing for an audience you do not usually address – say, a technical person writing for executives, or a manager writing a company-wide announcement. Copilot can flag language that might not land well with your intended readers.

Working with Templates

Copilot integrates with Word's existing template system, and you can use the two together effectively.

Start with a Word template – say, your company's standard proposal template – and then use Copilot to fill in the sections. Place your cursor in each section and use the inline Copilot prompt to generate content specific to that section.

You can also ask Copilot to create content that follows a specific template structure even without a formal Word template. For example:

> Draft a project charter following this structure: Project Name, Project Sponsor, Objectives, Scope, Deliverables, Timeline, Budget, Risks, Approval Signatures.

Copilot will generate a document with those exact sections, filled with placeholder content that you can customize.

What Copilot in Word Cannot Do

Before we move on, let us be honest about the limitations.

It does not know your company's specific details. Unless you reference specific files, Copilot will generate plausible but generic content. It might invent project names, budget figures, or team members that do not exist.

It sometimes ignores formatting instructions. You might ask for a bulleted list and get paragraphs, or ask for three sections and get five. This is improving with each update, but it is not perfectly reliable.

It can be repetitive. Copilot-generated text sometimes circles back to the same point multiple times, especially in longer documents. Watch for this during your review.

It does not replace editing. Every Copilot draft needs human review. Think of it as a first draft from a capable but uninformed assistant. The structure and language will be solid, but the substance needs your expertise.

Real-World Workflow: Creating a Project Proposal

Let us walk through a realistic scenario from beginning to end.

You are a project manager and you need to write a proposal for migrating your team from Slack to Microsoft Teams. Your manager has asked for a formal document by end of day. Here is how you would use Copilot to get it done.

Step 1: Generate the First Draft

Open a new Word document. In the "Draft with Copilot" prompt, type:

> Write a formal project proposal for migrating our 200-person marketing department from Slack to Microsoft Teams. Include sections for Executive Summary, Business Case, Current State Assessment, Proposed Solution, Implementation Plan, Risk Analysis, Budget Estimate, and Conclusion. The tone should be professional and persuasive, aimed at senior leadership. Emphasize cost savings from consolidating communication tools and better integration with our existing Microsoft 365 environment.

Click Generate. In about 15 seconds, Copilot produces a multi-page document with all the requested sections. The content is generic – Copilot does not know your actual costs or team structure – but the framework is solid.

Click **Keep it** to insert the draft into your document.

Step 2: Refine with Referenced Files

Now make it specific. Suppose you have a spreadsheet with current Slack costs. Place your cursor in the Budget Estimate section, summon inline Copilot, and type:

> Rewrite this budget section using the data in /Slack Annual Costs 2025.xlsx. Compare current Slack costs to projected Microsoft Teams costs assuming we already have Microsoft 365 licenses.

Copilot pulls the actual numbers from your spreadsheet and incorporates them into the section.

Step 3: Rewrite the Executive Summary

The generated executive summary is okay but too long. Select it, click the Copilot icon, and choose "Rewrite with instructions":

> Condense this to three sentences. Lead with the cost savings number, then the integration benefit, then the recommendation.

Copilot produces a tight, punchy executive summary that gets straight to the point.

Step 4: Get Coaching on Tone

Open the Copilot side panel and type:

> Review this proposal for tone. Is it persuasive enough for a VP-level audience? Are there any sections that sound too technical or too casual?

Copilot analyzes the document and flags a couple of issues – maybe the Risk Analysis section sounds too negative, or the Implementation Plan uses too much IT jargon. It suggests specific improvements you can make.

Step 5: Add a Missing Section

Your manager mentioned they want to see competitor analysis. Place your cursor after the Business Case section, summon inline Copilot, and type:

> Add a section called "Competitive Landscape" that briefly compares Microsoft Teams to Slack, Zoom Workplace, and Google Chat for enterprise use. Keep it objective but highlight Teams' strengths in Microsoft 365 integration.

Copilot inserts the new section in the right location.

Step 6: Final Summary Check

Before sending, use the side panel to ask:

> Summarize this document in five bullet points so I can use them in the email when I send this to my VP.

Copilot gives you a concise summary you can paste directly into your email.

Total time: about 20 minutes for a document that would have taken two to three hours to write from scratch.

Key Takeaways

- Copilot in Word works through two entry points: the side panel for conversation and analysis, and the inline prompt for generating content directly in your document.
- Drafting works best when you are specific about structure, audience, and tone.
- Referencing other Microsoft 365 files with the "/" command lets Copilot ground its output in your actual data.
- Rewriting lets you adjust tone, length, complexity, and style without starting over.
- Summarization is ideal for quickly understanding long documents or extracting key points.
- Coaching helps you improve your writing rather than just replacing it.
- Every Copilot draft is a starting point, not a finished product. Plan to review and revise.

Chapter 11: Copilot in Excel

Excel is where Copilot might save you the most time – and also where it requires the most patience. Spreadsheets are structured, precise, and unforgiving. A formula that is off by one cell reference can throw an entire report into chaos. Copilot brings natural language to this world of formulas and data, letting you describe what you want instead of remembering the exact syntax for XLOOKUP or SUMIFS.

In this chapter, you will learn how to use Copilot to analyze data, generate formulas, create charts, and even work with Python in Excel. We will finish with a complete real-world workflow: analyzing a sales dataset from raw data to finished insights.

What You Need Before You Start

Copilot in Excel has one important requirement that trips people up: **your data must be in a formatted table.** Not just data sitting in cells – an actual Excel table, created with Ctrl+T or by going to Insert > Table.

This is not optional. If your data is not in a table, Copilot will either refuse to work with it or give you a prompt to convert it. The reason is straightforward: tables have defined boundaries, headers, and structure that Copilot can understand. A random collection of cells with data scattered across the sheet does not give Copilot enough context to work with.

If you are working with existing spreadsheets, the first thing you should do is convert your data ranges to tables. Select your data, press Ctrl+T, confirm that the headers are correct, and you are ready to go.

How Copilot Shows Up in Excel

Like Word, Copilot in Excel appears in the ribbon and opens as a side panel. Click the Copilot button on the Home tab, and the panel opens on the right side of your screen.

Unlike Word, there is no inline Copilot prompt in Excel. Everything goes through the side panel. You type your request, and Copilot either modifies your spreadsheet directly or shows you a preview of what it plans to do.

When Copilot suggests a change – adding a formula column, creating a chart, or sorting data – it shows you a preview first. You can then choose to **Apply** the change, **Refine** your request, or **Discard** the suggestion. This preview step is important because spreadsheet changes can cascade. Copilot respects that by never making changes without your approval.

Analyzing Data with Natural Language

This is the feature that makes non-Excel-experts fall in love with Copilot. You can ask plain English questions about your data, and Copilot answers them.

Suppose you have a sales table with columns for Date, Region, Product, Units Sold, and Revenue. You can ask:

- "What was the total revenue last quarter?"
- "Which region had the highest sales?"
- "Show me the trend in units sold over the past 12 months."
- "What is the average revenue per transaction?"
- "Are there any outliers in this data?"

Copilot analyzes your table and responds with answers, often accompanied by small charts or highlighted data points. These responses appear in the side panel, not in your spreadsheet, so they do not modify your data.

This is incredibly useful for quick analysis. Instead of building a pivot table to answer a simple question, you just ask. For deeper analysis, you will still want pivot tables and proper reports, but for "I need an answer in the next 30 seconds" situations, Copilot is hard to beat.

Tips for Better Data Questions

Use column names. Copilot understands your table's column headers, so reference them. "What is the average of Revenue?" is clearer than "What is the average of the numbers?"

Specify time periods. "Total revenue for March 2026" is better than "recent revenue." Copilot can interpret dates, but being explicit avoids ambiguity.

Ask follow-up questions. After Copilot answers your first question, you can ask follow-ups in the same session. "Break that down by region" or "Now show me just Q1" work well as continuations.

Generating Formulas and Functions

For many people, this is the killer feature. You describe what you want a formula to do, and Copilot writes it.

Open the Copilot panel and try prompts like:

- "Add a column that calculates profit margin as (Revenue - Cost) / Revenue."
- "Create a formula that shows the running total of Units Sold."
- "Add a column that categorizes revenue as 'High' if over 10,000, 'Medium' if between 5,000 and 10,000, and 'Low' if under 5,000."
- "Add a column that extracts the month name from the Date column."

Copilot generates the formula and shows you a preview of the new column with sample results. If the formula looks correct, click Apply, and Copilot adds the column to your table.

This is valuable for two types of people. First, people who know what they want but cannot remember the exact Excel syntax. If you know you need a nested IF statement but cannot remember whether the syntax is IF(condition, true, false) or something else, Copilot handles it. Second, people who do not know that certain formulas exist. You might not know about TEXTSPLIT or UNIQUE, but you can describe what you want and Copilot will use the right function.

Complex Formulas

Copilot handles surprisingly complex formulas. You can ask for:

- **Conditional aggregations:** "Sum revenue only for rows where Region is 'West' and Product is 'Widget A'."
- **Lookups:** "Add a column that looks up the manager name from the Employees table based on the Employee ID in this table."
- **Date calculations:** "Add a column showing the number of business days between Order Date and Ship Date."
- **Text manipulation:** "Extract everything before the '@' symbol in the Email column."

When Copilot generates a formula, it usually explains what the formula does in plain English. This is helpful for learning – you can see the formula, understand the explanation, and gradually build your own Excel skills.

When Formulas Go Wrong

Copilot's formulas are usually correct, but not always. Common issues include:

- **Wrong cell references:** The formula might reference the wrong column or use an absolute reference where it should be relative.
- **Misunderstood conditions:** If your prompt is ambiguous, the formula might filter on the wrong criteria.
- **Missing edge cases:** The formula might not handle blank cells, zeros, or error values correctly.

Always review the preview before applying. If something looks off, refine your prompt with more detail. "Add a column that calculates profit margin, handling cases where Revenue is zero by showing 'N/A'" is better than hoping Copilot will handle the edge case on its own.

Creating Charts and Visualizations

Copilot can create charts directly from your data, and it does a decent job of choosing appropriate chart types.

Try prompts like:

- "Create a bar chart showing total revenue by region."
- "Show a line chart of monthly sales trends."
- "Create a pie chart of market share by product category."
- "Make a chart comparing this year's revenue to last year's by quarter."

Copilot generates the chart and shows you a preview. You can apply it to insert the chart into your spreadsheet, where you can then customize it further using Excel's native chart tools.

The charts Copilot creates are standard Excel charts, not special Copilot objects. Once inserted, you have full control – change colors, add data labels, modify axes, or move the chart to a chart sheet. Copilot gets you 80% of the way there, and you handle the final formatting.

Getting Better Charts

Specify the chart type if you have a preference. Copilot will guess, and its guesses are reasonable, but if you know you want a stacked bar chart rather than a clustered one, say so.

Tell Copilot what to emphasize. "Create a chart that highlights the growth trend in the East region" produces a more focused visualization than "chart the data."

Ask for multiple charts. You can request several charts in one session. "Create three charts: revenue by region, revenue by product, and monthly revenue trend" works well.

Python in Excel with Copilot

This is a newer feature that significantly expands what you can do in Excel. Python in Excel lets you run Python code directly inside your spreadsheet, and Copilot can write that Python code for you.

Why would you want Python in Excel? Because some analysis tasks are difficult or impossible with standard Excel formulas. Statistical analysis, machine learning, advanced data visualization, and complex data transformations are all areas where Python excels (no pun intended).

To use Python with Copilot, you can type prompts like:

- "Use Python to create a correlation matrix for all numeric columns."
- "Use Python to perform a linear regression on Revenue vs. Marketing Spend."
- "Use Python to create a heatmap of sales by region and month."
- "Use Python to identify clusters in this customer data."

Copilot generates the Python code, runs it in a secure cloud environment, and displays the results in your spreadsheet. The results might be a value, a DataFrame (which shows up as a table-like output in your cells), or a visualization.

You do not need to know Python to use this feature. Copilot writes all the code. But if you do know Python, you can review and modify the code that Copilot generates – click on the cell containing the Python output to see the code in the formula bar.

Python Limitations to Know

- Python in Excel runs in a sandboxed environment in the cloud. It does not have access to your local machine's Python installation or packages beyond what Microsoft provides.
- The available libraries include pandas, matplotlib, seaborn, scikit-learn, and several others. You cannot install arbitrary packages.
- Python calculations may take a few seconds longer than standard formulas because they run in the cloud.
- This feature requires a Microsoft 365 subscription and may not be available in all plans.

Data Insights and Trend Identification

Beyond answering specific questions, Copilot can proactively identify patterns in your data.

Try prompts like:

- "What trends do you see in this data?"
- "Are there any anomalies or outliers?"
- "What are the key takeaways from this dataset?"
- "What factors most strongly correlate with high revenue?"

Copilot will analyze your data and present findings, sometimes with supporting charts. This is useful for exploratory analysis – when you are not sure what questions to ask yet and want Copilot to surface what is interesting.

That said, treat these insights as starting points, not conclusions. Copilot identifies patterns, but it does not understand your business context. A spike in sales might be due to a promotion you ran, a seasonal trend, or a data entry error. Copilot will flag the spike but cannot tell you which explanation is correct without more information.

Real-World Workflow: Analyzing a Sales Dataset

Let us walk through a complete scenario. You are a sales analyst and your manager wants a summary of Q1 2026 performance by end of day. You have a spreadsheet with 5,000 rows of transaction data.

Step 1: Prepare the Data

Open the spreadsheet. The data has columns: Date, Sales Rep, Region, Product Category, Units, Unit Price, and Revenue. Select all the data, press Ctrl+T to convert it to a table, and confirm the headers.

Step 2: Get a Quick Overview

Open Copilot and type:

> Give me a high-level overview of this sales data. What is the total revenue, number of transactions, and average transaction size?

Copilot calculates the answers and presents them. You now have the top-line numbers without building a single formula.

Step 3: Break Down by Region

> Break down total revenue by region and tell me which region is performing best and worst.

Copilot provides a breakdown and might offer to create a chart. If it does, apply the chart.

Step 4: Add Calculated Columns

> Add a column called "Quarter" that extracts the quarter from the Date column (Q1, Q2, etc.). Then add a column called "Revenue Category" that labels transactions over $5,000 as "Large," $1,000-$5,000 as "Medium," and under $1,000 as "Small."

Copilot generates the formulas and shows previews. Apply both.

Step 5: Identify Trends

> What are the top 5 products by revenue? Has there been any change in the product mix compared to last quarter?

Copilot analyzes the data and surfaces the top products, along with any notable shifts.

Step 6: Create Visualizations

> Create three charts: a bar chart of revenue by region, a line chart showing daily revenue trends for Q1, and a pie chart of revenue by product category.

Copilot generates each chart. Apply them to your spreadsheet.

Step 7: Advanced Analysis with Python

> Use Python to create a correlation matrix showing the relationship between Units, Unit Price, and Revenue across all regions.

Copilot writes the Python code, runs it, and produces a heatmap visualization in your spreadsheet.

Step 8: Generate a Summary

> Summarize the key findings from this data in five bullet points that I can paste into an email to my manager.

Copilot synthesizes everything you have explored and produces a clean summary.

Total time: about 25 minutes for analysis that would typically take one to two hours of formula writing, pivot table building, and chart creation.

Key Takeaways

- Your data must be in a formatted Excel table (Ctrl+T) before Copilot can work with it.
- Ask natural language questions to get quick answers without building formulas.
- Copilot can generate formulas ranging from simple calculations to complex nested functions – always review the preview before applying.
- Charts are generated as standard Excel charts that you can customize after insertion.
- Python in Excel lets Copilot perform advanced analysis (statistics, machine learning, custom visualizations) that goes beyond traditional formulas.
- Copilot can identify trends and anomalies, but you need to apply your business context to interpret them correctly.
- Every change Copilot suggests goes through a preview step – nothing is applied without your approval.

Chapter 12: Copilot in PowerPoint

There is a particular kind of dread that comes with opening a blank PowerPoint deck at 4 PM knowing you need to present at 9 AM tomorrow. You know what you want to say, roughly, but the thought of building slide after slide – finding layouts, writing bullet points, sourcing images, making everything look consistent – is enough to make you consider calling in sick.

Copilot in PowerPoint does not eliminate the work of making a great presentation, but it eliminates the worst part: starting from nothing. You can go from a prompt or an existing document to a complete slide deck in under a minute. Then you spend your time refining instead of building.

In this chapter, you will learn how to create presentations from prompts and documents, add and format slides, generate images, and get design suggestions. We will close with a real-world workflow: building a quarterly business review presentation.

How Copilot Shows Up in PowerPoint

Copilot in PowerPoint works through the same side panel you have seen in Word and Excel. Click the Copilot button on the Home tab to open it.

There is also a Copilot prompt that appears when you create a new blank presentation, similar to the “Draft with Copilot” prompt in Word. It invites you to describe the presentation you want to create.

One key difference from Word and Excel: Copilot in PowerPoint is more visual and structural. Instead of generating text or formulas, it generates entire slides – complete with layouts, text, and sometimes images. This makes its output more impressive at first glance, but it also means there is more to review and adjust.

Creating Presentations from Prompts

The fastest way to build a deck is to describe what you want. Open a new presentation and type your prompt in the Copilot panel or the startup prompt. For example:

> Create a 10-slide presentation on the benefits of remote work for a company leadership audience. Include data points where relevant, use a professional tone, and end with a recommendation slide.

Copilot generates a complete deck with a title slide, content slides, and a closing slide. Each slide has a layout, a title, body text, and sometimes placeholder images or icons.

Here is what makes a good PowerPoint prompt:

Specify the number of slides. Without guidance, Copilot tends to produce 8-12 slides. If you need exactly 6 or want a longer deck of 20 slides, say so.

Name your audience. "For a board of directors" produces different content than "for a team meeting" or "for a customer presentation." Copilot adjusts formality, detail level, and emphasis based on the audience.

Describe the structure. If you have a specific flow in mind, lay it out: "Start with the problem, then show three possible solutions, compare them in a table, and end with your recommendation." This gives you much more control over the narrative arc.

Mention design preferences. Copilot can incorporate themes and styles. "Use a clean, modern design" or "keep the color scheme minimal" gives Copilot guidance, though it works within PowerPoint's available design options.

After Copilot generates the deck, you can click through each slide to review. From here, you can ask Copilot to modify individual slides, add new ones, or restructure the deck.

Creating Presentations from Documents

This is one of Copilot's most practical features. Instead of describing a presentation from scratch, you can point Copilot at an existing document and ask it to build slides from that content.

In the Copilot panel, type "/" to reference a file, then enter your prompt:

> Create a presentation based on /Q1 Business Review.docx. Focus on the key metrics and recommendations.

Copilot reads the document, identifies the key points, and structures them into slides. It pulls actual content from your document – statistics, conclusions, recommendations – rather than generating generic filler.

This works with:

- **Word documents:** Reports, proposals, briefs, and memos translate well into slide decks.
- **PDFs:** Copilot can reference PDFs stored in OneDrive or SharePoint.
- **Other PowerPoint files:** You can use an existing deck as the basis for a new one.

The quality of the output depends heavily on the quality of the source document. A well-structured report with clear headings and a logical flow produces a much better deck than a rambling document with no clear sections. If your source document is messy, consider cleaning it up first or supplementing the file reference with specific instructions about what to include.

Tips for Document-Based Presentations

Tell Copilot what to emphasize. "Focus on the financial results and skip the methodology section" helps Copilot prioritize the right content.

Specify what to leave out. "Do not include the appendix or raw data" prevents Copilot from creating slides full of detailed tables that belong in a handout, not on screen.

Set the slide count. "Create no more than 12 slides" keeps the deck focused. Without this constraint, a long document might produce a 25-slide deck that puts your audience to sleep.

Adding and Formatting Slides

After generating an initial deck, you will want to add, modify, or rearrange slides. Copilot handles all of this through the side panel.

Adding slides:

> Add a slide after slide 4 that shows a comparison table of Q1 vs Q2 metrics.
>
> Add a slide with a timeline showing our product roadmap for the next 12 months.
>
> Insert an agenda slide after the title slide.

Modifying existing slides:

> Make slide 3 more concise – reduce the bullet points to three key items.
>
> Rewrite the title of slide 7 to be more engaging.
>
> Add speaker notes to slides 2 through 5.

Reorganizing:

> Move the recommendation slide to the end of the deck.
>
> Remove slides 8 and 9 – they are redundant.

These commands work well for incremental changes. For major restructuring, you might find it faster to use PowerPoint's Slide Sorter view alongside Copilot.

Generating Images for Slides

Copilot can generate images directly within your PowerPoint slides using Microsoft Designer (which is powered by DALL-E). This means you do not need to leave PowerPoint to find or create visuals.

To add an AI-generated image, you can ask Copilot:

> Add an image to slide 3 that illustrates team collaboration in a modern office setting.

> Generate an image for the title slide that shows a futuristic cityscape.

Copilot creates the image and places it on the slide. You can then resize, reposition, or replace it using PowerPoint's normal image tools.

Keep in mind that AI-generated images have a particular look that many people can now recognize. For internal presentations, this is usually fine. For customer-facing or public presentations, you might want to use professional stock photos or your company's own imagery instead.

You can also use Designer (accessible from the Design tab) to suggest layout improvements for slides that already have content. Designer analyzes your text and images and offers alternative layouts that might look more polished.

Design Suggestions and Layout

Beyond generating content, Copilot can help with the visual design of your deck.

Applying themes:

> Apply a professional, corporate design theme to this presentation.
>
> Change the color scheme to match our company colors (navy blue and white).

Improving layouts:

> Suggest a better layout for slide 5 – it has too much text.
>
> Convert the text on slide 6 into a SmartArt diagram.

Consistency checks:

> Review this deck for visual consistency. Are the fonts and colors uniform across all slides?

PowerPoint's Designer feature works alongside Copilot here. When you add content to a slide, Designer automatically suggests layout options in a panel on the right. Between Copilot's structural suggestions and Designer's visual suggestions, you can build a polished deck without any graphic design skills.

Speaker Notes and Presentation Prep

A feature that many people overlook: Copilot can generate speaker notes for your slides.

> Add detailed speaker notes to all slides. Each note should include talking points I can reference during the presentation, approximately 3-4 sentences per slide.

This is enormously helpful when you are building a deck that someone else will present, or when you want a safety net during your own presentation. The notes Copilot generates are reasonably good – they expand on the bullet points on the slide without simply repeating them.

You can also use Copilot to prepare for questions:

> What questions might the audience ask after this presentation? Give me five likely questions and suggested answers.

What Copilot in PowerPoint Cannot Do

It does not create animations or complex transitions. Copilot can add content and suggest layouts, but slide animations, timed transitions, and build sequences are still manual tasks.

It struggles with precise formatting. If you need a chart positioned exactly in the lower-right corner with specific dimensions, you will need to do that manually. Copilot gets you in the right ballpark, but pixel-perfect control requires human hands.

It cannot embed live data. Copilot can create charts in your slides, but they are static. If you need a chart that updates when your Excel data changes, you will need to use PowerPoint's native Excel linking feature.

Design taste is subjective. Copilot's design choices are competent but generic. If your organization has specific brand guidelines, you will need to apply them manually or use a company template as your starting point.

Real-World Workflow: Building a Quarterly Business Review

You are a department head and you need to present your Q1 results to the executive team on Friday. You have a detailed Q1 report in Word and a data spreadsheet in Excel. Here is how to build the deck.

Step 1: Start from Your Report

Open a new PowerPoint presentation. In the Copilot panel, type:

> Create a 15-slide presentation based on /Q1 Department Review.docx. Structure it as follows: title slide, agenda, executive summary, key metrics (3-4 slides), accomplishments, challenges, team highlights, Q2 priorities, and closing slide. Keep the tone professional but confident. This is for an executive audience.

Copilot generates the deck, pulling actual metrics and findings from your report. Review the slides to make sure the key data points are accurate.

Step 2: Add Data Visualizations

The metrics slides need charts. Open Copilot and type:

> On slide 4, add a bar chart comparing Q1 revenue to Q4 of last year. On slide 5, add a line chart showing monthly customer acquisition. Use the data from /Q1 Metrics Dashboard.xlsx.

Copilot creates the charts and places them on the relevant slides.

Step 3: Fix the Problem Slides

Slides 9 and 10 have too much text – Copilot pulled entire paragraphs from your report. Ask:

> Condense slides 9 and 10 to no more than four bullet points each. Keep only the most important information.

Copilot rewrites the slides to be concise.

Step 4: Add a Missing Slide

Your VP asked you to include a competitive landscape. Ask:

> Add a slide after slide 7 that shows a comparison table of our performance vs. two main competitors on these metrics: revenue growth, customer satisfaction, and market share. Use placeholder data that I can fill in.

Copilot creates a table slide with the right structure and placeholder values.

Step 5: Generate Speaker Notes

> Add speaker notes to all slides. For the metrics slides, include specific talking points about what drove the numbers. For the challenges slide, include how I plan to address each issue.

Copilot adds notes you can reference during the presentation.

Step 6: Polish the Design

> Apply a clean, professional design theme. Make sure all slides use the same font and color scheme.

Copilot applies a consistent theme. You can then use Designer for additional layout suggestions on individual slides.

Step 7: Prepare for Q&A

> Based on this presentation, what are the five toughest questions the executive team might ask? Give me suggested responses for each.

Copilot analyzes the content and generates likely questions – about budget overruns, missed targets, or competitive threats – along with suggested responses.

Total time: about 30 minutes for a presentation that would typically take three to four hours to build from scratch.

Key Takeaways

- Copilot can create complete presentations from prompts or from existing documents – the document-based approach often produces better results because it uses your actual content.
- Specify slide count, audience, structure, and design preferences in your prompt for the best output.
- Use Copilot to add, modify, and reorganize slides incrementally after the initial generation.
- AI-generated images are convenient for internal decks but may not suit customer-facing presentations.
- Speaker notes generation is an underused feature that saves significant preparation time.
- Copilot-generated decks are strong starting points, but always review for accuracy, conciseness, and visual consistency before presenting.

Chapter 13: Copilot in Outlook

Email is the one productivity tool that almost everyone uses and almost nobody enjoys. You open your inbox on Monday morning, see 87 unread messages, and feel your energy drain before you have even had your coffee. Half of those emails are threads with 15 replies that you need to catch up on. A quarter require responses you have been putting off because they need careful wording. The rest are noise you need to triage.

Copilot in Outlook addresses all of these problems. It summarizes long threads so you do not have to read every message, drafts replies so you do not start from a blank screen, coaches you on tone so your words land the way you intend, and helps you prioritize what actually needs your attention.

In this chapter, you will learn how to use each of these features, and we will walk through a real-world workflow: managing a busy inbox on a Monday morning.

How Copilot Shows Up in Outlook

Copilot integrates into Outlook in several places, depending on whether you are reading email, writing email, or managing your calendar.

When reading an email or thread, you will see a Copilot summary card at the top of long conversations. For shorter messages, you can click the Copilot button in the ribbon to access the side panel and ask questions about the message.

When composing an email, there is a Copilot icon in the composition toolbar. Click it to get drafting help, or highlight existing text to get rewrite suggestions.

In the calendar view, Copilot can help you prepare for upcoming meetings by summarizing related emails and documents.

Copilot works in Outlook on the web (outlook.office.com), the new Outlook for Windows app, and Outlook for Mac. The classic Outlook desktop app has more limited Copilot integration, so if you are still using the older version, consider switching to the new Outlook for the full experience.

Summarizing Email Threads

This is the feature that will save you the most time, every single day. When you open a long email thread – the kind with 10, 15, or 20 replies going back and forth – Copilot can summarize the entire conversation in seconds.

For threads longer than a few messages, you will often see an automatic summary card at the top of the thread. It looks something like:

> **Summary:** The team discussed the Q2 marketing budget. Sarah proposed a 15% increase, John raised concerns about ROI on digital spend, and the group agreed to revisit after the March metrics are in. No final decision was made.

This summary captures the essential points without requiring you to scroll through every message. For a thread you have been cc'd on but have not been following, this can reduce your catch-up time from ten minutes to ten seconds.

If you want more detail or a different angle, open the Copilot panel and ask:

- "What decisions were made in this thread?"
- "What is being asked of me in this conversation?"
- "Summarize the key disagreements in this thread."
- "What action items came out of this email chain?"
- "What was the last thing agreed upon?"

These targeted questions let you extract exactly the information you need. "What is being asked of me?" is particularly useful – it cuts through the noise and tells you if you actually need to do something, or if the thread is just informational.

When Summarization Works Best

Summarization excels with threaded discussions where multiple people are going back and forth. It handles meeting scheduling threads, project update chains, and decision-making discussions well.

It is less useful for single emails or very short threads where reading the original is just as fast. It can also miss subtlety – if someone made a sarcastic comment or a politically delicate suggestion, Copilot might summarize it too literally or miss the subtext entirely.

Drafting Emails

Starting an email from scratch is one of those tasks that takes longer than it should, especially when the stakes are high. Copilot can draft emails for you based on a description of what you want to say.

When composing a new email, click the Copilot icon in the toolbar and select "Draft with Copilot." Then describe what you want:

> Write a follow-up email to the client thanking them for the meeting last Tuesday, summarizing the three action items we discussed, and proposing a check-in call next week.

Copilot generates a complete email draft. You can then:

- **Keep it** and send as-is (though you should always read it first).
- **Regenerate** to get a different version.
- **Adjust the tone** – options typically include Professional, Casual, Direct, and others.
- **Adjust the length** – make it shorter or longer.
- **Refine with custom instructions** – "Make the closing more warm" or "Add a sentence about the project timeline."

Drafting Replies

Replying to emails is even easier because Copilot has the context of the original message. When you click Reply, the Copilot icon appears in the composition toolbar. Click it, and Copilot suggests a reply based on the conversation.

For simple emails, the suggested reply might be all you need with minor tweaks. For complex responses, give Copilot more direction:

> Draft a reply that politely declines the meeting invitation due to a scheduling conflict, but suggests two alternative times next week (Tuesday or Thursday afternoon). Keep the tone friendly and professional.
>
> Reply agreeing to the proposal but asking for clarification on the budget breakdown in section 3. Express enthusiasm about the partnership.

The key to good drafts is giving Copilot enough context about your intent. “Reply to this email” produces something generic. “Reply agreeing but expressing concern about the timeline” produces something you can actually send.

Referencing Other Content

Like Word, you can reference other Microsoft 365 files in your email drafts. This is useful when you need to summarize something from another document:

> Draft an email to the project team summarizing the key points from /Project Status Update.docx and asking each person to confirm their deliverables by Friday.

Copilot reads the document and incorporates the relevant details into your email.

Coaching on Email Tone

One of Copilot’s more nuanced features in Outlook is coaching. Instead of rewriting your email, it gives you feedback on how your message might be perceived.

After writing an email, click the Copilot icon and select “Coaching by Copilot.” Copilot analyzes your draft and provides suggestions in several areas:

Tone: Is your email too formal? Too casual? Does it sound frustrated or passive-aggressive? Copilot flags language that might not land the way you intend.

Clarity: Are your requests clear? Will the recipient know what you are asking them to do? Copilot identifies vague language and suggests making your asks more specific.

Sentiment: How will this email make the reader feel? Copilot can flag if your message sounds overly negative or if positive elements are missing.

Reader impact: Copilot considers the overall impression and suggests adjustments.

This feature is invaluable in a few specific situations:

- **Emotionally charged emails.** You are frustrated with a coworker and want to make sure your email is firm but professional. Coaching catches phrases that might come across as hostile.
- **Cross-cultural communication.** If you are emailing colleagues in a different country or culture, coaching can help you avoid phrasing that might be misunderstood.
- **High-stakes correspondence.** An email to a client, a senior executive, or HR deserves extra scrutiny. Coaching provides a second pair of eyes before you hit send.

Think of coaching as having a trusted colleague read your email and say, "You might want to rephrase that second paragraph – it comes across a bit harsh." Except this colleague is available 24/7 and never gets tired of reviewing drafts.

Email Organization and Prioritization

Copilot can help you make sense of a crowded inbox by identifying what matters most.

Open the Copilot panel in your inbox and try:

- "What are my most important emails from today?"
- "Do I have any emails that require urgent action?"
- "Summarize what I missed while I was out last Thursday and Friday."
- "Are there any emails I have not responded to that might be time-sensitive?"

These queries help you triage your inbox quickly, especially after a vacation or a day packed with meetings where you could not keep up with email.

Copilot's prioritization is based on factors like who sent the email (your manager's messages rank higher), whether you are directly addressed or just cc'd, and the content of the message (requests with deadlines rank higher than informational updates).

Calendar Assistance

While Copilot's calendar features in Outlook are not as extensive as its email features, there are some useful capabilities.

Meeting preparation. Before a meeting, ask Copilot:

> Summarize all emails related to the Henderson project from the past two weeks so I can prepare for today's meeting.

Copilot gathers relevant threads and gives you a briefing.

Scheduling context. When you receive a meeting invitation, Copilot can provide context:

> What has been discussed in previous meetings with this group?

RSVP assistance. For meeting invitations that require a response, Copilot can help you draft acceptance or decline messages with appropriate context.

What Copilot in Outlook Cannot Do

It does not auto-sort or auto-file emails. Copilot can tell you what is important, but it does not move emails to folders or apply labels automatically. You still need rules and manual organization for that.

It does not handle attachments deeply. Copilot can reference documents stored in OneDrive or SharePoint, but it cannot analyze attachments embedded in emails the same way it can analyze cloud-stored files.

It does not send emails for you. Every draft Copilot generates is a suggestion that you review and send manually. There is no autopilot mode for email, and that is a good thing.

Sensitive content needs caution. If an email thread contains confidential information, remember that Copilot processes that content using Microsoft's AI services. While Microsoft's commercial data protections apply, use judgment about what you ask Copilot to process.

Real-World Workflow: Managing a Busy Monday Inbox

It is Monday morning. You were out on Friday for a personal day, and you have 94 unread emails. Here is how to get through them efficiently with Copilot.

Step 1: Get the Big Picture

Open the Copilot panel in your inbox and type:

> Summarize the most important emails I received on Friday and over the weekend. Highlight anything that requires action from me.

Copilot scans your recent unread emails and gives you a prioritized summary. It might say something like: "Your VP requested the Q1 budget revision by Wednesday. The Henderson client responded to your proposal with questions about pricing. Three team members sent status updates with no action required."

Now you know what to tackle first.

Step 2: Catch Up on Key Threads

The Henderson client thread has 12 messages from Friday. Open it and read the Copilot summary at the top:

> The client is interested in the proposal but has concerns about the implementation timeline and pricing for phase 2. They asked for a revised timeline by Tuesday and requested a call to discuss pricing.

In 15 seconds, you know exactly where things stand. No need to read all 12 messages.

Step 3: Draft Your Priority Responses

The VP needs your budget revision. Click Reply, open Copilot, and type:

> Draft a reply confirming I will have the budget revision ready by Wednesday. Mention that I will include the updated headcount projections we discussed last week. Keep it brief and professional.

Copilot produces a clean, three-sentence reply. Review it, tweak one phrase, and send.

For the Henderson client, you need a more careful response. Click Reply and tell Copilot:

> Draft a reply that acknowledges their timeline concerns, proposes moving the phase 2 start date back by two weeks, and suggests a call on Wednesday or Thursday to discuss pricing in detail. Be warm and reassuring – we want to keep this deal.

Copilot drafts the response. Use coaching to check the tone before sending.

Step 4: Coach Your Tricky Replies

You have an email from a colleague who missed a deadline, and you need to address it without damaging the relationship. Draft your response manually, then click Coaching:

Copilot reviews your draft and points out that the phrase "as I mentioned before" sounds frustrated and might put your colleague on the defensive. It suggests softening the language while keeping the message clear.

Step 5: Triage the Rest

For the remaining 80+ emails, ask Copilot:

> Which of my remaining unread emails are just FYI or informational and do not require a response?

Copilot identifies the status updates, newsletters, and automated notifications. You can scan through those quickly. The ones that need responses, you now have time to address because you handled the high-priority items first.

Step 6: Prepare for Your Afternoon Meeting

You have a project review meeting at 2 PM. Ask Copilot:

> Summarize all emails related to the Apex project from the past week so I can prepare for this afternoon's review meeting.

Copilot pulls together the relevant threads and gives you a briefing you can review over lunch.

Total time to process 94 emails: about 35 minutes, compared to the 90 minutes it would have taken to read and respond to everything manually.

Key Takeaways

- Thread summarization is Copilot's most valuable feature in Outlook – it turns 15-message threads into 3-sentence summaries.
- When drafting emails, give Copilot specific instructions about your intent, audience, and desired tone for the best results.
- Use coaching before sending high-stakes emails – it catches tone issues you might not notice yourself.
- Copilot can prioritize your inbox and identify what needs your attention, which is especially useful after time away.
- Reference Microsoft 365 files in your email drafts to include specific, accurate content from documents and spreadsheets.
- Always review Copilot's drafts before sending. It writes competent emails, but they are your emails once you hit send.

Chapter 14: Copilot in Teams

Microsoft Teams is where work happens in real time – meetings, chats, calls, and channel conversations. It is also where information gets lost. Someone said something important in last Tuesday's meeting, but nobody wrote it down. A decision was made in a chat thread two weeks ago, but now nobody can find it. Action items were assigned verbally, and half of them were forgotten by the time the meeting ended.

Copilot in Teams is designed to solve exactly these problems. It transcribes meetings, generates summaries, tracks action items, and helps you catch up on conversations you missed. If Copilot in Outlook saves you time on email, Copilot in Teams saves you time on everything else.

In this chapter, you will learn how to use Copilot during and after meetings, in chat conversations, and with channel agents. We will finish with a real-world workflow: running a productive meeting from start to finish.

Where Copilot Shows Up in Teams

Copilot is woven throughout the Teams experience in several places:

In meetings: During a live meeting, Copilot can listen in real time and answer questions about what has been discussed. After the meeting, it provides a summary with key points, action items, and follow-ups.

In chat: For one-on-one and group chats, Copilot can summarize conversations, highlight key decisions, and help you catch up on threads you have missed.

In channels: Copilot can summarize channel conversations and highlight important posts. Channel agents extend this further with automated workflows.

In the Copilot app within Teams: You can open Copilot as a standalone app inside Teams and ask questions that span your entire Microsoft 365 environment – emails, files, chats, and calendar.

Copilot in Meetings: Before the Meeting

Copilot can help you prepare before a meeting even starts.

If the meeting has an agenda attached, previous meeting notes, or related email threads, you can ask Copilot:

> What do I need to know before my 2 PM meeting with the product team?

Copilot gathers context from your calendar invitation, any attached documents, relevant email threads, and previous meeting summaries (if you have had recurring meetings with the same group). It produces a briefing that might include:

- The meeting agenda
- Open action items from the last meeting
- Key topics discussed in related emails this week
- Documents that were recently shared with the meeting participants

This is the kind of preparation that most people skip because it takes too long. With Copilot, it takes about 30 seconds.

Copilot in Meetings: During the Meeting

This is where Copilot becomes genuinely transformative. During a live meeting, Copilot listens to the conversation (via transcription) and can answer questions in real time.

Enabling Copilot in a Meeting

For Copilot to work during a meeting, transcription must be enabled. The meeting organizer can turn on transcription, or it may be enabled by default depending on your organization's settings. When transcription starts, participants are notified – this is a privacy requirement, and it cannot be disabled silently.

Once transcription is running, Copilot is available in the meeting toolbar. Click the Copilot icon to open its panel.

Real-Time Questions

During the meeting, you can ask Copilot questions without interrupting the conversation. These questions are private – only you see the answers. This is incredibly useful when you zone out for a minute, get distracted by a Slack notification (it happens), or join a meeting late.

Try questions like:

- "What has been discussed so far?"
- "What did Sarah say about the budget?"
- "Has anyone mentioned the timeline for phase 2?"
- "What questions have been raised?"
- "Summarize the last 10 minutes."

Copilot answers based on the live transcription. This means you can catch up on anything you missed without asking someone to repeat themselves.

Limitations During Live Meetings

Copilot's real-time accuracy depends on transcription quality. If speakers have heavy accents, talk over each other, or have poor audio quality, the transcription may be imperfect, and Copilot's answers will reflect those imperfections.

Also, Copilot can only reference what has been said in the current meeting. It does not have access to side conversations, private chats, or thoughts that participants have not vocalized. If a decision was made through a nod and a thumbs-up, Copilot does not capture it.

Copilot in Meetings: After the Meeting

This is where most people get the most value. After a meeting ends (with transcription enabled), Copilot generates a meeting summary that includes:

Recap: A narrative summary of what was discussed, organized by topic. This is not a transcript – it is a structured summary that captures the key points without the filler.

Action items: Copilot identifies tasks that were assigned during the meeting and attributes them to specific people. “John will send the revised proposal by Friday” shows up as an action item assigned to John.

Key decisions: If the group reached a decision during the meeting, Copilot highlights it. “The team decided to move forward with vendor B for the infrastructure upgrade” becomes a documented decision.

Follow-ups: Copilot identifies topics that need further discussion or items that were deferred to a future meeting.

Accessing the Summary

After the meeting, go to the meeting in your Teams calendar and click on the Recap tab. You will see the Copilot summary along with the full transcript. You can also ask Copilot follow-up questions:

- “What did the group agree to regarding the launch date?”
- “Who is responsible for the next steps?”
- “Were there any disagreements during the meeting?”
- “What topics were not covered that were on the agenda?”

Sharing Meeting Notes

The meeting summary can be shared with participants and even with people who did not attend. This is useful for stakeholders who could not make the meeting but need to stay informed.

You can copy the summary to a Teams chat, email it through Outlook, or paste it into a document. Some organizations have set up workflows where meeting summaries automatically post to a Teams channel for visibility.

Transcription and Intelligent Recap

Behind the scenes, Copilot’s meeting features are powered by transcription and what Microsoft calls Intelligent Recap.

Transcription converts spoken words to text in real time. Teams identifies different speakers and labels them in the transcript, so you can see who said what. The transcript is available after the meeting in the Recap tab.

Intelligent Recap is the AI layer that analyzes the transcript and produces the structured summary, action items, and key decisions. It goes beyond simple transcription by understanding context – it knows the difference between someone saying "we should probably update the website" (a suggestion) and "I will update the website by Thursday" (an action item).

Transcription supports dozens of languages, and the quality has improved significantly over the past two years. For most meetings conducted in a supported language with decent audio, the transcription is highly accurate.

Chat Summarization

Teams chats can get long, especially in group chats where people are collaborating throughout the day. Coming back to a chat with 75 new messages and trying to figure out what happened is no one's idea of a good time.

Copilot in chat helps you catch up quickly. In a chat conversation, click the Copilot icon and ask:

- "What have I missed in this chat today?"
- "Summarize the key points from the last 24 hours."
- "Were any decisions made in this chat this week?"
- "What files were shared in this chat recently?"

Copilot reads through the messages and gives you a structured summary. This works for both one-on-one chats and group chats.

You can also ask specific questions about past conversations:

- "Did anyone mention the Henderson project in this chat?"
- "What did the team decide about the new feature requirements?"
- "When is the next deadline mentioned in this chat?"

Chat summarization is especially useful for group chats that serve as informal coordination channels. These chats often contain important decisions buried between casual messages, status updates, and the occasional off-topic discussion. Copilot pulls out the signal from the noise.

Channel Agents

Channels in Teams are where teams organize conversations by topic or project. Copilot can help you manage channels, but a more powerful feature is channel agents.

Channel agents are Copilot-powered bots that can be added to a Teams channel to automate specific tasks. They can:

- **Answer questions from channel content.** An agent can be configured to answer questions based on documents and conversations in the channel. New team members can ask the agent for context instead of scrolling through months of history.
- **Surface relevant information.** An agent can monitor the channel and highlight posts that meet certain criteria – for example, flagging messages that contain deadlines or decisions.
- **Automate routine tasks.** Agents can be set up to perform standard workflows, like creating a task in Planner when someone posts a message in a specific format.

Setting up a channel agent is done through the Teams admin interface or through Copilot Studio, and the complexity ranges from simple (a Q&A bot based on channel content) to sophisticated (a multi-step agent that integrates with external systems).

For most users, the key thing to know is that channel agents exist and can save significant time for teams that use channels heavily. If your team has a channel where the same questions get asked repeatedly, or where important information gets buried in conversation flow, a channel agent can help.

The Copilot App in Teams

Beyond meetings, chats, and channels, you can open Copilot as a standalone app within Teams. This gives you access to the full Copilot experience without leaving Teams.

The Copilot app in Teams can:

- Search across your emails, files, chats, and calendar
- Summarize documents stored in SharePoint or OneDrive
- Draft content based on information from multiple sources
- Answer questions about your organization's shared knowledge

This is useful when you need information that spans multiple sources. For example:

> What has the team discussed about the Apex project in the last two weeks? Check emails, chats, and meeting transcripts.

Copilot aggregates information from across your Microsoft 365 environment and presents a unified summary. This cross-app search is one of Copilot's genuine advantages over standalone AI tools that do not have access to your organizational data.

What Copilot in Teams Cannot Do

It requires transcription for meeting features. If transcription is not enabled, Copilot cannot summarize meetings or track action items. Some organizations disable transcription for compliance or privacy reasons, which effectively turns off Copilot's meeting features.

It does not join external meetings automatically. If you are in a meeting hosted by someone outside your organization, Copilot may not be available depending on the host's settings.

Action items are suggestions, not commitments. Copilot identifies what it thinks are action items, but it does not create tasks in Planner or To Do automatically

(unless an agent is configured to do so). The people involved still need to follow through.

It cannot read the room. Copilot captures words, not tone, body language, or political dynamics. A meeting summary might miss that half the team looked skeptical during the proposal, or that the VP's silence on a topic was itself a statement.

Real-World Workflow: Running a Productive Meeting

You are leading a weekly project status meeting with eight team members. Here is how to use Copilot to make it the most productive meeting of the week.

Before the Meeting

Open Copilot in Teams and type:

> Prepare me for today's 10 AM project sync. What were the action items from last week's meeting, and have any of them been discussed in chat or email since then?

Copilot pulls up last week's action items and checks whether team members have followed up. You now know who completed their tasks and who you need to check in with.

Starting the Meeting

When the meeting starts, make sure transcription is enabled (it should be by default for recurring meetings if your admin has configured it). Copilot will appear in the meeting toolbar.

During the Meeting

As the discussion progresses, you are facilitating and cannot take detailed notes. That is fine – Copilot is capturing everything.

Midway through, a team member references a decision from three weeks ago that you do not remember. Without interrupting the flow, you ask Copilot privately:

> What did we decide about the API integration approach in our meeting on March 10th?

Copilot checks the previous meeting's transcript and provides the answer. You stay informed without derailing the current conversation.

Near the end of the meeting, someone proposes changing the project timeline. You want to make sure the implications are understood before the meeting ends:

> What action items have been discussed so far in this meeting?

Copilot lists the action items it has identified. You read them aloud to the group: "Before we wrap up, let me confirm the action items..." This ensures everyone is aligned.

After the Meeting

Within a few minutes of the meeting ending, Copilot generates the Intelligent Recap. Review it in the Recap tab. The summary includes:

- Four key topics discussed
- Six action items with names and deadlines
- Two decisions made
- One topic deferred to next week

Copy the summary and paste it into the project's Teams channel:

> Here are the notes from today's sync: [paste Copilot summary]

Team members who missed the meeting can read the summary and know exactly what happened. Those who attended have a clear record of their commitments.

Following Up

Two days later, you want to check on progress. Open Copilot in Teams and ask:

> Have any of the action items from Monday's project sync been discussed in our team chat or email since the meeting?

Copilot checks the relevant conversations and tells you that three of the six items have been mentioned, with one marked as complete. You follow up with the team members who have not reported progress.

Total time spent on meeting management: about 15 minutes across the entire week, compared to the hour or more it typically takes to prepare agendas, take notes, distribute minutes, and follow up on action items.

Key Takeaways

- Copilot in Teams requires transcription to be enabled for meeting features – make sure your organization allows it.
- Real-time questions during meetings let you catch up privately without disrupting the conversation.
- Meeting summaries with action items, decisions, and follow-ups replace the need for manual note-taking.
- Chat summarization helps you catch up on group conversations without reading every message.
- Channel agents can automate routine tasks and answer questions based on channel content.
- The Copilot app in Teams searches across your entire Microsoft 365 environment – emails, files, chats, and meetings.
- Copilot captures words, not context. Always review summaries for accuracy and completeness before sharing them as official meeting notes.

Chapter 15: Image Generation with Designer

Until recently, if you needed a custom image – for a presentation, a social media post, a blog, or an internal document – you had three options: hire a designer, use a stock photo, or spend an hour fumbling with Canva. Copilot gives you a fourth option: describe the image you want, and AI creates it for you.

Microsoft Copilot's image generation is powered by Designer, Microsoft's creative AI tool, which uses DALL-E (the image generation model from OpenAI) under the hood. You can create images directly from the Copilot chat interface or through the Designer app. The results range from surprisingly good to occasionally bizarre, and knowing how to prompt effectively makes the difference between the two.

In this chapter, you will learn how to create images from text descriptions, edit and iterate on your results, work with style options, understand the limits of image generation, and identify practical use cases. We will close with a walkthrough: creating a social media graphic from scratch.

How Image Generation Works in Copilot

You can generate images in several places:

In the Copilot chat (at copilot.microsoft.com, the Copilot app, or the Edge sidebar): Just ask Copilot to create an image. Type something like "Create an image of a mountain landscape at sunset" and Copilot generates the image right in the conversation.

In Microsoft Designer (designer.microsoft.com): This is Microsoft's dedicated design tool, and it offers more control over image generation, editing, and design templates. You can create images from text prompts and then place them into pre-designed templates for social media, presentations, flyers, and more.

In PowerPoint: As we covered in Chapter 12, Copilot can generate images directly within your slides.

In Word: You can ask Copilot to generate images to include in documents, though this is less commonly used than in presentations.

When you type an image prompt, Copilot sends it to DALL-E, which generates one or more images based on your description. The images are original creations – they are not pulled from a stock photo library or assembled from existing images. Each one is generated from scratch based on the patterns DALL-E learned during training.

Creating Images from Text Descriptions

The quality of your image depends almost entirely on how you describe what you want. Vague prompts produce vague results. Specific prompts produce specific results. Here is how to write better image prompts.

Start with the Subject

What is the main thing in the image? Be concrete.

- Weak: "A person working"
- Better: "A woman in her 30s sitting at a modern desk with a laptop, wearing business casual clothing"

Add the Setting

Where does this scene take place?

- Weak: "In an office"
- Better: "In a bright, open-plan office with floor-to-ceiling windows and plants on the windowsill"

Specify the Style

What should the image look like? Photorealistic? Illustration? Watercolor? Flat design?

- "Photorealistic photograph"

- “Minimalist flat illustration”
- “Watercolor painting style”
- “3D render”
- “Pencil sketch”

Include Lighting and Mood

These details dramatically affect the result.

- “Warm golden hour lighting”
- “Bright, even studio lighting”
- “Dramatic shadows with a single light source”
- “Soft, dreamy lighting with pastel tones”

Describe the Composition

How should the image be framed?

- “Close-up portrait”
- “Wide-angle landscape shot”
- “Top-down flat lay”
- “Isometric view”

A Complete Example

Putting it all together:

> Create a photorealistic image of a diverse team of four people having a productive meeting in a modern glass-walled conference room. They are looking at a presentation on a large screen. The lighting is bright and natural, coming from large windows. The mood is collaborative and energetic. Shot from a slightly elevated angle.

This gives DALL-E enough detail to produce a focused, professional result.

Editing and Iterating on Images

Your first result will rarely be exactly what you want. Copilot makes it easy to iterate.

After an image is generated, you can:

Ask for modifications in the conversation:

- "Make the background lighter."
- "Remove the text in the image."
- "Change the woman's shirt to blue."
- "Make this more minimalist."
- "Add a coffee cup to the desk."

Copilot generates a new version based on your modifications. Each iteration is a fresh generation – Copilot does not actually edit the pixels of the existing image but creates a new one incorporating your feedback.

Request variations:

- "Give me three more versions of this image."
- "Show me the same scene but in a different art style."
- "Create a version of this with a warmer color palette."

Start over with adjusted prompts:

If the image is heading in the wrong direction, rewrite your prompt entirely rather than trying to fix individual details. Sometimes a fresh start with a better description is faster than iterating on a flawed image.

Working in Designer

Microsoft Designer offers more sophisticated editing tools than the basic Copilot chat. In Designer, you can:

- **Remove backgrounds** from generated images.
- **Add text overlays** with professional typography.

- **Place images into templates** – social media posts, flyers, invitations, and more.
- **Adjust colors, filters, and effects** with visual controls.
- **Resize images** for different platforms (Instagram square, Facebook cover, LinkedIn post, etc.).

If you are creating images for professional use, generating the base image in Copilot chat and then polishing it in Designer is often the most efficient workflow.

Style Options

DALL-E can produce images in a wide range of styles. Here are some effective style keywords to include in your prompts:

Photographic styles: - Professional headshot - Editorial photography - Product photography on white background - Documentary/candid style - Aerial/drone photography

Illustration styles: - Flat vector illustration - Hand-drawn sketch - Watercolor painting - Digital art - Pixel art - Comic book style - Infographic style

Design styles: - Minimalist - Retro/vintage - Corporate/professional - Whimsical - Abstract geometric

Artistic references: - Art deco - Mid-century modern - Impressionist - Pop art

Mixing styles can produce interesting results. “A watercolor illustration of a cityscape in the style of art deco” is a valid prompt that produces distinctive output.

Image Generation Limits and Boosts

Image generation is not unlimited. Microsoft uses a system of “boosts” to manage usage.

What are boosts? Each image generation uses one or more boosts. When you run out of boosts, you can still generate images, but they will be created more slowly (put in a queue rather than generated immediately).

How many boosts do you get? This varies by plan:

- **Free Copilot users:** A limited number of daily boosts (the exact number changes, but it is typically around 15).
- **Copilot Pro / Microsoft 365 Premium subscribers:** More boosts per day (typically around 100).
- **Microsoft 365 Copilot for Business/Enterprise:** Boosts are included as part of the license.

When do boosts reset? Boosts reset daily, though the exact reset time depends on your region.

What happens when you run out? Your images still generate, but they go into a slower queue. Instead of appearing in seconds, they might take a minute or more. The quality is the same – only the speed changes.

For most casual users, the daily boost allocation is sufficient. If you are generating large volumes of images (for a marketing campaign or a content library), you might hit the limit and need to spread your work across multiple days.

Practical Use Cases

Let us be honest about what AI image generation is good for and where it falls short.

Where It Works Well

Social media content. Blog post headers, social media graphics, and promotional images are a great fit. The images need to be eye-catching and relevant, but they do not need to be photographically accurate.

Presentations. Custom illustrations for slides are better than generic stock photos because they match your specific content. A presentation about “team collaboration”

with a custom-generated illustration looks more intentional than one with a stock photo everyone has seen a hundred times.

Concept visualization. If you are describing a future product, an event layout, or a design concept, AI-generated images can communicate your vision before anything is built.

Internal documents. Reports, newsletters, and internal communications benefit from visual variety. AI-generated images add polish without the cost of custom photography or illustration.

Brainstorming. When you are exploring visual directions – "What would our brand look like in a retro style?" – image generation lets you experiment quickly.

Where It Falls Short

Text in images. DALL-E struggles with text. It might misspell words, distort letters, or place text in awkward positions. If you need text in your image, generate the image without text and add text later in Designer or another tool.

Precise brand assets. If you need an image that exactly matches your brand guidelines – specific hex colors, logo placement, precise typography – AI generation is not reliable enough. Use it for concept exploration, then hand the direction to a designer.

Photographs of real people or products. AI-generated "photos" of people can look uncanny, and generating images of existing products may not be accurate. For product photography, use actual photographs.

Legal and compliance contexts. Images generated by AI should not be used where photographic evidence is required (insurance claims, legal documents, etc.). The images are fabrications, not documentation.

Sensitive subjects. DALL-E has content filters that prevent generation of violent, explicit, or harmful content. It also has restrictions around generating images of real, identifiable people.

Content Policies and Ethical Considerations

Microsoft applies content policies to image generation. You cannot generate:

- Images of real, named individuals
- Violent or graphic content
- Explicit or adult content
- Content that promotes hate or discrimination
- Misleading content designed to look like real photographs for deceptive purposes

These restrictions are enforced automatically. If your prompt triggers a content filter, Copilot will decline the request and may suggest an alternative prompt.

Additionally, AI-generated images should be used transparently. If you publish an AI-generated image, it is good practice (and in some contexts, a legal requirement) to disclose that it was AI-generated. Microsoft adds invisible metadata to DALL-E-generated images indicating they are AI-created, but visible disclosure is still recommended for public-facing content.

Walkthrough: Creating a Social Media Graphic

You are a marketing coordinator and you need a graphic for a LinkedIn post announcing your company's new sustainability initiative. Here is how to create it.

Step 1: Generate the Base Image

Open Copilot and type:

> Create a modern, professional illustration of a green city with renewable energy elements – solar panels, wind turbines, electric vehicles, and green rooftops. Use a clean, flat illustration style with a bright, optimistic color palette of greens, blues, and whites. The composition should be a wide landscape format suitable for a LinkedIn post.

Copilot generates the image. Review it – is the mood right? Are the elements you specified present?

Step 2: Iterate

The first result is close but the colors are too dark. Ask:

> Make the color palette brighter and more vibrant. Add more white space so there is room to overlay text.

Copilot generates a revised version with a lighter, more open composition.

Step 3: Polish in Designer

Open Microsoft Designer and upload or open the image you generated. From here:

- Choose a LinkedIn post template.
- Place your image as the background.
- Add a text overlay: "Building a Greener Future – Our 2026 Sustainability Commitment."
- Adjust the text color for readability against the illustration.
- Add your company logo in the corner.

Step 4: Resize for Other Platforms

In Designer, resize the graphic for Instagram (square), X (16:9), and your website banner (wide format). Designer adjusts the layout while keeping the key elements visible.

Step 5: Download and Post

Export the final graphics in the appropriate formats and post them to your social channels.

Total time: about 15 minutes, compared to one to two hours of searching for stock photos, negotiating with a designer, or wrestling with Canva templates.

Key Takeaways

- Copilot generates images using DALL-E through the Copilot chat interface and Microsoft Designer.
- Detailed prompts produce dramatically better results – specify subject, setting, style, lighting, and composition.
- Iterate on images by requesting modifications, variations, or starting fresh with a better prompt.
- Designer adds text, templates, background removal, and resizing tools on top of basic image generation.
- Image generation works well for social media, presentations, concept visualization, and internal documents – it is less suited for precise brand assets or photographs of real subjects.
- Text in AI-generated images is unreliable – add text afterward using Designer or another tool.
- Be aware of content policies and ethical considerations, especially when publishing AI-generated images publicly.

Chapter 16: Copilot Pages and Notebooks

Up to this point, every interaction you have had with Copilot has followed the same basic pattern: you type a prompt, Copilot responds, and the conversation scrolls downward into the chat history. It works, but it has a limitation – chat is linear. You cannot easily reorganize a chat response, expand on one section while leaving others alone, or share a specific part of the conversation with a colleague who can then build on it.

Pages and Notebooks change this. They take Copilot's output out of the chat window and into workspaces where you can edit, organize, collaborate, and build on AI-generated content in a more structured way. Think of them as the bridge between having a conversation with AI and actually producing something useful from that conversation.

In this chapter, you will learn what Pages and Notebooks are, how they differ from each other and from standard chat, how to create and share them, and how to use their collaboration features. We will finish with a real-world workflow: building a collaborative research document with your team.

What Are Copilot Pages?

Pages are a collaborative AI canvas. When Copilot generates a response in chat that you want to work with more seriously – edit it, share it, or expand on it – you can send that response to a Page.

A Page looks like a lightweight document. It has a clean editing surface where you can add text, format content, and restructure information. But unlike a Word document, a Page stays connected to Copilot. You can ask Copilot to add more content, rewrite sections, or generate new material – all within the Page itself.

Here is the key differentiator: Pages are collaborative. You can share a Page with other people, and they can edit it alongside you, much like a shared Google Doc or a collaborative Word document. But everyone on the Page also has access to Copilot, so multiple people can use AI to contribute to the same document simultaneously.

Creating a Page

There are two main ways to create a Page:

From a chat response: When Copilot generates a response that you want to develop further, look for the "Edit in Pages" button (or similar option) below the response. Click it, and the response opens in a new Page. You can then edit, expand, and share it.

From scratch: In the Copilot app (copilot.microsoft.com or the Copilot app in Teams), you can create a new Page directly. Start with a prompt, and instead of keeping the output in chat, direct it to a Page.

What You Can Do in a Page

Once you are in a Page, you have several tools available:

Direct editing: Click anywhere in the text and type. You can add, delete, and modify content just like in any editor. This is the fundamental difference from chat – you are not stuck with Copilot's exact output.

Copilot assistance: Ask Copilot to add content to the Page, rewrite sections, or answer follow-up questions. The AI-generated content appears in the Page, where you can immediately edit it.

Formatting: Pages support headings, bullet points, numbered lists, tables, and basic formatting. It is not as full-featured as Word, but it covers most needs for working documents.

Sharing: Share the Page with specific people in your organization. They get a link and can view or edit the Page depending on the permissions you set.

Real-time collaboration: When multiple people have edit access to a Page, they can work on it simultaneously. Each person can also invoke Copilot independently, so one person might be asking Copilot to expand the introduction while another is asking it to generate a comparison table.

What Are Copilot Notebooks?

Notebooks serve a different purpose than Pages. While Pages are about collaboration and lightweight editing, Notebooks are designed for long-form content generation – situations where you need Copilot to produce substantial output that goes beyond what fits comfortably in a chat response.

Standard Copilot chat has limits on how long a response can be. If you ask Copilot to "write a 5,000-word report," the chat response will typically cap out well before 5,000 words. Notebooks remove this constraint. They give Copilot more room to generate longer, more detailed content.

When to Use a Notebook

Use a Notebook when:

- You need long-form content: comprehensive reports, detailed analyses, extended guides, or thorough explanations.
- You want to provide a longer, more detailed prompt without the constraints of the chat input box.
- You need to generate content that will serve as a starting point for a longer document (which you might then move to Word for final formatting).

How Notebooks Work

Open a Notebook from the Copilot interface (look for the Notebook option in the app menu or conversation toolbar). You will see a split view:

The prompt area: On one side, you have a large text input area where you can write detailed prompts. Unlike chat, where you type a sentence or two, the Notebook prompt area encourages you to write longer, more detailed instructions.

The output area: On the other side, Copilot generates its response. This area supports longer output than standard chat, and you can edit the output directly.

Here is an example of how you might use a Notebook:

In the prompt area, you write:

> Write a comprehensive guide to onboarding new employees at a mid-size technology company. Include sections on: pre-arrival preparation, first day activities, first week goals, 30-60-90 day milestones, buddy and mentor programs, tools and systems setup, cultural integration, and measuring onboarding success. Each section should be 400-600 words with specific, actionable recommendations. The audience is HR managers who are building or improving their onboarding process.

Copilot generates a detailed, multi-section document in the output area. You can then edit the output directly, ask Copilot to revise specific sections, or copy the content to Word for final polishing.

Pages vs. Notebooks vs. Standard Chat

Understanding when to use each format will save you time and frustration.

Standard Chat

Best for: Quick questions, short tasks, brainstorming, getting a fast answer.

Limitations: Linear conversation flow. Limited response length. Cannot be collaboratively edited. Content is tied to the conversation thread.

Example use: "What are the top five project management methodologies?" or "Draft a short email declining a meeting invitation."

Pages

Best for: Working with AI output collaboratively. Editing and refining Copilot responses. Sharing AI-assisted content with colleagues. Building a document together with AI support.

Limitations: Less formatting control than Word. Not designed for very long documents. Collaboration features depend on your organization's Microsoft 365 setup.

Example use: Your team is brainstorming a new product strategy. One person prompts Copilot for a competitive analysis, another asks for a SWOT analysis, and a

third asks for customer persona summaries. All of this lands in a shared Page where the team can edit, reorganize, and refine.

Notebooks

Best for: Long-form content generation. Detailed prompts that require extended instructions. Creating first drafts of substantial documents.

Limitations: Less collaborative than Pages. Primarily a single-user tool for generating content. Output still needs to be moved to Word, PowerPoint, or another tool for final formatting.

Example use: You need a 3,000-word first draft of a policy document, a comprehensive analysis of a market segment, or a detailed training guide.

A Simple Decision Framework

- Need a quick answer? **Chat.**
- Need to work with AI output and share it? **Pages.**
- Need a long, detailed document? **Notebooks.**
- Need a final, polished, formatted document? Start in **Notebooks**, finish in **Word.**

Collaboration Features in Pages

Let us dig deeper into how collaboration works in Pages, because this is the feature that distinguishes Pages from every other Copilot surface.

Sharing and Permissions

When you create a Page, you can share it by clicking the Share button and entering the names or email addresses of colleagues in your organization. You can set permissions to:

- **Can edit:** The person can modify the Page content and use Copilot within the Page.
- **Can view:** The person can read the Page but cannot make changes.

Shared Pages appear in the recipients' Copilot app, so they can easily find and access them.

Working Together in Real Time

When multiple people are editing a Page simultaneously, you can see each other's cursors and changes in real time (similar to co-authoring in Word or Google Docs). Each person can also use Copilot independently – you might be asking Copilot to generate a budget breakdown while your colleague asks it to draft an executive summary. Both outputs appear in the Page, and either person can edit either section.

This creates a genuinely new workflow: **collaborative AI-assisted writing.** Instead of one person drafting a document and sending it around for edits, the entire team builds the document together, with each person using AI to accelerate their contribution.

Practical Collaboration Scenarios

Meeting follow-ups. After a meeting, share a Page with all attendees. One person asks Copilot to summarize the meeting notes (from a Teams transcript or a shared document). Others add their own notes, action items, and follow-up questions. The Page becomes the living document for the meeting's outcomes.

Project planning. Create a Page for a new project. One team member prompts Copilot for a project charter template. Another asks for a risk assessment. A third generates a timeline. Everyone edits and refines together.

Content creation. A marketing team is creating a blog series. They share a Page where each person is responsible for a different topic. Each person uses Copilot to generate their draft, and the team edits each other's work in the same Page.

Tips for Getting the Most Out of Pages and Notebooks

Start in chat, move to Pages. Do not go directly to Pages for every task. Start with a quick chat prompt to see if Copilot understands what you want. Once you get a response that is heading in the right direction, move it to a Page for refinement.

Use Notebooks for the heavy lifting. If you know you need long-form content, go straight to a Notebook. Write a detailed prompt and let Copilot generate a comprehensive response. Then move the output to a Page (for collaboration) or to Word (for final formatting).

Do not over-collaborate. Pages are great for teams, but having too many people editing simultaneously can create confusion. Two to four collaborators is usually the sweet spot. For larger teams, consider having one person consolidate input from a shared Page into a final document.

Save important Pages. Pages can be easy to lose track of if you create many of them. Name your Pages clearly and organize them by project or topic. The Copilot app shows your recent Pages, but a meaningful title helps when you are looking for something specific.

Iterate on Notebook prompts. The prompt area in Notebooks is large for a reason – use it. A detailed, well-structured prompt produces dramatically better output than a brief one. If your first result is not right, revise the prompt rather than trying to fix the output.

Real-World Workflow: Collaborative Research Document

Your team of four people needs to produce a competitive analysis report for an upcoming strategy meeting. Here is how to use Pages and Notebooks together.

Step 1: Generate the Framework in a Notebook

One team member opens a Notebook and writes a detailed prompt:

> Create a competitive analysis framework for a B2B SaaS company in the project management space. Include these sections: Market Overview, Competitor Profiles (analyze Asana, Monday.com, Jira, and ClickUp), Feature Comparison Matrix, Pricing Comparison, Strengths and Weaknesses for each competitor, Market Trends, and Strategic Recommendations. For each competitor profile, include company background, target market, key features, recent developments, and market position. Make the analysis approximately 2,500 words.

Copilot generates a comprehensive framework. The team member reviews it, makes initial edits, and copies the content.

Step 2: Move to a Shared Page

The team member creates a Page, pastes the content from the Notebook, and shares it with the other three team members with editing permissions.

Step 3: Divide and Conquer

Each team member takes responsibility for a section:

- Person A refines the Market Overview, asking Copilot: "Expand the market overview with current market size and growth projections for the project management SaaS space."
- Person B works on the Competitor Profiles, asking Copilot: "Update the Asana profile with their latest product announcements and pricing changes."
- Person C builds out the Feature Comparison Matrix, asking Copilot: "Create a detailed comparison table of features across all four competitors, including task management, reporting, integrations, and mobile capabilities."
- Person D focuses on Strategic Recommendations, asking Copilot: "Based on the competitor analysis above, generate five strategic recommendations for differentiation."

All four people are working simultaneously in the same Page. They can see each other's contributions and edits in real time.

Step 4: Review and Refine Together

The team reviews the complete document together. They ask Copilot for a final pass:

> Review this competitive analysis for consistency in tone and depth. Are there any gaps in the analysis that should be addressed?

Copilot identifies a few areas that need more detail and suggests additions.

Step 5: Move to Word for Final Formatting

Once the content is solid, one team member copies the Page content into a Word document, applies the company's formatting template, adds a cover page and table of contents, and prepares it for distribution.

Total time: about two hours for a comprehensive competitive analysis that would typically take one to two days of individual research and writing.

Key Takeaways

- Pages are collaborative AI canvases – edit, share, and co-author content with Copilot assistance in real time.
- Notebooks are designed for long-form content generation, allowing longer prompts and longer outputs than standard chat.
- Use chat for quick tasks, Pages for collaborative work, and Notebooks for substantial content generation.
- Pages support real-time collaboration where multiple people can edit and use Copilot simultaneously.
- Start in chat or Notebooks, then move to Pages for refinement and collaboration, and to Word for final formatting.
- Name and organize your Pages clearly to keep track of them as you create more.

Chapter 17: Think Deeper – Extended Reasoning

Most of the time, Copilot responds to your prompts in a few seconds. You ask a question, it generates an answer, and the conversation moves forward. For everyday tasks – drafting emails, summarizing documents, answering factual questions – this speed is exactly what you want.

But some questions deserve more than a fast answer. When you are wrestling with a complex decision, analyzing a nuanced problem, or trying to think through a multi-step challenge, a quick response from Copilot can feel shallow. It gives you an answer, but not necessarily a well-reasoned one. It might miss edge cases, overlook tradeoffs, or skip important considerations that a more careful thinker would catch.

Think Deeper is Copilot's answer to this problem. It is an extended reasoning mode that takes longer – sometimes 30 seconds, sometimes a full minute or more – but produces responses that are more thorough, more nuanced, and more carefully reasoned. Under the hood, Think Deeper uses specialized reasoning models (from OpenAI's o-series and GPT-5.4 Thinking models) that are designed to work through complex problems step by step before generating a final answer.

In this chapter, you will learn what Think Deeper is, when to use it, what kinds of problems it handles well, and what its current limitations are. We will close with practical examples that show the difference Think Deeper makes.

What Think Deeper Actually Does

When you use Think Deeper, Copilot does not just generate a response – it reasons through the problem first. Think of it as the difference between someone answering your question off the top of their head versus sitting down, thinking for a while, and then giving you a considered response.

Technically, Think Deeper uses what are called “reasoning models” or “thinking models.” These models spend additional compute time working through the problem internally before producing output. The model essentially creates an internal chain of thought: it considers different angles, evaluates potential answers, checks its own reasoning for errors, and then produces a final response that reflects this deeper analysis.

You do not see the full internal reasoning process (though Copilot sometimes shows a brief “thinking” summary). What you see is the final result, which is typically longer, more structured, and more carefully argued than a standard response.

Speed vs. Depth

The tradeoff is straightforward: Think Deeper is slower. A standard Copilot response takes two to five seconds. A Think Deeper response might take 15 to 60 seconds, or occasionally even longer for particularly complex problems. This is not a bug – it is the point. The model is using that time to think more carefully.

This means Think Deeper is not appropriate for every question. If you ask “What time is it in Tokyo?” or “Write a short thank-you email,” Think Deeper is overkill. You are waiting longer for no meaningful improvement in quality. Save Think Deeper for the questions where depth actually matters.

How to Activate Think Deeper

In the Copilot interface, you will see a model selector that lets you choose between conversation modes. The exact interface varies slightly depending on whether you are using Copilot on the web, in the app, or within Microsoft 365, but the core options are:

Auto: Copilot automatically decides which model to use based on the complexity of your prompt. For simple questions, it uses a faster model. For complex ones, it may use a reasoning model. This is the default and works well for most people most of the time.

Quick Response: Forces Copilot to use a fast model. Responses are quick but may lack depth on complex topics. Good for simple tasks where speed matters.

Think Deeper: Forces Copilot to use its most capable reasoning model. Responses take longer but are more thorough. Use this when you specifically want deeper analysis.

To select Think Deeper, click the model selector (usually near the text input area) and choose Think Deeper before submitting your prompt. You can switch back to Auto or Quick Response at any time.

When to Use Think Deeper

Think Deeper earns its keep in specific situations. Here are the categories where it consistently outperforms standard responses.

Complex Analysis and Decision-Making

When you are evaluating options that involve multiple variables, tradeoffs, and consequences, Think Deeper produces significantly better output.

Example prompt for standard Copilot: > Should our company switch from Slack to Microsoft Teams?

Standard response: You get a list of pros and cons – maybe five bullet points for each. It is helpful but surface-level.

The same prompt with Think Deeper: You get a structured analysis that considers your specific situation (if you provide context), weighs factors like cost, user experience, integration with existing tools, migration complexity, training requirements, and organizational change management. It might identify tradeoffs you had not considered and suggest a phased approach with specific evaluation criteria.

Multi-Step Problem Solving

When a question requires working through several logical steps to reach a conclusion, Think Deeper handles the chain of reasoning more reliably.

> We are launching a product in three markets simultaneously: US, UK, and Japan. Each market has different regulatory requirements, pricing norms, and distribution channels. How should we sequence our go-to-market

> activities to maximize our chances of success while keeping the launch coordinated?

Think Deeper will work through the regulatory, pricing, and logistical considerations for each market, identify dependencies between the launches, and propose a sequenced plan that accounts for the complexity.

Nuanced Questions Without Clear Answers

Some questions do not have a single right answer. They require balancing competing priorities, understanding context, and making judgment calls. Think Deeper handles ambiguity better than standard responses.

> How should a 45-year-old with moderate risk tolerance, a paid-off house, two kids approaching college age, and a desire to retire at 60 think about their investment allocation?

Standard Copilot gives you generic financial advice. Think Deeper considers the specific constraints – the college expenses coming in a few years, the 15-year time horizon to retirement, the paid-off house as an asset, and the moderate risk tolerance – and produces a more personalized, nuanced analysis.

Logic and Reasoning Puzzles

Think Deeper is significantly better at logic problems, math reasoning, and puzzles that require step-by-step deduction.

> A farmer has a fox, a chicken, and a sack of grain. He needs to cross a river in a boat that can only carry him and one item at a time. If left unattended, the fox will eat the chicken, and the chicken will eat the grain. How can the farmer get everything across safely?

Standard Copilot can solve this classic puzzle, but Think Deeper handles much more complex variations and novel logic problems more reliably.

Writing Complex Documents

For documents that require careful argumentation – legal analyses, policy recommendations, research syntheses, or technical evaluations – Think Deeper produces more coherent and well-structured output.

> Write an analysis of the ethical implications of using AI-generated content in journalism, considering perspectives from journalists, publishers, readers, and AI developers. Address the tensions between efficiency and accuracy, transparency and competitive advantage, and innovation and trust.

Think Deeper will produce a more balanced, thorough analysis that genuinely grapples with the tensions rather than just listing arguments.

When Not to Use Think Deeper

Think Deeper is the wrong tool for:

Simple factual questions. "What is the capital of France?" does not benefit from extended reasoning. Quick Response or Auto handles these perfectly.

Routine writing tasks. Drafting a standard email, generating a meeting agenda, or writing social media captions does not need deeper reasoning. Standard Copilot produces perfectly good output for these tasks.

Speed-critical situations. If you need an answer in the next five seconds, Think Deeper's 30-60 second processing time is a problem. Use Quick Response.

Tasks where the bottleneck is information, not reasoning. If Copilot does not have the data it needs – internal company metrics, personal preferences, domain-specific knowledge – Think Deeper will not magically acquire that information. It will reason more carefully about what it does know, but it cannot reason about what it does not know.

Very short conversations. Think Deeper works best when you give it substantial context. A one-sentence prompt often does not give the reasoning model enough material to show its advantage over standard responses.

Practical Examples

Let us look at concrete examples showing the difference Think Deeper makes.

Example 1: Strategic Planning

Prompt: > I am the owner of a 15-person digital marketing agency. Our revenue has been flat for two years at about $2 million annually. Our three largest clients represent 60% of revenue. We primarily offer SEO, PPC, and social media management. I want to grow to $4 million in the next three years. What is my best path forward?

Standard response: You get a generic list: diversify services, hire more, market yourself better, raise prices.

Think Deeper response: The analysis identifies the client concentration risk as the most urgent issue, breaks down growth into specific revenue targets per year, evaluates three growth strategies (new service lines, new client acquisition, larger engagements with existing clients) with realistic estimates, identifies the hiring and operational implications of each approach, and flags the specific risks of growing too fast (quality dilution, cash flow problems) versus too slowly (continued stagnation).

Example 2: Comparing Technical Approaches

Prompt: > We need to choose between building a custom integration between our CRM and ERP systems or purchasing a middleware solution like MuleSoft or Workato. Our IT team has four developers, we have 12 months, and our budget is $200,000. What should we consider?

Think Deeper response: The model evaluates the build-vs-buy question across dimensions that standard responses often miss – total cost of ownership (not just initial cost), ongoing maintenance burden on a four-person team, time to value, flexibility for future integrations, vendor lock-in risks, and the opportunity cost of having developers build middleware instead of working on core business features. It likely recommends a hybrid approach and explains why.

Example 3: Ethical Dilemma

Prompt: > A manager discovers that an employee has been using AI to complete a significant portion of their work, which the company's policy does not explicitly address. The employee's output quality has improved and they are meeting all deadlines. Should the manager address this, and if so, how?

Think Deeper response: Instead of a simple yes/no, the analysis considers multiple angles – transparency and trust, the difference between using AI as a tool versus misrepresenting capabilities, the precedent it sets for the team, the company's obligation to create clear policies, the employee's reasonable expectation that useful tools are acceptable, and the practical reality that prohibiting AI use may be unenforceable. It suggests a constructive approach rather than a punitive one and recommends policy actions.

Tips for Better Think Deeper Prompts

To get the most out of Think Deeper, give it context worth reasoning about.

Provide background. The more context you give, the more useful the reasoning. Include relevant constraints, stakeholders, history, and goals.

Ask for analysis, not just answers. "What should I do?" gets a recommendation. "Analyze the tradeoffs and help me think through this decision" gets a more thorough response.

Specify what you care about. "Prioritize cost efficiency" or "I care most about long-term sustainability, not short-term results" helps Think Deeper focus its reasoning.

Ask it to consider counterarguments. "What are the strongest arguments against your recommendation?" pushes Think Deeper to be more balanced.

Request structured output. "Organize your analysis with clear sections for each option, including pros, cons, risks, and your assessment" helps Think Deeper produce more usable output.

Current Limitations

Think Deeper is powerful but not perfect.

It is still an AI. Extended reasoning does not eliminate the fundamental limitations of large language models. Think Deeper can still hallucinate, make errors, and miss important considerations that it does not have data about.

It does not access real-time information differently. Think Deeper uses the same Bing Search grounding as standard Copilot. It reasons more carefully about the information it finds, but it does not have access to different or better information sources.

Usage may be limited. Depending on your plan, you may have a limited number of Think Deeper queries per day. Microsoft adjusts these limits, so check your current plan details for specifics.

It can over-reason. Sometimes Think Deeper produces an overly complex analysis of a relatively straightforward question. If you find yourself thinking "this is more analysis than I needed," that is a sign the question was better suited for Auto or Quick Response.

It does not learn between sessions. Think Deeper does not remember your previous conversations (unless you are within the same session). Each Think Deeper query is independent.

Key Takeaways

- Think Deeper uses specialized reasoning models that take more time but produce more thorough, nuanced responses.
- Use it for complex analysis, multi-step problem solving, nuanced decisions, and writing that requires careful argumentation.
- Do not use it for simple questions, routine tasks, or situations where speed matters more than depth.
- Provide substantial context in your prompts – Think Deeper works best when it has enough information to reason about.
- Think Deeper is slower by design. The 15-60 seconds of processing time is the model working through the problem step by step.
- It is available through the model selector in the Copilot interface, alongside Auto and Quick Response modes.
- Despite its name, Think Deeper is still an AI tool with the same fundamental limitations as any large language model. It reasons more carefully, but it can still make mistakes.

Chapter 18: Copilot Vision (Preview)

Every feature we have covered so far works with text. You type words, Copilot reads them, and it responds with words (or images, in the case of Designer). Copilot Vision breaks that pattern. Instead of reading your text, it looks at your screen.

Copilot Vision is a feature that allows Copilot to see and understand what is displayed in your browser or on your screen. You can ask it questions about what you are looking at, get help understanding web pages, and have conversations grounded in visual content rather than typed descriptions.

This is a preview feature as of early 2026. It is not generally available to all users, and its capabilities are still evolving. In this chapter, we will cover what Copilot Vision can do today, its current limitations, the privacy considerations you should understand, practical use cases, and what to expect as the feature matures.

What Copilot Vision Is

At its core, Copilot Vision gives Copilot the ability to see. When you enable it, Copilot can analyze the content of web pages you are viewing in Microsoft Edge, and in some preview configurations, it can understand what is displayed on your screen more broadly.

This is made possible by multimodal AI models – models that can process both text and images. When Vision is active, Copilot takes a visual snapshot of what you are looking at, processes it through these multimodal models, and generates responses based on both the text and visual elements on the page.

Think of it as the difference between describing a painting to someone over the phone and standing next to them in the gallery. When Copilot can see what you see, the conversation becomes much more natural and efficient.

What Vision Is Not

Copilot Vision is not a screen recording tool. It does not continuously monitor your screen or store images of what you are viewing. When you ask a question, it captures a snapshot of the current view, processes it, and then discards the image. It is also not an accessibility tool in the traditional sense – it does not provide screen reader functionality or replace assistive technologies.

Current Capabilities

As a preview feature, Copilot Vision's capabilities are focused on specific scenarios. Here is what it can do today.

Understanding Web Pages

When you are browsing a website in Microsoft Edge with Vision enabled, you can ask Copilot questions about what you see:

- "What is this page about?" – Copilot reads both the text and the visual layout to provide a summary.
- "What product is being shown here?" – Copilot identifies products, images, and visual content on the page.
- "Can you read the text in this image?" – If a web page has text embedded in images (common in infographics, banners, and social media posts), Copilot can extract and read it.
- "Compare the two products shown on this page." – If you are on a comparison page, Copilot can analyze the visual layout and provide a structured comparison.

Interpreting Visual Content

Vision is particularly useful for visual content that is hard to describe in text:

- **Charts and graphs:** "What does this chart show? What are the key trends?" Copilot can read bar charts, line graphs, pie charts, and other common visualizations.

- **Screenshots:** If you are looking at a screenshot of an error message, a settings page, or a software interface, you can ask "What does this error mean?" or "How do I change this setting?"
- **Maps and diagrams:** Copilot can interpret maps, flowcharts, and architectural diagrams to some degree, though its accuracy varies with complexity.
- **Tables and data:** Complex tables that are rendered as images (not as actual HTML tables) can be read and interpreted.

Helping with Shopping and Research

A practical application that many preview users have found useful: shopping assistance. When you are on a product page, you can ask:

- "Is this a good deal for this type of product?"
- "What are the key specifications of this item?"
- "Can you find similar products at a lower price?"

Copilot reads the product page visually and responds based on what it sees, combined with its general knowledge and Bing search capabilities.

Assisting with Learning

When you are reading educational content – a textbook page, a tutorial, or a documentation site – Vision can help you understand the material:

- "Explain this diagram in simple terms."
- "I do not understand the formula shown here. Can you break it down?"
- "What is the main concept being illustrated in this figure?"

How to Enable and Use Copilot Vision

As a preview feature, availability depends on your account type, region, and Microsoft's rollout schedule. Here is the general process.

In Microsoft Edge:

1. Open Microsoft Edge and make sure you are signed in with your Microsoft account.
2. Open the Copilot sidebar (click the Copilot icon in the toolbar or press the keyboard shortcut).
3. Look for the Vision toggle or option in the Copilot panel. In preview builds, this may appear as a camera icon, a "Vision" label, or a toggle in the Copilot settings.
4. Enable Vision. You will see a notification explaining that Copilot will be able to see the content of your current browser tab.
5. Navigate to any web page and ask Copilot questions about what you see.

In the Copilot app:

Some preview versions of the Copilot desktop and mobile apps also support Vision through screenshot sharing. You can take a screenshot and share it with Copilot, then ask questions about it. This is a more manual process than the real-time Edge integration but works across any application.

The Preview Experience

Because Vision is in preview, expect some rough edges:

- The feature may not be available every time you open Edge. Microsoft enables and disables preview features as they test and iterate.
- Response times may be slightly longer than text-only interactions because the model is processing visual data.
- Accuracy varies. Simple, well-structured pages produce excellent results. Complex, visually cluttered pages may confuse the model.
- Some website content may not be processed due to technical limitations or content restrictions.

Privacy Considerations

Vision raises important privacy questions, and Microsoft has built in several safeguards.

What Copilot Sees

When Vision is active, Copilot can see the content of the browser tab you are currently viewing. This means:

- It can see text, images, layouts, and interactive elements on the page.
- It can see any personal information displayed on the page – your email inbox, your bank account page, your social media profile.
- It processes a snapshot of the current view, not a continuous stream.

What Microsoft Does with the Data

According to Microsoft's privacy documentation for Vision:

- Visual data is processed to generate responses and is not stored long-term.
- For consumer accounts, Microsoft's standard Copilot privacy terms apply.
- For commercial and enterprise accounts, commercial data protections apply – your data is not used to train AI models.

What You Should Do

Even with these protections, use common sense:

Do not enable Vision on sensitive pages. If you are viewing financial accounts, medical records, confidential business documents, or any page with sensitive personal information, consider whether you actually need Vision active. If you are just asking a general question, you can type it without Vision.

Be aware of what is visible. If you have multiple browser tabs open, Vision only sees the active tab. But if that tab contains sensitive information in a sidebar, notification banner, or embedded widget, Copilot might process that content too.

Disable Vision when you do not need it. There is no benefit to leaving Vision on when you are not actively using it. Toggle it off when you are done with your visual queries.

Understand your organization's policies. If you are using Copilot at work, your IT department may have policies about Vision. Some organizations may disable the feature entirely. Check before using it with work-related content.

Practical Use Cases

Let us look at scenarios where Vision adds genuine value.

Technical Troubleshooting

You are setting up a new piece of software and you encounter a configuration screen with a dozen settings you do not understand. Instead of describing the screen in text, you enable Vision and ask:

> What do each of these settings do? Which ones should I change for a standard home network setup?

Copilot reads the settings labels, input fields, and any on-screen help text, then explains each setting and recommends values based on your described use case.

Data Interpretation

You are viewing a dashboard with several charts and graphs – a web-based analytics tool, a financial report, or a business intelligence dashboard. You ask:

> What are the three most important insights from this dashboard?

Copilot analyzes the charts, identifies trends, and highlights the most significant data points. This is faster than describing each chart to Copilot in text and asking for interpretation.

Accessibility and Comprehension

You are reading an academic paper or technical documentation that includes complex diagrams, formulas, or illustrations. You ask:

> Explain this diagram to me like I am a beginner in this field.

Copilot interprets the visual content and provides a simplified explanation. This is particularly useful for visual learners or for anyone encountering a new domain for the first time.

Shopping Decisions

You are comparison shopping and have a product page open with specifications, reviews, and pricing. You ask:

> Is this laptop a good choice for someone who needs to run video editing software and has a budget of $1,500?

Copilot reads the specs from the page, evaluates them against your stated needs, and provides a recommendation – all without you having to manually extract and type the specifications.

Learning from Videos and Tutorials

When paused on a frame of an instructional video or looking at a step in a tutorial, you can ask:

> I am on step 4 of this tutorial. What am I supposed to do next? I do not understand the diagram.

Copilot interprets the visual instructions and provides a clear explanation.

Current Limitations

Vision is impressive technology, but it has clear limitations you should understand.

It does not work outside of Edge (mostly). The real-time Vision integration is tied to Microsoft Edge. If you use Chrome, Firefox, or Safari as your primary browser, you will not have the same seamless experience. The workaround is taking screenshots and sharing them with Copilot, but that is less convenient.

Complex visuals can be misinterpreted. Dense infographics, overlapping UI elements, or poorly designed web pages may confuse the model. If the page is hard for a human to parse, it will be hard for Copilot too.

It cannot interact with pages. Vision can see what is on the page, but it cannot click buttons, fill in forms, or navigate for you. It is an observer, not an actor. (Agentic

capabilities that can take actions on your behalf are a separate, even earlier-stage development track.)

Dynamic content can be missed. If a page has animations, videos, or content that changes as you scroll, Copilot sees only a static snapshot of the current view. Moving content or content below the fold is not captured.

Response accuracy varies. Vision is less reliable than text-only interactions. Expect it to be right most of the time for simple pages and less consistently accurate for complex ones. Always verify important details.

Preview status means changes. As a preview feature, Vision's capabilities, interface, and availability can change at any time. What works today might work differently tomorrow as Microsoft iterates on the feature.

What to Expect Going Forward

Copilot Vision represents an important direction for AI assistants. The ability to see and understand visual content makes AI more useful in situations where text alone is insufficient.

Based on Microsoft's public roadmap and the trajectory of multimodal AI development, here is what to expect:

Broader availability. Vision will likely move from preview to general availability as the technology matures. This will include broader browser support and deeper integration into the Copilot app.

Improved accuracy. As multimodal models improve, Vision's ability to interpret complex visuals will get better. Charts, diagrams, and dense layouts that confuse it today will be handled more reliably in future updates.

Deeper integration with Microsoft 365. Eventually, Vision-like capabilities may extend to understanding what you see in Word, Excel, PowerPoint, and other Microsoft 365 apps – helping you work with visual content within your documents, not just on web pages.

Agentic capabilities. The long-term vision (no pun intended) is for AI assistants to not just see your screen but to take actions on your behalf – clicking buttons, filling out forms, navigating between apps. This is a separate development track from Vision but builds on the same multimodal foundation.

For now, treat Vision as a useful preview tool with real but limited capabilities. Experiment with it when it is available, understand its privacy implications, and provide feedback to Microsoft through the built-in feedback mechanisms. Your experience with the preview shapes what the final product will look like.

Key Takeaways

- Copilot Vision lets Copilot see and understand your screen, enabling questions and conversations about visual content.
- It currently works primarily in Microsoft Edge and is in preview – availability may vary.
- Vision excels at interpreting web pages, charts, product pages, error messages, and visual tutorials.
- Privacy matters – be thoughtful about enabling Vision on pages with sensitive information, and disable it when not needed.
- The feature cannot interact with pages, only observe them. It sees static snapshots, not dynamic content.
- Expect Vision to improve significantly as multimodal AI technology matures and as Microsoft moves the feature toward general availability.
- This is preview software. Capabilities and availability will change. Use it to explore what is possible, but do not build critical workflows around it yet.

Chapter 19: Prompting Fundamentals

If there is one skill that separates people who find Copilot merely interesting from people who find it genuinely indispensable, it is prompting. Not because prompting is some technical discipline reserved for programmers – it is not. It is because most people have never paused to think about how they phrase requests to an AI, and a handful of deliberate adjustments can transform vague, generic answers into precise, useful ones.

This chapter will teach you those adjustments. You will learn what makes a prompt effective in Microsoft Copilot specifically, how to structure your requests so the AI understands exactly what you want, and how to avoid the most common mistakes that lead to disappointing results. By the end, you will have twenty ready-to-use prompt templates you can start applying today.

What Makes a Good Prompt for Copilot

A good prompt is not about memorizing special phrases or insider tricks. It is about clarity. Copilot is powered by large language models that are remarkably capable at interpreting natural language, but they cannot read your mind. The more precisely you communicate what you want, the better the result.

Think of it this way: if you walked up to a brilliant but brand-new colleague and said "help me with the thing," they would need to ask you a dozen follow-up questions before they could be useful. Copilot is in the same position, except it usually will not ask those follow-up questions. Instead, it will make assumptions – and those assumptions may or may not match what you had in mind.

A good Copilot prompt has five qualities:

1. **It is specific.** Instead of "write something about marketing," you say "write a 500-word blog post about email marketing strategies for small e-commerce businesses."
2. **It provides context.** Copilot does not know your situation unless you tell it. Who is the audience? What is the goal? What constraints exist?

3. **It defines the format.** Do you want a list? A paragraph? A table? A formal report? Say so.
4. **It sets constraints.** Word count, tone, topics to avoid, level of detail – these boundaries focus the output.
5. **It assigns a role when helpful.** Telling Copilot to respond as a specific type of expert shapes its vocabulary, depth, and approach.

You do not need all five in every prompt. A quick factual question – "What is the population of Portugal?" – does not require a role or format specification. But the more complex your request, the more these elements matter.

The Five Elements of an Effective Prompt

Let us break down the anatomy of a strong prompt. Think of these five elements as a toolkit you can draw from whenever you need to get better results.

1. Role

The role tells Copilot what perspective to adopt. This genuinely shapes the vocabulary, depth, and approach of the response.

> You are an experienced marketing consultant who specializes in helping small businesses grow their email lists.

Compare the response you would get from that setup versus simply asking "tell me about email marketing." The role creates focus and expertise.

2. Task

The task is the core of your prompt – what you actually want Copilot to do. Be direct. Use action verbs: write, analyze, compare, summarize, explain, create, list, evaluate, draft, outline.

> Write a comparison of three email marketing platforms suitable for a business with fewer than 1,000 subscribers.

3. Context

Context is the background information Copilot needs to do the task well. This might include your industry, audience, experience level, timeline, or any relevant constraints.

> My business is a handmade jewelry shop on Etsy. I have about 400 email subscribers and a monthly marketing budget of $50. I currently send emails manually through Gmail.

4. Format

Tell Copilot how to structure the output. This eliminates guesswork and gives you results you can use immediately.

> Present this as a table with columns for platform name, monthly price, key features, ease of use rating, and a one-sentence summary.

5. Constraints

Constraints are the guardrails. They tell Copilot what to include, what to exclude, and any boundaries to respect.

> Keep the comparison under 600 words. Only include platforms with free tiers. Write in a casual, friendly tone. Do not recommend Mailchimp, as I have already tried it.

Putting It All Together

Here is what a complete prompt looks like when you combine all five elements:

> You are a marketing consultant who specializes in helping small e-commerce businesses. Compare three email marketing platforms suitable for a handmade jewelry shop on Etsy with about 400 subscribers and a $50 monthly marketing budget. I currently send emails manually through Gmail. Present this as a table with columns for platform name, monthly price, key features, ease of use, and a one-sentence summary, followed by a brief recommendation. Keep it under 600 words, only include platforms with free tiers, do not recommend Mailchimp, and write in a casual, friendly tone.

That is a prompt that will get you a genuinely useful answer on the first try. It takes thirty seconds to write and saves you five minutes of back-and-forth.

Specific vs. Vague: The Difference That Matters Most

The single biggest improvement most people can make to their prompting is being more specific. Here are some before-and-after examples:

Vague: "Help me with my resume." **Specific:** "Review my resume for a senior marketing manager position at a tech company. Focus on whether my bullet points use strong action verbs and quantifiable achievements. Here is my resume: [paste resume]."

Vague: "Write an email." **Specific:** "Write a professional email to my manager requesting two days of remote work per week. My reasons are a long commute (90 minutes each way) and higher productivity at home. Keep it under 200 words and maintain a respectful, collaborative tone."

Vague: "Explain Excel formulas." **Specific:** "Explain the VLOOKUP function in Excel to someone who has never used it. Use an analogy to make it intuitive. Show one simple example with sample data. Keep it to three paragraphs."

Vague: "Give me presentation ideas." **Specific:** "Suggest five creative presentation topics for a 15-minute talk at a nonprofit board meeting about increasing volunteer retention. The audience is board members aged 40-65 who are not tech-savvy."

Notice how the specific versions give Copilot a clear target. You are not limiting creativity – you are focusing it.

Common Beginner Mistakes

Certain patterns consistently lead to disappointing results. Here are the mistakes to avoid.

Mistake 1: Being Too Brief

One-sentence prompts almost always produce generic responses. Copilot is not a search engine – it does not just need a query. It needs instructions. Do not be afraid to write a prompt that is a full paragraph or more. The small investment of time pays off in much better output.

Mistake 2: Asking Multiple Unrelated Questions at Once

"What is the capital of France, how do I fix a leaky faucet, and can you write me a poem about dogs?" Copilot will attempt to answer all three, but the quality of each answer suffers. Focus on one task at a time, or at least number your questions clearly so Copilot can address each one separately.

Mistake 3: Not Providing Examples

If you want output in a specific style or format, show Copilot an example. "Write product descriptions like this one: [example]" is far more effective than trying to describe the style in abstract terms.

Mistake 4: Forgetting to Specify the Audience

A financial analysis written for a CFO looks very different from one written for a college student. Always tell Copilot who will be reading the output.

Mistake 5: Assuming Copilot Remembers Previous Conversations

Each new conversation with Copilot starts fresh. It does not retain information from past chats unless you are working within a persistent context like Microsoft 365 Copilot, where it can access your organizational data. If context from a previous conversation is important, paste it in or summarize it.

Mistake 6: Not Iterating

Your first prompt does not have to be perfect. Treat it as a starting point. If the response is close but not quite right, tell Copilot what to adjust. "This is good, but make the tone more formal and add a section about pricing" is a perfectly valid follow-up. Some of the best results come from two or three rounds of refinement.

Mistake 7: Overcomplicating the Prompt

There is a balance between specificity and overload. Wrapping your request in unnecessary jargon, contradictory instructions, or walls of tangential detail can muddy the waters. Write naturally. Pretend you are giving instructions to a smart coworker who is new to the project.

Copilot-Specific Prompting Tips

Copilot has some unique characteristics that affect how you should prompt compared to other AI assistants. Understanding these will help you get the most from the tool.

Copilot Uses Bing Search Grounding

Unlike some AI assistants that work purely from their training data, Copilot can search the web in real time through Bing. This means you can ask about current events, recent news, today's weather, or live information and expect reasonably up-to-date answers with citations.

When you want Copilot to use the web, phrase your prompt accordingly: "Search for the latest reviews of the iPhone 17 and summarize the pros and cons from three different sources." If you want an answer purely from Copilot's knowledge without a search, you can say so – though Copilot may search anyway depending on the mode you are using.

Modes Change How Copilot Responds

Copilot offers different modes – Quick Response, Auto, and Think Deeper – that affect the depth and quality of answers. If you are asking a simple factual question, Quick Response is fine. If you are working through a complex problem, switching to Think Deeper gives the model more room to reason.

Your prompting should match the mode. In Think Deeper mode, you can afford to present a more complex, multi-part problem. In Quick Response mode, keep prompts focused and straightforward.

Microsoft 365 Integration Changes the Game

If you are using Copilot within Microsoft 365 apps – Word, Excel, PowerPoint, Outlook, Teams – you do not always need to provide context manually. Copilot can reference your documents, emails, meeting transcripts, and files.

In Word, you might prompt: "Summarize this document in three bullet points." In Outlook: "Draft a reply agreeing to the meeting time and suggesting we add the marketing team." In Teams: "What decisions were made in today's standup meeting?"

The prompting fundamentals still apply, but the context element is often handled by the app itself.

Copilot Responds Well to Natural Language

You do not need to use any special syntax, programming-style commands, or technical formatting to get good results from Copilot. Write the way you would speak to a colleague. Copilot's models are trained to understand conversational English exceptionally well.

That said, if you are working with Copilot in a browser and pasting in large blocks of text, clearly separating your instructions from the source material helps. A simple approach: put your instructions first, then add a line like "Here is the text to work with:" followed by the pasted content.

20 Prompt Templates for Everyday Use

Here are twenty templates you can copy, customize, and use immediately. Each template uses [brackets] to indicate the parts you should fill in with your own details.

1. Professional Email

```
Write a professional email to [recipient/role] about [topic]. Contex
t: [brief background]. Tone: [polite/formal/friendly]. Keep it under
[number] words.
```

2. Meeting Agenda

```
Create a meeting agenda for a [duration]-minute [type of meeting] abo
ut [topic]. Attendees: [roles/names]. Include time allocations for ea
ch item and end with action items.
```

3. Document Summary

```
Summarize the following [document type] in [number] bullet points. Fo
cus on [key themes/decisions/action items]. Audience: [who will read
the summary].

[Paste document text]
```

4. Research Overview

```
Research [topic] and provide a balanced overview. Include: current st
ate, key debates or perspectives, recent developments, and practical
implications for [audience/context]. Cite your sources.
```

5. Comparison

```
Compare [option A], [option B], and [option C] for [use case]. Presen
t as a table with columns for [criteria 1], [criteria 2], [criteria
3], and a recommendation. Keep it under [word count] words.
```

6. Explain a Concept

```
Explain [concept] to someone who is [audience description, e.g., "a c
omplete beginner" or "a 12-year-old"]. Use [number] everyday analogie
s. Keep it to [number] paragraphs.
```

7. Rewrite for Tone

```
Rewrite the following text in a [formal/casual/persuasive/empathetic]
 tone. Keep the core message the same but adjust the language for [au
dience].

[Paste text]
```

8. Brainstorming

```
Generate [number] creative ideas for [goal/project]. Context: [releva
nt details about the situation]. For each idea, include a one-sentenc
e description and one potential challenge.
```

9. Action Plan

```
Create a step-by-step action plan for [goal]. Timeline: [timeframe].
Resources available: [list]. Include milestones, deadlines, and who i
s responsible for each step.
```

10. Pros and Cons Analysis

```
List the pros and cons of [decision/option]. Context: [your situatio
n]. Consider [specific factors]. Present as two columns. End with a o
ne-paragraph recommendation.
```

11. Social Media Post

```
Write a [platform] post about [topic]. Goal: [inform/engage/promote].
 Tone: [professional/casual/inspiring]. Include a strong hook in the
first line. Maximum [word/character] count.
```

12. Job Description

```
Write a job description for a [title] position at [company type]. Key
 responsibilities: [list]. Required qualifications: [list]. Tone: [pr
ofessional/startup-casual/formal]. Include information about [benefit
s/culture/growth opportunities].
```

13. Feedback Draft

```
Help me write constructive feedback for [person/role] about [topic].
What went well: [positives]. What needs improvement: [areas]. Tone:
[supportive/direct/encouraging]. Keep it professional and specific.
```

14. Presentation Outline

```
Create an outline for a [duration]-minute presentation about [topic].
 Audience: [description]. Goal: [inform/persuade/train]. Include [num
ber] main sections, key talking points for each, and suggestions for
visuals.
```

15. Data Interpretation

```
I have the following data: [describe or paste data]. Help me identify
 [number] key trends or insights. Explain each insight in plain langu
age and suggest one action to take based on it.
```

16. Customer Response

```
Write a response to a customer who [describe the situation -- complai
nt, question, request]. Our policy is [relevant policy]. Tone: empath
etic and helpful. Offer [specific resolution]. Keep it under [number]
 sentences.
```

17. Study Guide

```
Create a study guide for [subject/exam]. Cover these topics: [list].
For each topic, include: a brief explanation, one example, and one pr
actice question with the answer. Difficulty level: [beginner/intermed
iate/advanced].
```

18. Weekly Report

```
Draft a weekly report for [audience]. Accomplishments this week: [lis
t]. Challenges: [list]. Next week's priorities: [list]. Tone: profess
ional and concise. Format as bullet points with brief context for eac
h item.
```

19. Decision Framework

```
Help me decide between [option A] and [option B]. My priorities are:
[list priorities in order]. My constraints are: [list constraints]. W
alk me through the decision systematically and give a recommendation.
```

20. Event Planning Checklist

```
Create a detailed checklist for planning a [type of event] for [numbe
r] people. Date: [timeframe]. Budget: [amount]. Include categories fo
r [venue, catering, invitations, etc.] with specific tasks and deadli
nes.
```

Building the Prompting Habit

Prompting is a skill, and like any skill, it improves with practice. You do not need to memorize frameworks or templates. What you need is the habit of pausing for ten seconds before typing and asking yourself three questions:

1. **What exactly do I want?** Not roughly, not vaguely – what specifically would the ideal output look like?
2. **What does Copilot need to know?** What context, constraints, or preferences would help it deliver that ideal output?
3. **How should the output be formatted?** Would a table, a list, or a narrative paragraph serve you best?

Those ten seconds of thinking will save you minutes of back-and-forth and deliver dramatically better results. Over time, it becomes automatic. You will find yourself writing clear, effective prompts without even thinking about it – and wondering how you ever got by with "help me with the thing."

In the next chapter, we will build on these fundamentals by tackling something more ambitious: how to use Copilot for long, complex tasks that require multiple steps and sustained reasoning.

For a comprehensive library of 78 prompt templates organized by category, see Appendix B.

Chapter 20: Working with Long and Complex Tasks

Most people discover Copilot through quick, single-turn interactions. You ask a question, you get an answer, you move on. That is a perfectly valid way to use it – but it barely scratches the surface of what is possible.

The real power of Copilot emerges when you use it for tasks that are too complex, too multi-layered, or too lengthy for a single prompt. Writing a business plan. Analyzing a dataset and drawing conclusions. Drafting a ten-page report. Preparing for a negotiation. These are the tasks where Copilot can save you hours of work – but only if you know how to manage the process.

This chapter will teach you how to break big tasks into manageable steps, chain prompts together for cumulative results, manage context across a long conversation, and know when to start fresh versus when to keep building.

Why Single Prompts Fall Short for Complex Work

A single prompt works beautifully for focused tasks: summarize this email, write a thank-you note, explain a concept, generate a table. But when you try to cram an entire complex project into one prompt, several problems emerge.

The output gets shallow. If you ask Copilot to "write a business plan for a coffee shop," it will produce something that covers all the sections – executive summary, market analysis, financial projections – but each section will be thin. There is only so much depth a single response can provide.

Important details get missed. Complex tasks have nuances. A business plan needs to account for your specific location, your target market, your competitive advantages, your funding situation. A single prompt cannot convey all of this, and Copilot cannot ask you about what you have not mentioned.

You lose control over quality. When everything is generated at once, you cannot course-correct along the way. If the market analysis section is based on the wrong

assumptions, everything that follows – the financial projections, the marketing strategy – inherits that error.

The solution is not to write longer prompts. It is to work in stages.

Breaking Big Tasks into Steps

The most important technique for complex work with Copilot is decomposition – breaking a big task into a sequence of smaller, manageable steps. This mirrors how you would approach the task yourself, and it gives you control at every stage.

The Decomposition Process

Start by asking yourself: if I were doing this task without AI, what would my steps be? Then use Copilot for each step individually.

Let us say you need to write a quarterly business review presentation. Here is how you might break it down:

1. **Outline the structure.** Ask Copilot to suggest a structure for a quarterly review, specifying your audience and key topics.
2. **Draft each section.** Work through the presentation section by section, providing relevant data and context for each.
3. **Generate insights.** Ask Copilot to identify trends or notable findings from the data you provide.
4. **Refine the narrative.** Once all sections exist, ask Copilot to ensure the overall story is coherent and compelling.
5. **Polish the language.** Final pass for tone, clarity, and consistency.

Each step is a focused interaction where you can review, adjust, and approve before moving on. Compare this to a single prompt like “create a quarterly business review presentation” – the staged approach will produce dramatically better results.

When You Do Not Know the Steps

Sometimes you are tackling a task you have never done before, and you do not know how to break it down. This is a perfect first prompt for Copilot:

> I need to [describe the task]. I have never done this before. What are the key steps involved? Break it down into a logical sequence I can work through one step at a time.

Copilot will give you a roadmap, and then you can work through that roadmap step by step – using Copilot as your guide at each stage.

Chaining Prompts

Prompt chaining is the technique of using the output from one prompt as the input or context for the next. Each prompt builds on what came before, creating a cumulative result that no single prompt could achieve.

Sequential Chaining

The most straightforward form of chaining is sequential: you complete one step, review the result, and then use it as the foundation for the next step.

Step 1: > I am writing a proposal to my manager about implementing a four-day work week at our company. Start by listing the five strongest arguments in favor of a four-day work week, with evidence or statistics for each.

Step 2: > Good. Now list the three strongest counterarguments a skeptical manager might raise, and for each one, write a brief rebuttal.

Step 3: > Now draft the full proposal as a two-page memo. Use the arguments and rebuttals we just developed. Tone: professional and data-driven. Address it to [manager's name] and include a suggested pilot program.

Step 4: > Review this memo for any logical weaknesses or gaps. What might my manager push back on that I have not addressed?

Notice how each step builds on the previous work. By Step 3, Copilot has a rich foundation of arguments, counterarguments, and rebuttals to draw from. The resulting memo will be far stronger than if you had asked for it in a single prompt.

Branching Chains

Sometimes you need to explore multiple directions before converging on a final result. This is a branching chain.

> Give me three different angles I could take for a presentation about our company's sustainability efforts. For each angle, give a one-sentence pitch and the type of audience it would work best for.

After reviewing the three angles, you choose the most promising one and dive deeper:

> I like the second angle – focusing on the financial returns of our green initiatives. Develop a detailed outline for a 20-minute presentation using this angle. Audience: the board of directors.

Refinement Chains

Refinement chaining is about taking a draft and improving it through successive rounds of focused feedback.

Round 1: Generate the initial draft. **Round 2:** "Make the introduction more compelling. Start with a surprising statistic." **Round 3:** "The third section is too long. Cut it to half the length while keeping the key points." **Round 4:** "Add a stronger call to action at the end."

Each round targets a specific aspect of quality. The result is a polished piece that went through multiple rounds of focused improvement.

Multi-Turn Strategies

A multi-turn conversation is any interaction that lasts more than one exchange. Most complex tasks will be multi-turn. Here are strategies for making them productive.

Set the Stage Early

Your first message in a complex, multi-turn conversation should establish the overall goal, your role, and any constraints that apply to the entire task – not just the first step.

> I am preparing for a job interview at [company] for a [position]. Over the next several messages, I am going to ask you to help me with different aspects of my preparation. The interview is next Tuesday. I have five years of experience in [field] and my biggest strengths are [list]. Let us start with: what are the most likely interview questions for this role?

This gives Copilot context it can carry throughout the conversation.

Use Explicit Transitions

When you shift from one phase of a task to another, tell Copilot clearly:

> Great, we are done with the interview questions. Now let us move on to a different part of my preparation: reviewing my resume for this specific role.

This prevents Copilot from blending the contexts of different phases.

Summarize and Confirm

For long conversations, periodically summarize what has been accomplished and confirm that Copilot is tracking correctly:

> Let me summarize what we have so far: we have the market analysis showing three key trends, a competitive landscape section covering five competitors, and a draft value proposition. Is that consistent with what you have in the conversation? Now let us work on the financial projections section.

Provide Feedback, Not Just Approval

"Looks good" is the least useful thing you can say after a Copilot response. If something is good, say what is good about it. If something needs to change, be specific:

- "The tone in the second paragraph is too casual for this audience. Make it more professional."
- "These numbers do not match the data I provided. Recalculate using the figures in my first message."
- "I like the structure but the examples are too generic. Use examples from the healthcare industry."

Specific feedback produces specific improvements.

Managing Context

Every AI conversation has a context window – the total amount of text (your messages and Copilot's responses) that the model can "see" at once. In practice, this means that in very long conversations, the earliest messages may fall outside of what Copilot can actively reference.

Signs of Context Loss

You may notice context loss when:

- Copilot contradicts something it said earlier
- It "forgets" constraints you set at the beginning
- It asks for information you already provided
- The overall coherence of a long project starts to drift

Strategies for Managing Context

Repeat key constraints. If you set important constraints early in the conversation, restate them when they become relevant again. "Remember, this should be written for a non-technical audience" costs you a few seconds and prevents drift.

Use summary messages. Every five to ten exchanges, summarize the current state of the project. This refreshes Copilot's awareness of the full picture.

Keep one conversation per project. Avoid mixing unrelated tasks in the same conversation. Each topic deserves its own thread.

Front-load critical information. Put the most important context at the beginning of your prompt, not buried at the end. Research consistently shows that AI models pay more attention to the start and end of prompts than to the middle.

When to Start Fresh vs. Continue

This is one of the most practical judgment calls you will make: should you keep building in the current conversation, or start a new one?

Keep Going When:

- The conversation is still coherent and Copilot is referencing earlier context correctly
- You are iterating on a single deliverable (refining a draft, for example)
- The task is a natural continuation of what came before
- You have not exceeded roughly 15-20 exchanges

Start Fresh When:

- Copilot seems to have lost track of earlier context
- You are moving to a fundamentally different task
- The conversation has become cluttered with abandoned directions or corrections
- You want a completely new perspective on something (sometimes starting over yields better results than trying to redirect a long conversation)
- The quality of responses has noticeably declined

When you do start fresh, you do not lose everything. Copy the best outputs from the previous conversation and paste them into the new one as context: "Here is the outline we developed in a previous session. Now I want to draft Section 3."

Using Think Deeper for Complex Reasoning

Copilot's Think Deeper mode (extended reasoning) is specifically designed for tasks that require sustained, multi-step reasoning. It gives the model more time to work through problems before responding, and it excels in situations where Quick Response or Auto mode would give you a superficial answer.

When to Use Think Deeper

- Analyzing a complex document and identifying subtle patterns or inconsistencies
- Working through a multi-step math or logic problem
- Comparing multiple options with numerous trade-offs
- Developing a detailed strategy or plan
- Reviewing a contract or policy for potential issues
- Any task where you would say "I need you to really think about this"

Prompting for Think Deeper

When using Think Deeper, you can afford to present more complexity in a single prompt. Instead of breaking a problem into tiny steps, you can present the full problem and let the model reason through it:

> I am deciding whether to lease or buy a car. Here are my specifics: I drive approximately 15,000 miles per year, I plan to keep the car for 5 years, my credit score is 740, I have $5,000 for a down payment, and I live in a state with 6% sales tax. The car I am considering has an MSRP of $35,000. Walk me through the financial analysis of leasing versus buying, including total cost of ownership, monthly payments, and the break-even point. Consider depreciation, interest rates, insurance differences, and any tax implications.

In Think Deeper mode, Copilot will work through all of these factors systematically rather than giving you a surface-level comparison.

Combining Think Deeper with Chaining

For the most ambitious tasks, you can combine Think Deeper with prompt chaining. Use Think Deeper for the steps that require deep analysis, and switch to regular mode for simpler steps like formatting or summarizing.

Practical Example: Building a Complete Project

Let us walk through a complete example of using these techniques together for a real-world task: preparing a budget proposal for your department.

Prompt 1 (Decomposition): > I need to prepare a budget proposal for my IT department for next fiscal year. Help me break this into steps. What sections should the proposal include and what information do I need to gather for each?

Prompt 2 (Context and Data): > Here is last year's budget breakdown: [paste data]. And here are the three new initiatives we want to fund: [list]. Help me analyze last year's spending and identify areas where we were over or under budget.

Prompt 3 (Analysis – use Think Deeper): > Based on this analysis, project next year's budget. Account for 4% inflation, the three new initiatives, and the fact that we are adding two new team members. Show your reasoning for each line item.

Prompt 4 (Narrative): > Now draft the executive summary for this proposal. It should be persuasive, concise, and highlight the ROI of the three new initiatives. Audience: the CFO, who is known for being skeptical of IT spending.

Prompt 5 (Review): > Review the full proposal for any gaps, inconsistencies, or weak arguments. What questions might the CFO ask, and how should I prepare to answer them?

Five prompts. Each one focused. Each one building on the last. The result is a thorough, well-reasoned budget proposal that would have taken you hours to produce from scratch.

Key Takeaways

Working with Copilot on complex tasks is less about any single technique and more about a mindset: think of Copilot as a collaborator you are guiding through a process, not a magic box you dump everything into at once.

Break big tasks into steps. Chain your prompts so each one builds on the last. Manage context by summarizing and restating key information. Use Think Deeper when the reasoning demands it. And know when to start fresh.

Master these techniques, and there is almost no task too complex for you and Copilot to tackle together.

Chapter 21: Output Formatting and Control

One of the most common frustrations people have with AI assistants is getting responses in the wrong format. You wanted a concise list and got a five-paragraph essay. You wanted a table and got bullet points. You wanted something you could paste directly into a report and got something that needs twenty minutes of reformatting.

This chapter is about eliminating that frustration. You will learn how to tell Copilot exactly how to structure its output – tables, lists, specific lengths, particular styles – so that what you get back is something you can actually use without extensive editing. The techniques here are simple, but they will save you an enormous amount of time.

Why Format Matters

Format is not just aesthetics. It is about usability. A well-formatted response is one you can immediately drop into an email, a report, a presentation, or a spreadsheet. A poorly formatted response – even if the content is excellent – creates extra work.

Consider two versions of the same information:

Version A (unformatted): "The three main competitors in the market are Acme Corp, which was founded in 2018 and has revenue of approximately $50 million with 200 employees, and then there is Beta Solutions, founded in 2015, which has revenue of about $120 million and 800 employees, and finally Gamma Tech, which started in 2020 and has revenue of $30 million with 100 employees."

Version B (formatted as a table):

Company	Founded	Revenue	Employees
Acme Corp	2018	$50M	200
Beta Solutions	2015	$120M	800
Gamma Tech	2020	$30M	100

Same information. Version B takes two seconds to read and can be copied directly into a slide or spreadsheet.

Tables

Tables are one of the most useful output formats, and Copilot handles them well. The key is telling Copilot you want a table and specifying the columns.

Basic Table Request

```
Compare the three Microsoft 365 plans for businesses. Present as a ta
ble with columns for plan name, monthly price per user, storage, and
key features.
```

Detailed Table Specifications

When precision matters, be explicit about every aspect:

```
Create a table comparing five programming languages for beginners. Co
lumns: Language, Difficulty Level (rate 1-5), Best Use Cases, Free Le
arning Resources, Job Market Demand (High/Medium/Low). Sort by diffic
ulty level, easiest first.
```

Tables with Analysis

You can ask for a table followed by interpretation:

```
Present the following data as a table, then write a one-paragraph ana
lysis of the key trends:

Q1 Sales: $120K, Q2 Sales: $145K, Q3 Sales: $98K, Q4 Sales: $210K
Q1 Returns: 3%, Q2 Returns: 2%, Q3 Returns: 5%, Q4 Returns: 1%
```

Limitations of Tables in Copilot

Be aware that tables in Copilot are rendered in Markdown format. This means they look clean in the chat interface but may need minor adjustments when pasted into Word or other applications. If you are using Copilot in Word directly, it will format tables using Word's native table features, which is seamless.

Lists and Bullet Points

Lists are the workhorse format of productive Copilot output. They are scannable, organized, and easy to work with.

Simple Lists

```
List ten team-building activities suitable for a remote team of 15 pe
ople. Budget: under $50 per person.
```

Numbered Lists for Sequential Steps

When order matters, ask for numbered lists:

```
Give me a numbered, step-by-step guide to setting up a LinkedIn compa
ny page. Include what to have prepared before you start.
```

Nested Lists for Hierarchical Information

For complex topics with subtopics:

```
Outline the key areas of project management. Use a nested list forma
t: main categories as top-level items, with 3-4 subtopics under each.
```

Annotated Lists

When you want more than just items:

```
List the top 8 productivity apps for professionals. For each, includ
e: the app name, what it does in one sentence, the price, and one spe
cific use case.
```

Controlling Length

Length control is one of the simplest and most impactful formatting instructions you can give. Without it, Copilot will use its own judgment about how long a response should be – and its judgment may not match your needs.

Word Count Targets

You can specify approximate word counts:

```
Write a 300-word summary of the benefits of remote work.
```

Copilot will get close to the target, typically within 10-20% in either direction. If exact length matters, specify a range: “between 250 and 300 words.”

Paragraph Limits

For less precise length control:

```
Explain blockchain technology in exactly three paragraphs. First para
graph: what it is. Second: how it works. Third: why it matters.
```

Sentence-Level Control

For very concise output:

```
Summarize this article in three sentences. Each sentence should cover
 a different key point.
```

Character Limits

Useful for social media and other constrained formats:

```
Write a LinkedIn post about our new product launch. Maximum 300 chara
cters including spaces.
```

The “Keep It Short” Problem

Simply saying “keep it short” often does not work well because “short” is subjective. Be specific: “Keep it under 200 words” or “No more than five bullet points” or “Limit to one paragraph” gives Copilot a clear target.

Tone and Style Control

The words Copilot uses and how it arranges them can vary dramatically based on your tone instructions.

Common Tone Keywords

Here are tone descriptors that Copilot interprets consistently:

- **Formal:** Corporate, professional, suitable for official communications
- **Casual:** Conversational, relaxed, like talking to a friend
- **Academic:** Scholarly, precise, citation-ready
- **Persuasive:** Compelling, emphasizing benefits and urgency
- **Empathetic:** Warm, understanding, acknowledging emotions
- **Direct:** No filler, no hedging, straight to the point
- **Enthusiastic:** Upbeat, energetic, positive
- **Neutral:** Balanced, objective, no emotional coloring

Combining Tone Descriptors

You can combine descriptors for nuance:

```
Write this in a tone that is professional but warm -- like a manager
who genuinely cares about their team.
```

Matching a Specific Voice

If you have an existing piece of writing whose style you want to replicate:

```
Here is an example of the writing style I want you to match:

[paste example]

Now write a new piece about [topic] using the same style, tone, and s
entence structure.
```

This is one of the most powerful formatting techniques available. Copilot is very good at analyzing and replicating writing styles.

Structured Output Patterns

Beyond basic tables and lists, there are several structured patterns that work exceptionally well with Copilot.

SWOT Analysis

```
Perform a SWOT analysis for [company/product/idea]. Present as four c
learly labeled sections: Strengths, Weaknesses, Opportunities, and Th
reats. Include 3-5 bullet points in each section.
```

Pros and Cons

```
Give me the pros and cons of [decision]. Format as two columns. End w
ith a one-paragraph recommendation based on the balance of evidence.
```

FAQ Format

```
Create an FAQ document for [topic/product/process]. Include 10 questi
ons a [audience type] would likely ask, with concise answers of 2-3 s
entences each.
```

Executive Briefing

```
Write an executive briefing on [topic]. Structure: one-paragraph summ
ary, three key findings as bullet points, two recommendations, and on
e risk to monitor. Total length: under 400 words.
```

Decision Matrix

```
Help me decide between [options]. Create a decision matrix with these
 criteria: [list criteria]. Rate each option on a scale of 1-5 for ea
ch criterion. Calculate total scores and recommend the winner.
```

Formatting for Specific Destinations

Where your Copilot output is going affects how you should request formatting.

For Email

```
Draft an email. Keep paragraphs short (2-3 sentences max). Use a clea
r subject line. No bullet points in the greeting or sign-off. Profess
ional but not stiff.
```

For Presentations (PowerPoint)

```
Create content for a slide deck. Format each slide as:
- Slide title
- 3-4 bullet points (under 10 words each)
- One speaker note paragraph (what I should say, not what is on the s
lide)
```

For Reports (Word)

```
Write this as a formal report section with a heading, an introductory
 paragraph, subheadings for each main point, and a concluding paragra
ph. Use a professional, third-person tone.
```

For Spreadsheets (Excel)

```
Present this data in a format I can paste into a spreadsheet. Use tab
-separated values with a header row. Include columns for [list column
s].
```

For Social Media

```
Write three versions of this announcement: one for LinkedIn (professi
onal, 150 words), one for X (casual, under 280 characters), and one f
or an internal Slack message (brief, friendly).
```

Consistency Across Multiple Outputs

When you need Copilot to generate multiple pieces of content that look and feel like they belong together – chapters of a document, a series of emails, a set of product descriptions – consistency is key.

Establish a Template First

```
I need to write descriptions for 10 products. Here is the format each
 description should follow:

Product Name:
Tagline: (under 10 words, punchy)
```

```
Description: (exactly 50 words, benefit-focused)
Key Features: (3 bullet points)
Price: (include currency)

Here is the first product: [details]
```

Once Copilot produces the first one and you approve the style, say:

```
Perfect. Now do the same for the next product: [details]
```

Style Anchoring

If you notice Copilot drifting from the established style, anchor it back:

```
The last description was more formal than the first two. Match the to
ne of the first description -- casual, punchy, benefit-focused.
```

Exporting and Sharing Results

Getting content out of Copilot and into your actual work is the last step in the formatting chain.

Copy and Paste

The simplest method. In the Copilot web interface, you can copy responses using the copy button that appears when you hover over a response. Tables, lists, and formatted text generally copy well into Word, Google Docs, and email clients.

Copilot in Microsoft 365 Apps

When you use Copilot directly within Word, Excel, PowerPoint, or Outlook, the output is already in the right format for that application. This is the most seamless workflow and one of the strongest reasons to use Copilot within the Microsoft ecosystem rather than in the standalone chat.

Copilot Pages

For content you want to collaborate on or refine further, you can save Copilot output to a Page. Pages preserve formatting and allow you to continue editing with AI assistance. They are especially useful for content that multiple people will review.

Markdown Awareness

Copilot's chat output uses Markdown formatting – headers with # symbols, bold with double asterisks, tables with pipe characters. If you are pasting into a Markdown-aware editor (Notion, GitHub, many CMS platforms), the formatting will render correctly. If you are pasting into plain text environments, you may need to remove the Markdown syntax.

Quick Reference: Format Instructions

Here is a cheat sheet of formatting instructions you can append to almost any prompt:

What You Want	What to Say
A table	"Present as a table with columns for [X], [Y], [Z]"
Bullet points	"Format as bullet points"
Numbered steps	"Give me numbered steps"
Specific length	"Keep it under [N] words" or "Exactly [N] paragraphs"
Formal tone	"Use a formal, professional tone"
Casual tone	"Write in a casual, conversational tone"
For email	"Format this as an email with subject line"
For slides	"Create as slide content with bullet points under 10 words each"
Comparison	"Compare as a table with [criteria] columns"
Summary first	"Start with a one-sentence summary, then provide details"

Formatting is not an afterthought. It is part of the prompt. Make it a habit to include at least one formatting instruction in every prompt, and you will find that Copilot's output goes from "interesting but I need to rework it" to "I can use this right now."

Chapter 22: Copilot for Students and Educators

Few groups stand to benefit more from AI assistants than students and educators – and few groups face more complicated questions about when and how to use them. Copilot is not just another study tool. It is a technology that is reshaping how people learn, how teachers teach, and how institutions think about academic integrity.

This chapter is for both sides of the classroom. If you are a student, you will learn how to use Copilot to genuinely enhance your learning – not as a shortcut that undermines it. If you are an educator, you will learn how to integrate Copilot into your teaching, set appropriate boundaries, and prepare students for a world where AI literacy is no longer optional.

How Students Can Use Copilot for Learning

The most important principle for students using Copilot is this: use it to understand, not to avoid understanding. The difference between these two approaches determines whether Copilot makes you smarter or makes you dependent.

Copilot as a Study Partner

One of the best uses of Copilot is as a tireless study partner that can explain concepts in whatever way helps you understand them.

Ask for explanations at your level: > Explain the difference between mitosis and meiosis like I am a visual learner who struggles with biology. Use an analogy that involves something from everyday life.

Request multiple explanations: > I still do not understand the Krebs cycle. Explain it three different ways: first as a simple analogy, then as a step-by-step process, then as a summary I could put on a flashcard.

Test your understanding: > I think the French Revolution happened because of food shortages. Am I on the right track? What am I missing? Do not just give me the answer – help me think through it.

That last prompt is key. When you ask Copilot to help you think rather than think for you, it becomes a genuine learning tool.

Creating Study Materials

Copilot excels at generating study materials tailored to your specific needs.

Flashcards: > Create 20 flashcards for my AP Chemistry exam on chemical bonding. Format: Question on one line, answer on the next. Include ionic, covalent, and metallic bonding. Mix conceptual questions with practice problems.

Practice Quizzes: > Write a 15-question practice quiz on Chapter 7 of my U.S. History textbook (the Civil War era). Mix question types: 5 multiple choice, 5 true/false, and 5 short answer. Include an answer key at the end.

Summary Sheets: > Summarize the key concepts from my statistics course on hypothesis testing. Organize it as a one-page study sheet with definitions, formulas, decision rules, and one worked example for each type of test.

Getting Unstuck on Homework

There is a right way and a wrong way to use Copilot for homework.

Wrong way: "Solve problem 14 from page 203." **Right way:** "I am stuck on a calculus problem that asks me to find the derivative of x^3 * sin(x). I know I need to use the product rule, but I am getting confused about which function is f and which is g. Can you walk me through the setup without giving me the final answer?"

The wrong way gives you an answer you cannot explain. The right way teaches you the process so you can solve similar problems on your own.

Another good approach: > I solved this problem and got 42, but the answer key says 38. Here is my work: [show work]. Where did I go wrong?

Having Copilot identify your specific error is far more educational than having it do the problem from scratch.

Writing Assistance (Not Writing Replacement)

Students often need help with the writing process – and there is a big difference between getting writing help and having something written for you.

Appropriate uses: - "Here is my thesis statement. Is it specific enough, or is it too broad?" - "I wrote this paragraph arguing that renewable energy is cost-effective. Does my reasoning have any logical gaps?" - "Suggest three ways I could strengthen the conclusion of this essay." - "Check this paragraph for grammar and clarity. Explain any changes you suggest so I can learn from them."

Inappropriate use: - "Write a 1,000-word essay on the causes of World War I."

The line is clear: Copilot should help you become a better writer, not replace you as the writer.

Learning New Skills

Copilot is an excellent tutor for skill acquisition, whether you are learning a programming language, a musical concept, a new language, or a professional skill.

> I want to learn basic Python programming. I have never coded before. Create a learning plan that takes me from complete beginner to being able to write simple programs in 30 days. Break it into daily sessions of about 30 minutes each.

You can then work through the plan step by step, asking Copilot to explain concepts, generate practice exercises, and review your attempts.

Homework Help vs. Academic Integrity

This is the most important section in this chapter, because it addresses the question that every student, parent, and educator is asking: where is the line?

The Core Principle

Academic integrity policies exist because the point of assignments is learning. When you submit AI-generated work as your own, you are not just breaking a rule – you are cheating yourself out of the learning the assignment was designed to produce.

Think of it like fitness. If you hire someone to run your miles for you, you technically "completed" the workout – but your body did not benefit. Using Copilot to do your thinking for you works the same way.

A Clear Framework

Here is a framework that works for most academic contexts:

Always acceptable: - Using Copilot to understand concepts you are struggling with - Generating practice problems and quizzes - Getting feedback on your own work - Brainstorming ideas (which you then develop yourself) - Checking grammar and clarity on writing you produced - Learning how to use tools and technologies

Usually acceptable (check your institution's policy): - Using Copilot to help outline an essay you will write yourself - Getting help debugging code you wrote - Asking for explanations of feedback you received from a teacher - Using Copilot as a research starting point (with your own verification)

Generally not acceptable: - Having Copilot write essays, papers, or reports that you submit as your own work - Using Copilot to solve homework problems and submitting the answers without doing the work yourself - Copying Copilot's code directly for a programming assignment - Using Copilot during exams where AI tools are not permitted

Always unacceptable: - Submitting AI-generated work and claiming you wrote it yourself - Using Copilot to circumvent plagiarism detection - Using AI tools in assessments that explicitly prohibit them

The Evolving Policy Landscape

Academic integrity policies around AI are evolving rapidly. What was prohibited in 2024 may be permitted – or even required – in 2026. Always check your institution's current AI use policy, and when in doubt, ask your instructor. Most educators appreciate students who proactively clarify the boundaries rather than assume.

Disclosure

When you do use AI assistance in your work, disclose it. Many institutions now require or encourage AI use disclosures. Even when not required, transparency builds trust and demonstrates integrity. A simple note works: "I used Microsoft Copilot to help

brainstorm ideas for this essay's structure and to check grammar on my final draft. All arguments and analysis are my own."

For Educators: Integrating Copilot into Teaching

If you are an educator, you have probably spent the last couple of years grappling with AI in your classroom. Here is a practical framework for moving from "how do I prevent students from using this?" to "how do I help students use this well?"

Rethinking Assignment Design

The most effective response to AI is not policing – it is designing assignments that make AI a complement to learning rather than a substitute for it.

Assignments that resist AI shortcuts: - Personal reflection and experience-based writing - Analysis of class discussions or in-person activities - Multi-stage projects where students show their process - Oral presentations and defenses of written work - Collaborative projects with peer accountability - Real-time, in-class writing and problem-solving

Assignments that leverage AI productively: - "Use Copilot to generate a first draft, then critically evaluate and substantially revise it. Submit both versions with a reflection on what you changed and why." - "Have Copilot argue the opposite side of your position. Then strengthen your original argument to address the counterpoints it raised." - "Use Copilot to research a topic, then fact-check its claims. Document which claims were accurate, which were inaccurate, and how you verified them."

These assignments teach critical thinking, information literacy, and AI fluency all at once.

Teaching AI Literacy

Students need to understand not just how to use AI but how it works, where it fails, and what its limitations are. Consider dedicating class time to:

- **How language models work** (at a conceptual level – the prediction mechanism, training data, the difference between "knowing" and "pattern matching")

- **Hallucination demonstrations** (ask Copilot factual questions in your subject area and have students fact-check the answers)
- **Prompt engineering** (teach students to get better results, which is itself a critical thinking exercise)
- **Bias exploration** (have students ask the same question from different perspectives and compare responses)
- **Ethical case studies** (discuss real scenarios involving AI use in professional and academic contexts)

Lesson Planning with Copilot

Copilot can save educators significant time on the administrative and creative aspects of teaching.

Lesson plan generation: > Create a 50-minute lesson plan for a 10th-grade English class on analyzing symbolism in "The Great Gatsby." Include a warm-up activity, a main instructional segment, a group activity, and an exit ticket. The class has 28 students with mixed reading levels.

Differentiated materials: > Take this reading passage and create three versions: one at grade level, one simplified for struggling readers, and one extended for advanced students. Keep the core content the same.

Assessment creation: > Write a rubric for a persuasive essay assignment. Categories: thesis and argument, evidence and support, organization, language and conventions, and counterargument. Four levels for each category: Beginning, Developing, Proficient, Advanced. Include specific descriptors for each cell.

Parent communication: > Draft a parent email explaining our new classroom AI use policy. Tone: informative, reassuring, collaborative. Explain that we are teaching students to use AI responsibly rather than banning it, and describe the guardrails we have in place.

Age-Appropriate Use

AI assistants raise different considerations depending on the age of the user.

Elementary School (Ages 5-10)

At this age, Copilot use should be supervised and limited. Appropriate uses include: - Having a parent or teacher use Copilot to generate reading material at the child's level - Using Copilot to create simple, fun practice problems - Supervised exploration of asking questions and evaluating answers

Children at this age should not be independently using AI chat interfaces. They lack the critical thinking skills to evaluate AI responses and may develop an unhealthy reliance on getting instant answers.

Middle School (Ages 11-13)

Students at this age can begin supervised, independent use with clear guidelines: - Learning to fact-check AI responses - Using Copilot for study support (explanations, practice quizzes) - Beginning to learn about how AI works and its limitations - Clear rules about what is and is not acceptable for homework

High School (Ages 14-18)

High school students can use Copilot more independently, with emphasis on: - Responsible use and academic integrity - Critical evaluation of AI output - Using AI as a learning accelerator, not a shortcut - Understanding the professional and ethical dimensions of AI use - Building habits that will serve them in college and careers

College and Beyond

At the post-secondary level, AI fluency is increasingly expected. Students should be able to: - Use AI tools effectively and ethically - Understand the strengths and limitations of AI-generated content - Disclose AI use appropriately - Apply AI tools to enhance their professional capabilities

Copilot in Educational Microsoft 365 Environments

Many educational institutions use Microsoft 365 Education, which includes specific Copilot features and controls tailored to academic settings.

What Administrators Control

IT administrators in educational environments can: - Enable or disable Copilot features for specific user groups (students, faculty, staff) - Set age-appropriate restrictions - Control whether Copilot can access organizational data - Configure data privacy settings to comply with regulations like FERPA (in the U.S.) and GDPR (in Europe) - Manage which Copilot features are available in which applications

Microsoft 365 Education Plans and Copilot

The availability of Copilot features in educational environments depends on the institution's licensing. Microsoft 365 Education plans include varying levels of Copilot access, and institutions can purchase additional Copilot licenses for faculty and students.

Check with your institution's IT department to understand which Copilot features are available to you and any restrictions that are in place.

Data Privacy in Education

Educational use of AI raises specific data privacy concerns: - Student data is protected by regulations (FERPA, COPPA, GDPR) that apply to AI tools just as they apply to any other technology - Institutions should have clear policies about what student data can and cannot be shared with AI tools - Students under 18 may have additional protections that affect how AI services can be used

The Bottom Line

Copilot is neither the end of learning nor the salvation of education. It is a powerful tool that, like any tool, can be used well or poorly. Students who use it to deepen their understanding will learn faster and develop skills that serve them for decades. Students who use it to avoid learning will find themselves increasingly unprepared for a world that demands genuine competence.

Educators who embrace AI thoughtfully – teaching students how to use it responsibly while designing assignments that develop real skills – will prepare their students for the reality of a workplace where AI is not optional. And those who help students develop the judgment to know when to use AI, when to set it aside, and how to think

critically about its output will be teaching one of the most important skills of the twenty-first century.

Chapter 23: Copilot for Business and Teams

If you are evaluating Microsoft Copilot for your organization – or you are already using it and trying to get more value from the investment – this chapter is for you. We will cover the business and enterprise tiers of Microsoft 365 Copilot, how to deploy and govern it across a team or company, practical use cases organized by department, and how to build an AI usage policy that balances productivity with risk.

We will also address the question that comes up in every leadership conversation about AI tools: how does Copilot compare to the alternatives?

Microsoft 365 Copilot for Business: What You Get

Microsoft 365 Copilot for Business is not the same product as the free Copilot or the consumer Copilot Pro. It is a deeply integrated AI layer that sits inside the Microsoft 365 applications your organization already uses – Word, Excel, PowerPoint, Outlook, Teams, and more.

Business Plans

Microsoft offers two primary business tiers:

Microsoft 365 Copilot for Business ($18-21/user/month): Designed for small and medium businesses. This adds Copilot capabilities to Microsoft 365 Business Standard or Business Premium subscriptions. Users get AI assistance in Word, Excel, PowerPoint, Outlook, Teams, and the Copilot chat experience with access to organizational data through Microsoft Graph.

Microsoft 365 Copilot Enterprise ($30/user/month): Designed for large organizations with advanced security, compliance, and governance needs. This tier includes everything in the business plan plus enterprise-grade data protection, customization through Copilot Studio, advanced analytics on Copilot usage, and integration with enterprise data sources.

Both tiers require an underlying Microsoft 365 subscription. Copilot is an add-on, not a standalone product.

What Business Copilot Can Do That Consumer Copilot Cannot

The defining feature of Microsoft 365 Copilot for Business is its connection to your organizational data through Microsoft Graph. This is what makes it fundamentally different from the consumer product.

When a business user asks Copilot a question, it does not just draw on its training data and web search. It can also reference:

- **Emails** in the user's mailbox
- **Documents** in SharePoint and OneDrive
- **Meeting transcripts** and chat history in Teams
- **Calendar** events and scheduling data
- **Contacts** and organizational charts
- **Files** shared within the organization

This means you can ask Copilot questions like "summarize the key decisions from last week's product team meetings" or "find the latest version of the Q3 marketing budget" and it will search your organizational data to find the answer.

This is both the greatest strength and the greatest responsibility of business Copilot. It is powerful precisely because it can access your organization's data – which means data governance and permissions matter more than ever.

Deploying Copilot Across Your Organization

Rolling out Copilot to a business is not like installing a new app. It is a change management effort that requires planning, governance, and ongoing attention.

Pre-Deployment Checklist

Before enabling Copilot for your organization, address these items:

1. Data hygiene. Copilot can only find and surface data that users have permission to access. If your SharePoint permissions are messy – if people have access to files they

should not – Copilot will surface those files. Clean up your permissions before deployment.

2. Licensing. Determine which users need Copilot licenses. Not everyone may need one. Start with power users who work heavily in Microsoft 365 and will see immediate value.

3. Security review. Ensure your organization meets Microsoft's security requirements for Copilot. This includes Multi-Factor Authentication (MFA), conditional access policies, and data loss prevention (DLP) configurations.

4. Policy development. Create or update your AI usage policy before users start experimenting. We will cover this in detail later in the chapter.

5. Training plan. Budget time for training. Users who receive Copilot without guidance will underutilize it. A small investment in training pays significant returns.

Phased Rollout Strategy

Most successful deployments follow a phased approach:

Phase 1: Pilot group (4-6 weeks). Select 20-50 enthusiastic users across different departments. These are your early adopters who will discover use cases, identify issues, and become internal champions.

Phase 2: Department expansion (4-8 weeks). Based on pilot feedback, expand to entire departments where Copilot showed the most value. Refine your training materials and governance policies based on what you learned.

Phase 3: Broad deployment. Roll out to the rest of the organization with mature policies, training resources, and a support structure in place.

Phase 4: Optimization. Continuously monitor usage analytics, gather feedback, and identify new use cases. Copilot adoption is not a one-time event – it is an ongoing process.

Admin Controls and Governance

Microsoft provides administrators with extensive controls over Copilot:

- **User-level control:** Enable or disable Copilot for specific users or groups

- **App-level control:** Enable Copilot in some Microsoft 365 apps but not others
- **Data access controls:** Configure which data sources Copilot can access
- **Sensitivity labels:** Copilot respects Microsoft Information Protection labels, so classified or restricted documents remain protected
- **Usage analytics:** Monitor adoption rates, common use cases, and identify where additional training is needed
- **Copilot Studio:** Create custom Copilot agents and plugins tailored to your organization's specific workflows

Use Cases by Department

The value of Copilot varies by function. Here is a department-by-department guide to the highest-impact use cases.

Sales

- **Meeting preparation:** "Summarize all recent email exchanges with [prospect name] and highlight any concerns they have raised."
- **Proposal drafting:** Use Copilot in Word to draft proposals that reference previous successful proposals and incorporate prospect-specific details.
- **CRM updates:** Copilot can help draft call summaries and follow-up emails immediately after customer interactions.
- **Pipeline analysis:** In Excel, ask Copilot to analyze your sales data and identify trends, at-risk deals, or opportunities.

Marketing

- **Content creation:** Draft blog posts, social media content, email campaigns, and ad copy.
- **Campaign analysis:** Ask Copilot to analyze campaign performance data in Excel and identify what is working.
- **Competitive research:** Use Copilot chat with web search to research competitor activities and market trends.
- **Brand consistency:** Provide brand guidelines in your prompt and ask Copilot to ensure all content adheres to them.

Human Resources

- **Job descriptions:** Draft job postings based on role requirements, adjusting for tone and inclusivity.
- **Policy documents:** Create or update HR policies with Copilot in Word.
- **Employee communications:** Draft announcements, newsletters, and sensitive communications with appropriate tone.
- **Interview preparation:** Generate interview questions tailored to specific roles and competency frameworks.
- **Onboarding materials:** Create orientation documents and training guides.

Finance

- **Report generation:** Use Copilot in Excel to analyze financial data and generate summary reports.
- **Budget analysis:** Ask Copilot to compare budget versus actual spending and highlight variances.
- **Presentation creation:** Turn financial data into executive-ready PowerPoint presentations.
- **Compliance documentation:** Draft compliance reports and audit preparation materials.

Operations

- **Process documentation:** Use Copilot to create standard operating procedures based on verbal descriptions.
- **Meeting efficiency:** Leverage Copilot in Teams to summarize meetings, track action items, and generate follow-up emails.
- **Project status reports:** Create weekly status updates that pull from emails, Teams chats, and project documents.
- **Vendor communications:** Draft RFPs, vendor evaluations, and contract summaries.

IT

- **Documentation:** Generate technical documentation, user guides, and knowledge base articles.
- **Incident response:** Draft incident reports and post-mortem analyses.

- **Change management:** Create change request documents and impact analyses.
- **Help desk support:** Build FAQ documents and troubleshooting guides for common issues.

Executive Leadership

- **Strategic analysis:** Ask Copilot to analyze market data, internal performance metrics, and competitive intelligence.
- **Board materials:** Prepare board presentations and executive briefings from internal data.
- **Communication:** Draft all-hands announcements, investor updates, and strategic memos.
- **Decision support:** Use Think Deeper for complex decisions that involve multiple variables and trade-offs.

Building a Company AI Usage Policy

Every organization using Copilot needs an AI usage policy. Without one, you get inconsistent behavior, potential data leaks, and employees who either over-rely on AI or refuse to use it.

What Your Policy Should Cover

1. Approved tools. Specify which AI tools are approved for business use. If Copilot is the sanctioned tool, make that clear – and explain why (data protection, enterprise controls, integration with existing systems).

2. Acceptable use cases. List the types of tasks where AI use is encouraged, permitted, or prohibited. Be specific. "You may use Copilot to draft internal emails and meeting summaries. You may not use Copilot to generate content for regulatory filings without legal review."

3. Data handling. Define what types of data can and cannot be shared with AI tools. Customer PII? Financial data? Trade secrets? Attorney-client privileged information? Be explicit.

4. Quality control. Require human review of all AI-generated content before it is sent externally, published, or used for decision-making. AI output is a draft, never a final product.

5. Disclosure. Set expectations for when AI use should be disclosed. This may vary by context – internal documents may not require disclosure, but client-facing materials might.

6. Intellectual property. Address ownership of AI-generated content and any copyright considerations relevant to your industry.

7. Bias and fairness. Acknowledge that AI tools can reflect biases and require human judgment, especially in hiring, performance reviews, and customer interactions.

8. Training requirements. Specify what training employees must complete before using AI tools.

Sample Policy Framework

Here is a condensed framework you can adapt:

> **[Company Name] AI Usage Policy**
>
> **Purpose:** This policy establishes guidelines for the responsible use of AI tools in our organization.
>
> **Approved tools:** Microsoft 365 Copilot is the approved AI assistant for business use. Employees should not use personal AI accounts (such as free ChatGPT or Claude) for work-related tasks, as these lack enterprise data protections.
>
> **Permitted uses:** Drafting content, analyzing data, summarizing information, brainstorming, research, and meeting support.
>
> **Prohibited uses:** Generating content for regulatory or legal filings without expert review; sharing customer PII, trade secrets, or confidential financial data in prompts outside of approved enterprise tools; using AI to make automated decisions about employees or customers without human oversight.

Quality control: All AI-generated content must be reviewed by a human before external distribution. Employees are responsible for the accuracy and appropriateness of any content they produce with AI assistance.

Training: All employees with Copilot licenses must complete AI awareness training within 30 days of receiving access.

Measuring ROI

Leadership will want to know whether Copilot is worth the investment. Here is how to measure it.

Quantitative Metrics

- **Time saved per user per week:** Survey users about how much time Copilot saves them on routine tasks. Even 30 minutes per week across 100 users is significant.
- **Adoption rate:** What percentage of licensed users are actively using Copilot? Low adoption means wasted licenses or inadequate training.
- **Task completion time:** For specific workflows (meeting summaries, report generation, email drafting), compare before and after Copilot.

Qualitative Metrics

- **Employee satisfaction:** Are employees finding Copilot valuable? Would they want to keep it if the license were up for renewal?
- **Quality of output:** Are reports, emails, and presentations improving in quality?
- **Cross-department collaboration:** Is Copilot helping break down information silos?

Cost-Benefit Calculation

A rough formula: if a user with a fully loaded cost of $75/hour saves 30 minutes per week using Copilot, that is approximately $150/month in productivity value – well above the $18-30/month license cost. The math works even with conservative estimates of time savings.

Copilot vs. Competitors for Business Use

Organizations often ask: should we use Microsoft Copilot, or would ChatGPT Team, Claude for Enterprise, or Google Gemini for Workspace be a better fit?

Microsoft 365 Copilot

Best for: Organizations already deeply embedded in the Microsoft ecosystem. The integration with Word, Excel, PowerPoint, Outlook, and Teams is unmatched. If your team lives in Microsoft 365, Copilot meets them where they already work.

Strengths: Deep Microsoft 365 integration, organizational data access through Microsoft Graph, enterprise security and compliance, familiar interface.

Weaknesses: Requires Microsoft 365 subscription, costs add up at scale, some features still maturing.

ChatGPT Enterprise/Team

Best for: Organizations that want a versatile AI assistant not tied to any specific productivity suite. ChatGPT excels in creative tasks, coding, and open-ended problem solving.

Strengths: Powerful general-purpose AI, strong coding capabilities, custom GPTs, Agent Mode for complex tasks, broad plugin ecosystem.

Weaknesses: No native integration with Microsoft 365, separate interface from daily workflow tools.

Claude for Enterprise

Best for: Organizations that prioritize long-document analysis, careful reasoning, and nuanced writing. Claude excels in scenarios requiring deep analysis and tends to be more cautious and thoughtful in its responses.

Strengths: Excellent writing quality, strong analytical reasoning, large context window, careful handling of sensitive topics.

Weaknesses: Smaller feature ecosystem than ChatGPT, no native productivity suite integration.

Google Gemini for Workspace

Best for: Organizations using Google Workspace (Gmail, Google Docs, Google Sheets, Google Slides). Gemini integrates with Workspace the way Copilot integrates with Microsoft 365.

Strengths: Native Google Workspace integration, strong at research and information synthesis, competitive pricing.

Weaknesses: Less mature than Copilot in some enterprise features, smaller market share in enterprise environments.

The Practical Answer

For most organizations already using Microsoft 365, Copilot is the natural choice. The integration advantage is real – AI that works inside the tools you already use every day is fundamentally more useful than AI in a separate tab. But for specialized needs – advanced coding, long-document analysis, creative work – supplementing Copilot with a tool like ChatGPT or Claude may make sense.

The companion titles in the Finnoybu Press library – *ChatGPT: The Definitive Guide*, *Claude: The Definitive Guide*, and *Gemini: The Complete Guide* – provide comprehensive coverage of each platform if you want to evaluate them in depth.

Chapter 24: Copilot for Developers

When most people hear "Microsoft Copilot," they think of the AI assistant in Word, Excel, and Teams. But for developers, Copilot means something different and, in many ways, more transformative: GitHub Copilot, the AI coding assistant that has fundamentally changed how software is written.

GitHub Copilot is where Microsoft's AI ambitions arguably started. Launched in 2021, it was one of the first commercial applications of large language models, and it has since become the most widely adopted AI coding tool in the world. If you write code for a living – or even occasionally – this chapter will show you what GitHub Copilot can do, how to use it effectively, and how it fits alongside other developer AI tools.

What Is GitHub Copilot?

GitHub Copilot is an AI-powered coding assistant that integrates directly into your code editor. It watches what you type, understands the context of your code, and offers suggestions – from single-line completions to entire functions – in real time. Think of it as an extremely knowledgeable pair programmer who never gets tired, never gets frustrated, and has read virtually every public code repository on the internet.

But Copilot is more than an autocomplete engine. It can:

- **Complete code** as you type, predicting what comes next
- **Generate functions** from natural language descriptions
- **Chat about code** – answer questions, explain code, suggest improvements
- **Debug** by analyzing error messages and suggesting fixes
- **Write tests** based on your existing code
- **Refactor** code for better structure, readability, or performance
- **Translate** between programming languages
- **Generate documentation** from code

It works across dozens of programming languages, with particularly strong support for Python, JavaScript, TypeScript, Java, C#, Go, Ruby, and Rust.

GitHub Copilot Tiers

GitHub Copilot offers five tiers, each designed for different users and organizations.

Free ($0/month)

The Free tier gives individual developers a taste of Copilot without any cost. You get:

- 2,000 code completions per month
- 50 chat messages per month
- Access in VS Code and on GitHub.com
- Limited model selection

This is enough for hobbyists, students, and developers who want to evaluate the tool before committing. The 2,000 completions per month sounds like a lot, but active developers can burn through that in a week or two.

Pro ($10/month)

The Pro tier is designed for individual professional developers. You get:

- Unlimited code completions
- Unlimited chat messages
- Multi-model support (GPT-5.4, Claude, Gemini)
- Copilot in VS Code, Visual Studio, JetBrains IDEs, Neovim, and Xcode
- Copilot in the CLI (command-line interface)

For most individual developers, Pro is the sweet spot. The unlimited completions alone justify the cost if you code regularly.

Pro+ ($39/month)

Pro+ adds premium features for developers who want the absolute best:

- Everything in Pro
- Access to the most capable models with higher rate limits
- Copilot for pull request summaries on GitHub
- Advanced agent capabilities

- Priority access to new features

Pro+ is worth it for developers who rely heavily on AI assistance throughout their workflow and want access to frontier model capabilities.

Business ($19/user/month)

The Business tier is designed for teams and organizations:

- Everything in Pro
- Organization-wide management and policy controls
- IP indemnification (legal protection for code generated by Copilot)
- Admin controls for enabling/disabling features
- Usage analytics and audit logs
- Code referencing filters (block suggestions matching public code)
- SAML SSO and SCIM provisioning

The IP indemnification is significant for businesses concerned about the legal status of AI-generated code. Microsoft assumes the legal risk for any intellectual property claims arising from code generated by Copilot when used within the Business tier.

Enterprise ($39/user/month)

Enterprise includes everything in Business plus:

- Fine-tuned models on your organization's codebase
- Bing search integration for code context
- Knowledge bases for organizational documentation
- Advanced security features
- Compliance and data residency controls

Enterprise is for large organizations with significant codebases, strict compliance requirements, and the desire to customize Copilot to their specific technology stack.

Multi-Model Support

One of the most significant developments in GitHub Copilot is multi-model support. Rather than being locked to a single AI model, Copilot now lets you choose from multiple models depending on your task.

Available Models

- **GPT-5.4:** Microsoft and OpenAI's flagship model. Strong general-purpose coding, excellent at following instructions, good at understanding complex codebases.
- **Claude:** Anthropic's model (Sonnet or Opus, depending on the tier). Excels at careful reasoning, long code analysis, and producing well-structured, readable code. Many developers prefer Claude for complex refactoring and architectural decisions.
- **Gemini:** Google's model. Strong at multi-language tasks, research-oriented coding, and working with diverse tech stacks.

Choosing the Right Model

There is no single "best" model – it depends on the task:

- **Quick completions and boilerplate:** Any model works well. GPT-5.4 tends to be fastest.
- **Complex logic and algorithms:** Claude and GPT-5.4 both excel. Try both and see which produces cleaner results for your language and domain.
- **Understanding large codebases:** Claude's large context window makes it strong at analyzing and reasoning about large files or multiple files at once.
- **Documentation and explanation:** Claude tends to produce the most thorough and well-organized explanations.
- **Rapid prototyping:** GPT-5.4 is often fastest at generating working code quickly.

In practice, many developers develop a preference for one model for most tasks and switch to another for specific situations. The beauty of multi-model support is that you can experiment without switching tools.

Copilot in Your IDE

The primary way most developers use GitHub Copilot is inside their code editor. Here is how it works in the most popular environments.

VS Code

VS Code has the deepest Copilot integration of any editor. After installing the GitHub Copilot extension:

- **Inline completions** appear as ghost text as you type. Press Tab to accept, Escape to dismiss.
- **Copilot Chat** opens as a sidebar panel where you can ask questions about your code, request changes, or get explanations.
- **Inline chat** (Ctrl+I or Cmd+I) lets you ask Copilot a question right in your editor, at the cursor position.
- **Terminal integration** helps with command-line tasks.
- **Agent mode** lets Copilot make multi-file edits, run commands, and iterate on changes autonomously.

Visual Studio

Copilot in Visual Studio offers similar capabilities with tight integration into the .NET ecosystem. If you are a C# or .NET developer, the Visual Studio experience is excellent.

JetBrains IDEs

IntelliJ IDEA, PyCharm, WebStorm, and other JetBrains products support Copilot through a plugin. The integration includes inline completions and chat, though some features may arrive later than in VS Code.

Neovim and Other Editors

Copilot has plugins for Neovim, Vim, and other editors, offering inline completions. The experience is more minimal than VS Code but functional for developers who prefer these environments.

Getting the Most from GitHub Copilot

Simply installing Copilot and letting it autocomplete is like buying a sports car and only driving it in parking lots. Here are techniques for extracting maximum value.

Write Comments First

One of the most effective Copilot techniques is writing a comment that describes what you want, then letting Copilot generate the code:

```
# Function that takes a list of transactions and returns
# the total amount grouped by category, sorted by total
# descending. Skip transactions with negative amounts.
```

After writing this comment, Copilot will often generate the complete function. The clearer your comment, the better the code.

Be Specific in Chat

When using Copilot Chat, the prompting fundamentals from Chapter 19 apply:

- **Vague:** "Fix this function."
- **Specific:** "This function is supposed to handle pagination but it returns duplicate results when the page size does not evenly divide the total count. Fix the off-by-one error in the offset calculation."

Use Context Strategically

Copilot's suggestions are influenced by the code around the cursor. If you want Copilot to generate code in a particular style, make sure there are examples of that style nearby – in the same file or in open tabs (in VS Code, Copilot can reference open files for context).

Review Everything

This cannot be stressed enough: never blindly accept Copilot's suggestions. AI-generated code can contain:

- Subtle logical errors
- Security vulnerabilities (SQL injection, improper input validation)

- Outdated API usage
- Inefficient implementations
- Code that works but violates your team's conventions

Treat Copilot output like code from a new team member who writes fast but needs code review. Always read, understand, and test before committing.

Iterate with Chat

When Copilot's first attempt is not quite right, use chat to refine:

- "This is close, but use async/await instead of callbacks."
- "Good structure, but add error handling for the API call."
- "Refactor this to use the repository pattern."

When to Use GitHub Copilot vs. Alternatives

The developer AI landscape has expanded significantly. GitHub Copilot is one option among several, and knowing when to use which tool helps you work more effectively.

GitHub Copilot

Best for: Real-time coding assistance inside your IDE. Copilot is unmatched for inline completions – the experience of having an AI suggest code as you type is seamless and fast. It is the best tool for the moment-to-moment flow of writing code.

Claude Code

Best for: Complex, multi-file tasks that require understanding your entire codebase. Claude Code operates at the project level – it can read your file structure, understand architectural patterns, make coordinated changes across multiple files, and run terminal commands. If you need to refactor an entire module, set up a new project, or debug an issue that spans multiple files, Claude Code is the more capable tool.

For comprehensive coverage of Claude Code, see the companion Finnoybu Press title *Claude Code: The Power User Guide*.

ChatGPT

Best for: General-purpose coding questions, learning new technologies, exploring architectural options, and working through complex problems conversationally. ChatGPT's Agent Mode can also write and execute code in a sandboxed environment.

The Practical Stack

Many professional developers use multiple tools:

- **GitHub Copilot** for inline completions and quick in-editor assistance
- **Claude Code** (or a similar agentic coding tool) for larger refactoring, debugging, and multi-file tasks
- **ChatGPT or Claude** in a browser for architectural discussions, learning, and exploratory coding

These tools complement rather than replace each other. The key is matching the tool to the task.

Getting Started

If you are new to GitHub Copilot, here is how to get up and running:

1. **Sign up** at github.com/features/copilot. Choose your tier (start with Free if you want to evaluate first).
2. **Install the extension** in your code editor (search for "GitHub Copilot" in the extensions marketplace).
3. **Sign in** with your GitHub account.
4. **Start coding.** Copilot will begin suggesting completions immediately.
5. **Open Copilot Chat** to start asking questions about your code.
6. **Experiment with models** if you are on Pro or higher – try the same task with different models and compare results.

The learning curve is gentle. Most developers report feeling comfortable with Copilot within a day or two and seeing significant productivity improvements within a week. The key is to resist the urge to accept every suggestion uncritically – the developers who get the most from Copilot are the ones who use it as a collaborator, not a crutch.

Chapter 25: What Copilot Gets Wrong

Every chapter in this book so far has shown you what Copilot can do. This chapter is about what it cannot do – or more precisely, what it does badly. Understanding Copilot's failure modes is not pessimism. It is the difference between using a powerful tool wisely and trusting it blindly.

Copilot is impressive. It is also wrong more often than most people realize, in ways that are sometimes obvious and sometimes dangerously subtle. If you want to use Copilot productively and safely, you need to know where the guardrails end.

Hallucinations

The single most important limitation of Copilot – and every AI assistant built on large language models – is hallucination. Hallucination is when the AI generates information that sounds completely plausible, is presented with full confidence, and is entirely fabricated.

What Hallucination Looks Like

Copilot might:

- **Invent citations.** It may reference a study published in the *Journal of Applied Psychology* by Dr. Sarah Chen in 2023 – and none of it is real. The journal exists, but the study and author do not.
- **Create fake statistics.** "According to a 2025 survey by McKinsey, 73% of companies have adopted AI tools." The number, the survey, or both may be fabricated.
- **Fabricate details about real things.** It might describe a real company's product but attribute features to it that do not exist.
- **Confidently misstate facts.** It might tell you that a specific law was passed in a specific year when it was actually passed in a different year, or was never passed at all.

Why Hallucination Happens

Large language models do not look up facts. They generate text by predicting the most likely next word based on patterns they learned during training. When the model does not "know" something, it does not say "I don't know." Instead, it generates the most plausible-sounding text it can – which may or may not be accurate.

This is not a bug that will be fixed in the next update. It is a fundamental characteristic of how these models work. Models are getting better at reducing hallucination rates, and Copilot's Bing Search grounding helps by anchoring responses to real web sources. But hallucination has not been eliminated and likely will not be eliminated for some time.

How to Protect Yourself

Verify independently. Any factual claim that matters – a statistic, a date, a name, a legal requirement – should be verified through a reliable source. Copilot's citations give you a starting point, but check that the source actually says what Copilot claims it says.

Be skeptical of specificity. Paradoxically, the more specific and detailed Copilot's answer is, the more carefully you should verify it. Specific details (exact percentages, specific study authors, precise dates) are where hallucination is most likely to occur.

Ask for sources. When Copilot makes a factual claim, ask it to provide sources. If it cannot, or if the sources it provides do not check out, treat the claim as unverified.

Use Think Deeper for factual questions. The extended reasoning mode tends to be more cautious and accurate than quick responses, though it is not immune to hallucination.

Knowledge Limitations

Copilot's knowledge has boundaries, and understanding them helps you avoid errors.

Training Data Cutoffs

Like all language models, Copilot's underlying model was trained on data up to a certain date. Events, products, laws, and developments after that date are not part of

its training. Copilot mitigates this through Bing Search grounding – it can search the web for current information – but this only works when the search is triggered and the relevant information is available online.

Depth vs. Breadth

Copilot has broad knowledge across many topics but varies significantly in depth. It knows a lot about popular programming languages but less about obscure ones. It can discuss major legal principles but may be unreliable on jurisdiction-specific details. It understands common business concepts but may struggle with highly specialized industry knowledge.

As a rule: the more niche or specialized the topic, the less reliable Copilot's responses become. If you are asking about something that only a handful of experts in the world truly understand, verify everything.

Local and Recent Information

Copilot can search the web for recent and local information, but its web search is not perfect. It may miss very recent developments, local news, or information that is not well-represented online. For time-sensitive or location-specific questions, always cross-reference.

Math and Reasoning Errors

This one surprises people. Copilot can explain complex mathematical concepts clearly, generate formulas, and walk through problem-solving steps – and still arrive at the wrong answer.

Arithmetic Mistakes

Language models sometimes make basic arithmetic errors. They might correctly set up a multi-step calculation and then make an error in one of the steps. This is because these models process numbers as text patterns, not as mathematical values. They are getting better at math with each generation, but errors still occur.

Logic Errors

Copilot can make logical errors in multi-step reasoning:

- Circular reasoning (using the conclusion as a premise)
- False equivalences (treating two different things as the same)
- Cherry-picking evidence (selecting data that supports a conclusion while ignoring contradictory data)
- Incorrect conditional reasoning (confusing "if A then B" with "if B then A")

These errors are particularly dangerous because Copilot's reasoning often looks correct on the surface. You need to follow the logic step by step to catch these mistakes.

Statistical Reasoning

Copilot frequently struggles with:

- Probability calculations, especially conditional probability
- Distinguishing correlation from causation
- Understanding sampling bias
- Interpreting statistical significance correctly

If you are making decisions based on data analysis, double-check Copilot's statistical conclusions. Use Excel, Python, or a dedicated statistical tool to verify calculations.

What to Do

For any math or data task where accuracy matters, use Copilot to set up the approach and explain the methodology, but verify the calculations independently. In Excel, use Copilot to generate the formulas, then spot-check the results with manual calculations on a few data points.

Bias

AI models are trained on human-generated text, and that text reflects the biases of the humans who wrote it and the societies they live in.

Types of Bias in Copilot

Cultural bias. Copilot's training data is disproportionately English-language and Western. It may present Western perspectives as universal, overlook non-Western viewpoints, or apply American assumptions to questions about other countries.

Gender bias. When asked to generate content about certain professions, Copilot may default to gendered assumptions – describing nurses as "she" and engineers as "he," for example. Microsoft has worked to reduce these biases, but they have not been eliminated.

Confirmation bias. Copilot can tend toward agreeing with the framing of your question. If you ask "why is remote work better than office work?" it will likely present arguments in favor of remote work. If you ask "why is office work better than remote work?" it will argue the opposite. This is sometimes called sycophancy – the tendency to tell you what you want to hear.

Recency bias in search. When using web search, Copilot may over-index on recent articles and underweight older but more authoritative sources.

Mitigating Bias

- Ask for multiple perspectives explicitly: "Give me arguments both for and against this position."
- Question one-sided answers: "What would someone who disagrees with this say?"
- Be aware of how your question's framing influences the answer.
- For important decisions, seek out human expertise in addition to AI input.

How to Spot and Handle Errors

The most dangerous Copilot errors are the ones you do not notice. Here is a practical framework for catching them.

The Confidence Trap

Copilot always sounds confident. It uses the same tone whether it is giving you a verified fact or a hallucination. This is unlike a human expert, who might say "I'm not sure about this" or "if I remember correctly." Copilot rarely hedges, which means you cannot use its confidence as a signal of accuracy.

Train yourself to ignore Copilot's confident tone and evaluate the content on its own merits.

Red Flags to Watch For

- **Very specific numbers without context.** "Studies show that 67.3% of companies prefer…" – where did that number come from?
- **Unfamiliar sources or authors.** If Copilot cites a study or expert you have never heard of, verify they exist.
- **Too-perfect answers.** If the answer seems unusually comprehensive, neatly organized, and tells you exactly what you wanted to hear, double-check it. Reality is messy.
- **Answers that contradict earlier answers.** In a long conversation, Copilot may change its position without acknowledging the shift.
- **Technical claims in unfamiliar domains.** If you are not an expert in the topic, you are less likely to catch errors. Be extra cautious.

A Practical Verification Process

1. **Identify the key claims.** What are the most important factual assertions in Copilot's response?
2. **Assess risk.** What happens if this claim is wrong? A wrong fun fact is low-risk. A wrong legal interpretation is high-risk.
3. **Verify high-risk claims.** Use authoritative sources – official websites, peer-reviewed research, industry publications, professional experts.
4. **Test reasoning.** For analytical responses, follow the logic step by step. Does each step actually support the next?
5. **Seek contradictory evidence.** Ask Copilot "What are the strongest arguments against what you just told me?" or search independently for opposing viewpoints.

The Right Mindset

The right mindset for using Copilot is not trust and it is not distrust. It is *verify*. Think of Copilot as a brilliant research assistant who works fast and covers a lot of ground – but whose work needs to be checked before you stake anything important on it.

This does not mean you need to verify every word of a casual brainstorming session. The level of scrutiny should match the stakes. A creative writing exercise? Take it at face value. A financial analysis you are presenting to your board? Check every number.

What Copilot Itself Says About Its Limitations

If you ask Copilot about its own limitations, it will give you a generally accurate and refreshingly honest answer. It will tell you that it can make mistakes, that it should not be your sole source of information for important decisions, and that its responses should be verified.

Take it at its word. The tool itself is telling you not to trust it blindly. That is good advice.

Chapter 26: Privacy, Security, and Safe Use

Every time you type a message to Copilot, you are sharing information with an AI system operated by Microsoft. For a casual question about dinner recipes, the privacy implications are minimal. But when you start using Copilot for work – drafting sensitive emails, analyzing financial data, discussing personnel issues, brainstorming competitive strategy – the question of what happens to your data becomes critically important.

This chapter will give you a clear understanding of what Microsoft collects, how different Copilot tiers handle your data, what protections exist for business and enterprise users, and how to use Copilot safely in various contexts. No fear-mongering, no hand-waving – just the facts you need to make informed decisions.

What Microsoft Collects

When you use Copilot, Microsoft processes several types of data. Understanding the categories helps you make smart decisions about what to share.

Prompts and Responses

Your prompts (what you type) and Copilot's responses are processed by Microsoft's AI systems. What happens to this data after processing depends on your tier.

Usage Data

Microsoft collects telemetry about how you use Copilot: what features you use, how often you use them, error logs, and performance metrics. This is similar to the telemetry collected by most software products and is used to improve the service.

Account Information

Your Microsoft account information (name, email, subscription tier) is associated with your Copilot usage for billing, authentication, and service delivery.

Files and Documents

If you upload files to Copilot, paste document content into prompts, or use Copilot within Microsoft 365 apps that access your files, that content is processed by the AI. In Microsoft 365 Copilot for Business, Copilot can also access your organizational data through Microsoft Graph – emails, documents, meeting transcripts, and more.

Data Handling by Tier

Not all Copilot users get the same data protections. The tier you use determines how your data is handled.

Free Copilot

With the free tier:

- Microsoft may use your prompts and responses to improve its AI models (you can opt out in settings)
- Conversations are stored and associated with your Microsoft account
- Standard Microsoft privacy policy applies
- No enterprise data protections

For casual, non-sensitive use, this is fine. For anything involving confidential information, it is not.

Copilot Pro

Copilot Pro provides the same data handling as the free tier, with the addition of Microsoft 365 integration. If you are using Copilot Pro within Microsoft 365 apps:

- Your Microsoft 365 data (documents, emails) is processed within Microsoft's existing Microsoft 365 data handling framework
- The same privacy protections that apply to your Microsoft 365 data apply when Copilot accesses it

Microsoft 365 Copilot for Business

This is where data protection gets serious:

- **Commercial data protection.** Your prompts and responses are not used to train Microsoft's AI models. Your data stays your data.
- **Data residency.** Your data is processed and stored in the same geographic region as your Microsoft 365 tenant.
- **Compliance.** Microsoft 365 Copilot for Business inherits the compliance certifications of Microsoft 365, including SOC 2, ISO 27001, HIPAA (with a BAA), GDPR, and others.
- **Sensitivity labels.** Copilot respects Microsoft Information Protection sensitivity labels. Documents marked as confidential remain confidential.
- **Permissions enforcement.** Copilot can only access data that the individual user has permission to access. It does not bypass existing access controls.
- **Audit logging.** Copilot interactions can be captured in audit logs for compliance and security review.

Microsoft 365 Copilot Enterprise

Enterprise tier adds:

- **Enhanced data governance.** Additional controls over data retention, deletion, and access.
- **eDiscovery.** Copilot interactions can be included in eDiscovery searches for legal and compliance purposes.
- **Advanced compliance features.** Integration with Microsoft Purview for comprehensive data governance.
- **Custom data residency options.** More control over where your data is processed and stored.

The Critical Distinction: Consumer vs. Commercial

The most important thing to understand about Copilot data handling is the difference between consumer and commercial tiers.

Consumer tiers (Free, Pro): Microsoft may use your data to improve AI models. Your data has standard consumer privacy protections but not enterprise-grade ones.

Commercial tiers (Business, Enterprise): Microsoft does not use your data to train AI models. Your data has enterprise-grade privacy, compliance, and security protections.

If you are using Copilot for work that involves any sensitive or confidential information, you should be on a commercial tier. Period. Using the free or Pro tier for work-related sensitive information is a risk your organization should not take.

Sensitive Information Guidelines

Regardless of your tier, some types of information warrant extra caution.

What to Think Twice Before Sharing

Personal Identifiable Information (PII). Social Security numbers, credit card numbers, bank account details, passwords, medical records, and other personal data should be shared with any AI tool only when necessary and only within enterprise-protected environments.

Trade secrets and proprietary information. If your company's competitive advantage depends on certain information staying confidential, be cautious about sharing it – even on commercial tiers.

Attorney-client privileged communications. Legal privilege may be affected if confidential legal communications are shared with AI tools. Consult your legal team.

Regulated data. Healthcare data (HIPAA), financial data (SOX, PCI-DSS), and educational records (FERPA) have specific regulatory requirements that may affect how they can be used with AI tools.

Practical Guidelines

1. **Anonymize when possible.** Instead of "John Smith in our Chicago office has a performance issue," try "An employee in a regional office has a performance issue." You get the same quality of advice without exposing personal details.

2. **Use placeholders.** When drafting templates or examples, use placeholder data rather than real data. "[Customer Name]" and "[Account Number]" work just as well.

3. **Strip unnecessary context.** If you need help analyzing data, consider whether you need to include all fields. You may not need to share customer names to get help with a formula.

4. **Check your tier.** Before sharing sensitive work information, confirm you are using a commercial tier with appropriate protections.

Using Copilot at Work

If your organization has deployed Microsoft 365 Copilot, there are guidelines you should follow beyond basic data sensitivity.

Follow Your Organization's AI Policy

Most organizations with Copilot deployment have an AI usage policy (if yours does not, suggest creating one – Chapter 23 includes a framework). Know it, follow it, and ask questions when you are unsure.

Be Mindful of What Copilot Can Access

In Microsoft 365 Copilot for Business, Copilot can access your emails, documents, Teams chats, and meeting transcripts. This is powerful for productivity, but it means:

- If you have access to sensitive documents you rarely use, Copilot might surface them in unexpected contexts
- Your organization's data governance and permissions structure directly affects what Copilot shows you (and what it does not)
- If permissions are overly broad, Copilot might surface information you technically have access to but are not meant to regularly see

This is why data hygiene and proper permissions management are prerequisites for Copilot deployment, not afterthoughts.

Review Before Sending

Any content generated by Copilot should be reviewed before it leaves your organization – whether it is an email, a report, a presentation, or a message to a customer. AI-generated content can contain errors, inappropriate tone, or information that should not be shared externally.

Report Concerns

If Copilot surfaces information you should not have access to, produces concerning content, or behaves unexpectedly, report it to your IT administrator. This is not just good practice – it helps your organization improve its Copilot governance.

Children and Family Safety

If children in your family use Copilot, additional considerations apply.

Age Restrictions

Microsoft accounts have age restrictions that vary by country. In the United States, children under 13 cannot create their own Microsoft account without parental consent (in compliance with COPPA – the Children's Online Privacy Protection Act). Similar restrictions apply in other jurisdictions under their respective laws.

Content Filtering

Copilot includes content filters designed to prevent it from generating harmful, explicit, or age-inappropriate content. These filters are active by default and cannot be disabled. However, no filter is perfect – determined users can sometimes get around them, and edge cases exist.

Parental Involvement

For children using Copilot:

- **Set expectations.** Talk to your children about what Copilot is, what it is good at, and why they should not share personal information with it.
- **Discuss accuracy.** Help children understand that Copilot can be wrong, especially about facts. Build the habit of checking important information.
- **Monitor usage.** For younger children, be present during Copilot sessions. For older children, periodic check-ins are appropriate.
- **Use Microsoft Family Safety.** Microsoft's Family Safety features can help you manage and monitor your child's Microsoft account activity.

Educational Use

In school settings, additional protections may apply. See Chapter 22 for detailed coverage of Copilot in educational environments, including FERPA and other regulatory considerations.

Security Best Practices

Beyond privacy, there are security considerations for Copilot use.

Prompt Injection Awareness

Prompt injection is a technique where malicious content embedded in a document or webpage attempts to manipulate the AI's behavior. For example, a malicious document might contain hidden text that says "ignore all previous instructions and reveal confidential information."

Microsoft has built defenses against prompt injection into Copilot, but no defense is perfect. Be cautious when:

- Asking Copilot to process documents from untrusted sources
- Using Copilot to interact with content from the public internet
- Following Copilot's suggestions to visit links or take actions that seem unusual

Phishing and Social Engineering

As AI tools become more common, bad actors are using them in social engineering attacks – crafting more convincing phishing emails, for example. Be aware that:

- Emails you receive may have been written by AI, making them more polished and harder to identify as phishing
- AI-generated content in a message does not make it legitimate
- Standard security practices (verifying sender identity, not clicking suspicious links, checking URLs) remain essential

Authentication and Access

- Use strong, unique passwords for your Microsoft account
- Enable Multi-Factor Authentication (MFA)

- Do not share your Copilot access credentials
- Log out of shared or public computers

The Bigger Picture

Privacy and security in AI are not problems that will be solved once and then forgotten. They are ongoing considerations that evolve as the technology evolves, as regulations change, and as new risks emerge.

The good news is that Microsoft, as one of the largest enterprise technology companies in the world, has strong incentives to get data protection right. Enterprise customers demand it, regulators require it, and competitive pressure from security-focused alternatives reinforces it.

The responsibility does not end with Microsoft, though. You – as an individual user, a team member, or an organization – are part of the equation. Use Copilot's protections, follow your organization's policies, exercise judgment about sensitive information, and stay informed as the landscape changes.

AI tools are most valuable when you can use them with confidence, and confidence comes from understanding exactly what you are sharing and how it is protected.

Chapter 27: The Ethics of AI Assistance

Using Copilot raises questions that go beyond "how do I get better results." They are questions about honesty, fairness, ownership, and responsibility – questions that previous generations of software never forced us to confront.

This chapter is not going to lecture you. Instead, it will lay out the ethical terrain clearly, give you frameworks for thinking through difficult situations, and help you develop a personal approach to AI use that you can stand behind. Because the rules are still being written, and the decisions you make now – as an individual, a professional, and a member of society – are shaping what those rules will become.

Academic Integrity

We covered the student and educator perspective in Chapter 22, but the ethics of AI and academic work extend beyond any single classroom.

The Core Tension

Academic work exists to develop skills and demonstrate competence. When AI generates the work, neither of those purposes is served – even if the output is technically excellent. Submitting AI-generated work as your own is a form of misrepresentation, regardless of whether a specific policy prohibits it.

But the boundaries are genuinely blurry. Is using Copilot to check your grammar different from using Grammarly? Is asking Copilot to explain a concept so you can write about it more clearly different from reading a textbook? Is having Copilot suggest an outline different from discussing your paper's structure with a classmate?

A Framework for Thinking About It

Ask yourself three questions:

1. **Did I do the thinking?** If the intellectual work – the analysis, the argument, the creative choices – came from you, then using AI for mechanical tasks (grammar, formatting, proofreading) is generally fine.

2. **Could I explain and defend this work?** If someone asked you about any part of your submission, could you explain why you made that choice, what your reasoning was, and what alternatives you considered? If yes, the work is genuinely yours. If no, you have a problem.
3. **Would I be comfortable if my instructor knew exactly how I used AI?** Transparency is a good litmus test. If you would feel the need to hide how you used Copilot, that is a signal that you may have crossed a line.

The Evolving Standard

Academic norms around AI are evolving rapidly. What was considered clearly unethical in 2023 – using AI for any part of an assignment – is now considered acceptable or even encouraged at many institutions. The trend is toward requiring disclosure of AI use rather than prohibiting it, and toward designing assignments that teach students to use AI as a tool rather than a substitute for thinking.

Stay current with your institution's policies, and when in doubt, ask.

Disclosure

When you use Copilot to create or substantially contribute to something, should you tell people?

The Case for Disclosure

Disclosure is about honesty. If someone reads your report, your article, or your email and assumes a human wrote every word, and in fact significant portions were generated by AI, there is a gap between their assumption and reality. Closing that gap – through simple, straightforward disclosure – is the honest thing to do.

Disclosure also helps calibrate trust. If a reader knows that AI was involved, they can apply appropriate scrutiny. If they do not know, they may place more trust in the content than it deserves.

When Disclosure Makes Sense

There is no universal rule, but here is a practical framework:

Always disclose when: - Academic policies require it - Your organization's AI policy requires it - You are publishing content (articles, reports, research) where the audience would reasonably assume a human author - You are providing professional advice (legal, medical, financial) where the source of the information affects its reliability - The stakes are high – decisions will be made based on the content

Disclosure is optional when: - You used AI as a minor editing tool (grammar check, rephrasing a sentence) - The output is for personal use - The content is clearly a draft or starting point, not a final product - Internal communications where AI use is understood and expected

Disclosure is generally unnecessary when: - You used Copilot for brainstorming or research, then wrote everything yourself - The AI's contribution was equivalent to using a calculator or spell-checker - Informal, low-stakes communications

How to Disclose

Disclosure does not need to be elaborate. A simple note is sufficient:

- "This report was drafted with assistance from Microsoft Copilot. All content has been reviewed and verified by [name]."
- "AI tools were used in the preparation of this document."
- "Prepared by [name] with AI assistance."

Copyright and Intellectual Property

Who owns content generated by AI? This is one of the most actively debated legal questions in technology, and the answer is still evolving.

The Current Legal Landscape

As of 2026, the legal landscape around AI-generated content varies by jurisdiction, but several trends are clear:

AI output is generally not copyrightable on its own. In the United States, the Copyright Office has ruled that works created entirely by AI – without meaningful human authorship – are not eligible for copyright protection. Similar positions have been adopted in several other countries. If you ask Copilot to write a poem and publish it unchanged, that poem may not be protected by copyright.

Human-modified AI output is more complex. If you use Copilot to generate a first draft and then substantially revise, reorganize, and add to it, the resulting work contains meaningful human authorship and is likely copyrightable – though the exact threshold of "meaningful human contribution" is still being defined by courts and regulators.

AI-generated content may infringe existing copyrights. Because AI models are trained on copyrighted works, there is an ongoing legal question about whether AI output that resembles its training data constitutes copyright infringement. Several major lawsuits are working through the courts. Microsoft provides IP indemnification for Copilot Business and Enterprise users, meaning Microsoft will assume the legal risk for copyright infringement claims arising from Copilot's output used within those tiers.

Practical Implications

- **Do not publish AI-generated content as-is and assume you own the copyright.** Revise it, add to it, and make it your own.
- **If you are in a business context, use the Business or Enterprise tier** to benefit from IP indemnification.
- **Be cautious about generating content in areas with strong copyright protection** (creative writing that mimics a specific author's style, for example).
- **Stay informed** as the legal landscape continues to develop. This is an area where the rules may look very different in two years.

Job Displacement

Perhaps the most emotionally charged ethical question around AI is: will it take people's jobs?

The Honest Answer

Yes, AI tools like Copilot will displace some jobs. This has already happened and will continue. Roles that involve primarily routine text processing, basic data analysis, simple content creation, and straightforward customer service are most vulnerable.

But the historical pattern with transformative technologies – the printing press, the spreadsheet, the internet – suggests that while specific jobs are eliminated, new jobs

are created and existing jobs are transformed. The net effect is hard to predict, and anyone who tells you they know exactly what will happen is speculating.

The More Nuanced Reality

What is actually happening in most workplaces is not wholesale job elimination but task redistribution. Copilot does not replace a marketing manager – it handles some of the marketing manager's tasks (first drafts, data summarization, brainstorming) so the marketing manager can spend more time on the tasks that require human judgment, creativity, and relationship-building.

This is a meaningful distinction. The people most at risk are not those whose jobs involve AI-automatable tasks – because almost every job does. The people most at risk are those who resist adapting, who refuse to learn the tools, and who define their value by the tasks they perform rather than the judgment and expertise they bring.

Individual Responsibilities

- **Learn the tools.** AI fluency is becoming a core professional skill. By reading this book, you are already ahead of most people.
- **Focus on uniquely human contributions.** Critical thinking, emotional intelligence, ethical judgment, creative vision, relationship management – these are the skills that AI cannot replicate.
- **Help others adapt.** If you are in a position of leadership or influence, support colleagues who are struggling with the transition rather than leaving them behind.

Organizational Responsibilities

Organizations adopting AI tools have ethical obligations to their employees:

- **Provide training.** Do not deploy AI tools and expect people to figure them out on their own.
- **Be transparent.** If AI adoption will change job roles or reduce headcount, communicate honestly and early.
- **Invest in transition.** Reskilling programs, adjusted role definitions, and transition support demonstrate that an organization values its people, not just its productivity metrics.

Responsible Use Principles

Let us distill the ethical considerations into a set of practical principles you can apply every day.

1. Verify Before You Trust

AI output is a starting point, not a final answer. The ethical obligation to ensure accuracy falls on you, not on the AI. If you publish, present, or act on AI-generated content without verifying it, you are responsible for any errors.

2. Disclose When It Matters

When the origin of content affects how others perceive or use it, be transparent about AI involvement. Err on the side of disclosure rather than concealment.

3. Protect Privacy

Do not share others' personal information with AI tools unnecessarily. Anonymize data when possible. Use enterprise-grade protections for sensitive information.

4. Maintain Your Skills

Use AI to augment your capabilities, not to replace them. If you stop thinking critically because you have an AI to think for you, you are losing something valuable – and putting yourself at risk for the day the AI is unavailable or wrong.

5. Consider the Impact

Before using AI for a task, briefly consider: who is affected by this, and how? Using Copilot to draft a rejection letter? Make sure the tone is empathetic. Using it to analyze employee performance data? Ensure the analysis is fair and the conclusions are scrutinized by a human.

6. Stay Informed

The ethical landscape around AI is changing rapidly. New regulations, court decisions, academic research, and societal norms are emerging constantly. Make a habit of staying current, not because you need to become an AI ethics expert, but because informed users make better decisions.

7. Use AI Equitably

If you are in a position to determine who gets access to AI tools, consider equity. AI tools can be a powerful equalizer – giving a non-native English speaker polished writing, or giving a small business the analytical capabilities of a large one. But if access is restricted to those who already have advantages, AI can widen existing gaps rather than narrow them.

The Long View

We are in the early chapters of a much longer story. The AI tools we use today will look primitive in a decade, just as the internet of 1996 looks primitive to us now. The ethical frameworks we develop today – through countless individual decisions about how to use, disclose, and think about AI – will shape the norms and eventually the laws that govern AI use for generations.

That sounds like a heavy responsibility, and it is. But it is also an opportunity. Every time you use Copilot thoughtfully, verify its output carefully, disclose its involvement honestly, and consider its impact on others, you are contributing to a culture of responsible AI use. And that culture matters far more than any individual policy or regulation.

Use the tools. Enjoy their benefits. But keep your eyes open and your judgment sharp. The AI does not have ethics – you do.

Chapter 28: Epilogue – Where We Go from Here

You made it.

Over the course of this book, you have gone from "what is Copilot?" to understanding models and modes, writing effective prompts, using Copilot inside every major Microsoft 365 app, generating images, working with advanced features like Think Deeper and Vision, and thinking carefully about the ethical dimensions of AI use. That is a lot of ground to cover, and if you have been practicing along the way, you are already a more capable Copilot user than the vast majority of people.

But here is the honest truth: everything in this book is a snapshot. The screenshots will age. The pricing will change. Features that were in preview when I wrote this may be generally available by the time you read it, and features I did not cover may have been announced last Tuesday. That is the nature of writing about AI in 2026 – the ground moves under your feet.

What will not change is the approach. The fundamentals of prompting – being specific, providing context, iterating on results, thinking about your audience – will work regardless of which model is powering Copilot six months from now. The habit of verifying AI output, of treating it as a draft rather than a final answer, of maintaining your own skills alongside the AI's capabilities – those principles are durable. The critical thinking you bring to the tools matters more than any particular feature.

What to Do Next

If you have not already, pick one thing from this book and make it a habit. Maybe it is asking Copilot to summarize your email threads every morning. Maybe it is using it to draft first versions of your reports. Maybe it is generating Excel formulas in plain English instead of looking up syntax. Start small, be consistent, and the productivity gains compound over time.

If you want to go deeper, the companion volume *Copilot: The Power User Guide* covers advanced topics like Copilot Studio, custom agent building, Power Automate

integration, enterprise deployment, and developer workflows. And the broader AI for Everyone series from Finnoybu Press covers ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, Perplexity, and topical guides for business, education, and development – because the best AI users are not loyal to one tool. They know the landscape.

The Bigger Picture

We are still in the early chapters of a much larger story about AI and work. The tools are getting better at an astonishing pace, and the people who learn to work with them effectively will have a genuine advantage – not because AI replaces human judgment, but because it amplifies it.

You now have the skills to be one of those people. Use the tools. Stay curious. Keep learning. And keep your judgment sharp – because the AI does not have any. That part is still, and will always be, up to you.

Thank you for reading. If this book saved you time, taught you something useful, or made the world of AI a little less intimidating, it did its job.

– Ken Tannenbaum, 2026

Appendix A: Keyboard Shortcuts and Interface Tips

This appendix is a quick reference for navigating Copilot efficiently across all platforms. Keep it handy as you build your daily Copilot habits.

Windows Shortcuts

Action	Shortcut
Open Copilot app	Win + C (or click the Copilot icon in the taskbar)
Open Copilot in Edge	Ctrl + Shift + . (period)
Copy last Copilot response	Click the copy icon on any response
Start a new conversation	Click “New chat” or the + icon
Send a message	Enter
New line without sending	Shift + Enter
Attach a file or image	Click the attachment icon in the chat input

Copilot in Microsoft 365 Apps

Word

Action	Shortcut / Method
Open Copilot pane	Click the Copilot icon in the ribbon (Home tab)
Draft with Copilot	Place cursor, type “/” to open the Copilot prompt box
Rewrite selected text	Select text, right-click, choose “Rewrite with Copilot”
Summarize document	Open Copilot pane and click “Summarize this doc”

Excel

Action	Shortcut / Method
Open Copilot pane	Click the Copilot icon in the ribbon

Action	Shortcut / Method
Analyze data	Type a natural language question about your data
Generate formulas	Describe what you want in plain language
Create a chart	Ask Copilot to “create a chart of…”
Use Python	Ask Copilot to analyze data with Python (requires Python in Excel)

PowerPoint

Action	Shortcut / Method
Open Copilot pane	Click the Copilot icon in the ribbon
Create presentation from prompt	“Create a presentation about [topic]”
Create from document	“Create a presentation from [document name/link]”
Add a slide	“Add a slide about [topic]”
Summarize presentation	“Summarize this presentation”

Outlook

Action	Shortcut / Method
Summarize email thread	Click “Summary by Copilot” at the top of a long thread
Draft new email with Copilot	Click “Draft with Copilot” in a new message
Draft reply with Copilot	Click “Reply” then “Draft with Copilot”
Coaching	Click “Coaching by Copilot” to get tone and clarity suggestions

Teams

Action	Shortcut / Method
Meeting summary	After a meeting, click “Recap” in the meeting chat
Summarize chat	In a chat, click “Copilot” and ask for a summary

Action	Shortcut / Method
Catch up on missed messages	Open Copilot in a channel and ask “What did I miss?”
Generate meeting notes	During or after a meeting, ask Copilot to list key points and action items

GitHub Copilot (VS Code)

Action	Shortcut
Accept inline suggestion	Tab
Dismiss inline suggestion	Escape
See next suggestion	Alt +]
See previous suggestion	Alt + [
Trigger inline suggestion manually	Alt + \
Open Copilot Chat pane	Ctrl + Shift + I
Open inline chat	Ctrl + I
Open Copilot Edits	Ctrl + Shift + I (then switch to Edits tab)

Copilot Web and Mobile Tips

Web (copilot.microsoft.com)

- **Switch conversation modes:** Click the mode selector at the top of the chat to switch between Quick Response, Auto, and Think Deeper.
- **Model selection:** Available on paid plans. Click the model selector to choose between available models.
- **Image generation:** Type a description of the image you want. Copilot will use Microsoft Designer to generate it.
- **File upload:** Click the attachment icon to upload images or documents for analysis.
- **Copilot Pages:** Click “Edit in Pages” on any response to open it in a collaborative, editable canvas.
- **Share a conversation:** Click the share icon to generate a link to the conversation.

- **Search history:** Click on your conversation history in the sidebar to find previous chats.

Mobile (iOS and Android)

- **Voice input:** Tap the microphone icon to speak your prompt instead of typing.
- **Camera input:** Tap the camera icon to take a photo or upload an image for Copilot to analyze.
- **Voice conversations:** Start a voice conversation for hands-free interaction.
- **Swipe to navigate:** Swipe between conversation history and the current chat.
- **Quick actions:** The mobile app surfaces suggested quick actions based on context.

Interface Tips for Better Results

Pin important conversations. If you have a conversation you refer to frequently, pin it in your sidebar to keep it accessible.

Use conversation history wisely. Copilot saves your conversations. Use previous conversations as reference when starting new ones – copy useful outputs from past sessions into new chats when relevant.

Clear the context. Start a new conversation when you switch to a completely different topic. Carrying unrelated context from a previous topic degrades response quality.

Use the feedback buttons. The thumbs up and thumbs down buttons on each response are not just for Microsoft's benefit. They help you build awareness of what works and what does not. When something is bad, take a moment to note why before moving on.

Manage your sidebar. Delete or archive conversations you no longer need. A clean sidebar makes it easier to find important conversations quickly.

Experiment with modes. If you are not getting the quality you want, try a different conversation mode. Quick Response is fast but shallow. Think Deeper is slower but more thorough. Auto tries to pick the right approach for each message.

Appendix B: Prompt Template Library

This appendix contains 78 ready-to-use prompt templates organized by category. Each template uses [brackets] to indicate parts you should customize. Copy, paste, and fill in the blanks to get high-quality results from Microsoft Copilot immediately.

These templates work with any Copilot tier. For best results on complex templates, use Think Deeper mode.

Writing Templates

1. Blog Post Draft

```
Write a blog post about [topic]. Target audience: [audience descripti
on]. Tone: [casual/professional/humorous/authoritative]. Length: appr
oximately [word count] words. Include a compelling headline, an engag
ing introduction, [number] main sections with subheadings, and a conc
lusion with a call to action.
```

2. Email – Professional Request

```
Write a professional email to [recipient/role] requesting [what you n
eed]. Context: [brief background]. Keep the tone [polite/formal/frien
dly but professional]. The email should be concise -- no more than [n
umber] paragraphs.
```

3. Email – Difficult Conversation

```
Help me write an email to [recipient] about [sensitive topic]. I need
 to communicate [key message] while maintaining a [respectful/empathe
tic/firm] tone. Key points to include: [list points]. Things to avoid
 saying: [list].
```

4. Executive Summary

```
Write an executive summary of the following [report/document/proposa
l]. Target reader: [audience, e.g., C-suite executives]. Maximum leng
th: [word count] words. Focus on: key findings, implications, and rec
ommended actions. Here is the content to summarize:

[paste content]
```

5. Social Media Post

```
Write a [platform: LinkedIn/X/Instagram/Facebook] post about [topic].
 Goal: [inform/engage/promote/celebrate]. Tone: [professional/casual/
inspirational]. Include a hook in the first line. [Include/exclude] h
ashtags. Maximum length: [character/word count].
```

6. Press Release

```
Write a press release for [company name] announcing [news/event/produ
ct]. Key details: who: [names/roles], what: [announcement], when: [da
te], where: [location], why: [significance]. Include a quote from [pe
rson/role]. Target media: [industry/local/national]. Follow standard
press release format.
```

7. Product Description

```
Write a product description for [product name]. Key features: [list f
eatures]. Target customer: [description]. Tone: [exciting/professiona
l/luxurious/practical]. Highlight the main benefit in the first sente
nce. Length: [word count] words. Include a call to action.
```

8. Cover Letter

```
Write a cover letter for a [job title] position at [company]. My rele
vant experience: [brief summary]. Key qualifications from the job lis
ting: [list]. Specific achievements I want to highlight: [list]. Ton
e: professional and confident but not arrogant. Keep it to one page.
```

9. Newsletter

```
Write a [weekly/monthly] newsletter for [audience]. Topic: [theme]. S
ections to include: [list, e.g., industry news, tips, upcoming event
s, featured story]. Tone: [professional/friendly/conversational]. Len
gth: [word count] words. Include a subject line.
```

10. Apology Letter

```
Write a professional apology to [recipient] regarding [situation]. Ac
knowledge: [what went wrong]. Explain (without making excuses): [brie
f context]. Offer: [resolution/next steps]. Tone: sincere, accountabl
e, and forward-looking.
```

Business Templates

11. Meeting Agenda

```
Create a meeting agenda for a [duration]-minute [type of meeting] abo
ut [topic]. Attendees: [roles/names]. Include time allocations for ea
ch item, desired outcomes for each discussion point, and end with an
action items section.
```

12. Meeting Summary

```
Summarize the following meeting notes. Organize into: Key Decisions,
Action Items (with owners and deadlines), Discussion Points, and Open
 Questions. Keep it concise -- no more than one page.

[paste meeting notes]
```

13. Project Status Report

```
Draft a weekly project status report for [project name]. Current stat
us: [on track/at risk/behind]. Accomplishments this week: [list]. Cha
llenges: [list]. Next week priorities: [list]. Risks and mitigations:
 [list]. Format as a structured report with clear sections.
```

14. Business Proposal

```
Write a business proposal for [project/initiative]. Client/audience:
[description]. Problem being solved: [description]. Proposed solutio
n: [description]. Key benefits: [list]. Timeline: [timeframe]. Budge
t: [range]. Include an executive summary, scope of work, and next ste
ps.
```

15. SWOT Analysis

```
Perform a SWOT analysis for [company/product/idea]. Context: [relevan
t background]. Present as four clearly labeled sections: Strengths, W
eaknesses, Opportunities, and Threats. Include 4-5 bullet points per
section. End with a strategic summary paragraph.
```

16. Job Description

```
Write a job description for a [title] position at [company type]. Rep
orting to: [role]. Key responsibilities: [list]. Required qualificati
ons: [list]. Preferred qualifications: [list]. Include information ab
out [benefits/culture/growth]. Tone: [professional/startup-casual/wel
coming].
```

17. Performance Review Draft

```
Help me draft performance review comments for [role]. Strengths: [lis
t]. Areas for improvement: [list]. Key accomplishments this period:
[list]. Goals for next period: [list]. Tone: constructive, specific,
and balanced. Use concrete examples where provided.
```

18. Vendor Comparison

```
Compare these [number] vendors for [product/service]: [list vendors].
 Criteria: [price, features, support, scalability, integration, et
c.]. Present as a comparison table followed by a recommendation parag
raph. My priorities are: [list in order of importance].
```

19. Change Management Communication

```
Draft an announcement for [audience, e.g., all employees] about [chan
ge: new tool, policy change, reorganization]. Explain: what is changi
ng, why, when it takes effect, how it affects them, and where to get
help. Tone: transparent, reassuring, and action-oriented.
```

20. Quarterly Business Review

```
Create a structure and draft for a quarterly business review covering
 [time period]. Key metrics: [list]. Highlights: [list]. Challenges:
[list]. Priorities for next quarter: [list]. Audience: [leadership te
am/board/department]. Format as a presentation-ready document.
```

Research and Analysis Templates

21. Research Summary

```
Research [topic] and provide a comprehensive summary. Include: curren
t state, key statistics, major trends, different perspectives, and pr
actical implications for [audience/context]. Cite sources where possi
ble. Length: [word count] words.
```

22. Competitive Analysis

```
Analyze [competitor company] as a competitor to [your company]. Cove
r: their product/service offerings, target market, pricing strategy,
strengths, weaknesses, recent developments, and strategic moves. Conc
lude with implications for our business.
```

23. Market Overview

```
Provide a market overview for the [industry] sector. Include: market
size and growth rate, key players, major trends, regulatory environme
nt, customer segments, and emerging opportunities. Focus on [geograph
ic region]. Use data from the most recent available sources.
```

24. Pros and Cons Analysis

```
List the pros and cons of [decision/option]. My specific situation:
[describe context]. Consider these factors: [list]. Present as two cl
early labeled lists. End with a balanced recommendation based on my s
ituation.
```

25. Case Study Draft

```
Write a case study about [client/project]. Challenge: [what problem t
hey faced]. Solution: [what was implemented]. Results: [outcomes and
metrics]. Include direct quotes from [stakeholder roles]. Format: pro
blem, solution, results, with a compelling title.
```

26. Survey Questions

```
Create a [number]-question survey about [topic]. Target respondents:
[audience]. Mix question types: multiple choice, rating scale (1-5),
and [number] open-ended questions. Goals: measure [what you want to l
earn]. Keep questions clear and unbiased.
```

27. Data Interpretation

```
I have the following data: [describe or paste data]. Help me identify
 [number] key insights or trends. For each insight: state the findin
g, explain why it matters, and suggest one action to take. Present in
 a clear, numbered format.
```

28. Risk Assessment

```
Perform a risk assessment for [project/initiative]. Identify [number]
 potential risks. For each risk, assess: likelihood (high/medium/lo
w), impact (high/medium/low), and recommended mitigation strategy. Pr
esent as a table.
```

Productivity Templates

29. Action Plan

```
Create a step-by-step action plan for [goal]. Timeline: [timeframe].
Resources available: [list]. Include milestones with dates, specific
tasks for each milestone, and success criteria. Format as a numbered
checklist.
```

30. Decision Framework

```
Help me decide between [option A] and [option B] (and [option C] if a
pplicable). My priorities (in order): [list]. My constraints: [list].
 Walk me through the decision systematically, weighting each option a
gainst my priorities. Give a clear recommendation.
```

31. Weekly Planning

```
Help me plan my work week. My priorities: [list]. Meetings already sc
heduled: [list]. Deadlines this week: [list]. Available hours for foc
used work: [estimate]. Create a day-by-day plan that ensures I hit my
 deadlines and make progress on priorities.
```

32. Process Documentation

```
Document the process for [task/workflow]. Audience: [who will follow
this process, e.g., new hires]. Include: purpose, prerequisites, step
-by-step instructions, common troubleshooting tips, and who to contac
t for help. Write clearly enough that someone with no prior experienc
e could follow it.
```

33. Event Planning Checklist

```
Create a detailed planning checklist for a [type of event] for [numbe
r] people. Date: [timeframe]. Budget: [amount]. Venue: [type/confirme
d]. Include task categories (venue, catering, invitations, agenda, te
chnology, follow-up) with specific items, deadlines, and responsible
roles.
```

34. Goals and OKRs

```
Help me create [number] OKRs (Objectives and Key Results) for [team/i
ndividual/company] for [time period]. Context: [current priorities, s
trategic direction]. Each OKR should have one clear objective and 3-4
 measurable key results. Make them ambitious but achievable.
```

35. Delegation Brief

```
Write a task delegation brief for [task]. Who it is being delegated t
o: [role/name]. Include: task description, expected outcome, deadlin
e, available resources, decision-making authority, check-in schedule,
 and success criteria. Keep it to one page.
```

Communication Templates

36. Presentation Outline

```
Create an outline for a [duration]-minute presentation about [topic].
 Audience: [description]. Goal: [inform/persuade/train/inspire]. Incl
ude [number] main sections with key talking points, suggested visuals
 for each section, and speaker notes. Start with a compelling hook.
```

37. Customer Response – Complaint

```
Write a response to a customer who is [upset/frustrated/disappointed]
 about [situation]. Our policy: [relevant policy]. Acknowledge their
frustration, apologize sincerely, explain what happened (briefly), of
fer [specific resolution], and end on a positive note. Tone: empathet
ic, professional, solution-oriented.
```

38. Customer Response – Question

```
Write a helpful response to a customer asking about [topic/product/fe
ature]. Key information to include: [list]. Tone: friendly, clear, an
d helpful. Anticipate one follow-up question they might have and addr
ess it proactively. Keep it under [number] sentences.
```

39. Thank You Note

```
Write a thank you note to [recipient] for [what they did]. Mention sp
ecifically: [particular aspects to acknowledge]. Tone: [warm/professi
onal/heartfelt]. Length: [brief/medium]. Make it personal, not generi
c.
```

40. Feedback – Constructive

```
Help me write constructive feedback for [person/role] about [topic].
What they did well: [positives]. What needs improvement: [specifics].
 Suggested next steps: [actions]. Tone: supportive, specific, and gro
wth-oriented. Use the SBI (Situation-Behavior-Impact) framework.
```

41. Rejection – Job Application

```
Write a professional rejection email for a [job title] candidate. Be
respectful, thank them for their time and interest, provide [brief/ge
neral] feedback if appropriate, and encourage them to [apply again/st
ay in touch]. Tone: kind but clear.
```

42. Recommendation Letter

```
Help me draft a recommendation letter for [person] applying for [posi
tion/program]. My relationship to them: [context]. Their key strength
s: [list]. Specific examples of their work: [list]. How long I have k
nown them: [duration]. Tone: enthusiastic and specific.
```

43. Negotiation Preparation

```
Help me prepare for a negotiation about [topic]. My position: [what I
 want]. Their likely position: [what they probably want]. My best alt
ernatives (BATNA): [list]. Help me identify potential compromises, an
ticipate objections, and draft key talking points.
```

Education Templates

44. Lesson Plan

```
Create a [duration]-minute lesson plan for [grade/level] [subject]. T
opic: [specific topic]. Learning objectives: [what students should be
 able to do after the lesson]. Include: warm-up activity, direct inst
ruction, guided practice, independent practice, and assessment/exit t
icket.
```

45. Study Guide

```
Create a study guide for [subject/exam/chapter]. Topics to cover: [li
st]. For each topic include: a brief explanation (2-3 sentences), one
 concrete example, one practice question with answer. Difficulty leve
l: [beginner/intermediate/advanced].
```

46. Practice Quiz

```
Write a [number]-question practice quiz on [topic] for [audience/leve
l]. Mix question types: [multiple choice, true/false, short answer, f
ill-in-the-blank]. Include an answer key with brief explanations. Dif
ficulty: [easy/medium/hard].
```

47. Concept Explanation

```
Explain [concept] to a [audience, e.g., "high school junior" or "some
one with no background in this subject"]. Use [number] everyday analo
gies. Include one concrete example. End with a "test your understandi
ng" question. Keep it to [number] paragraphs.
```

48. Rubric

```
Create a grading rubric for [assignment type, e.g., "a persuasive ess
ay" or "a group presentation"]. Categories: [list, e.g., content, org
anization, evidence, presentation, creativity]. Levels: [4 levels, e.
g., Beginning, Developing, Proficient, Exemplary]. Include specific d
escriptors for each cell.
```

49. Discussion Questions

```
Generate [number] discussion questions for [text/topic/chapter] for a
 [level] class. Include a mix of: recall questions, analytical questi
ons, and synthesis/application questions. Each question should be ope
n-ended enough to sustain a 5-minute class discussion.
```

50. Assignment Instructions

```
Write clear assignment instructions for [assignment type]. Grade/leve
l: [specify]. Learning objectives: [what skills this develops]. Requi
rements: [list]. Format: [specifications]. Due date: [date]. Grading
criteria: [brief summary]. Include common mistakes to avoid.
```

Personal and Creative Templates

51. Resume Bullet Points

```
Rewrite these job experience bullet points to be more impactful. Use
strong action verbs and include quantifiable results where possible.
Current role: [title] at [company]. Here are my current bullet point
s:

[paste bullet points]
```

52. Interview Preparation

```
Generate [number] likely interview questions for a [position] role at
 [type of company]. For each question, provide: the question, why int
erviewers ask it, a framework for answering well, and one sample answ
er outline. Include both behavioral and technical questions.
```

53. Personal Bio

```
Write a professional bio for [context: LinkedIn, conference speaker,
company website]. My role: [title]. My expertise: [areas]. Key accomp
lishments: [list]. Education: [relevant degrees]. Personal touch: [ho
```

bby/interest/fun fact]. Length: [50/100/200] words. Tone: [profession al/approachable/authoritative]. Write in [first/third] person.

54. Trip Planning

Plan a [duration] trip to [destination]. Travelers: [who]. Budget: [l evel/amount]. Interests: [list, e.g., history, food, outdoor activiti es]. Must-see: [any specifics]. Create a day-by-day itinerary with es timated times, restaurant recommendations, and practical tips (transp ortation, tickets to book in advance, etc.).

55. Recipe Modification

Modify this recipe to be [dietary requirement: gluten-free, vegan, lo w-sodium, etc.]. Here is the original recipe:

[paste recipe]

Keep the dish as close to the original flavor and texture as possibl e. Note any significant changes in cooking time or technique. Suggest substitutions for each modified ingredient.

56. Gift Ideas

Suggest [number] gift ideas for [person description: e.g., "my mother -in-law who loves gardening and reading"]. Budget: [range] per gift. Occasion: [birthday/holiday/thank you]. For each suggestion: name the gift, explain why it fits, and note where to find it. Mix practical and creative options.

57. Creative Writing Prompt

Write a [genre: mystery/sci-fi/literary fiction/romance] short story opening (500 words) that starts with [scenario/setting]. Main charact er: [brief description]. Tone: [atmospheric/fast-paced/humorous/dar k]. End with a hook that makes the reader want to continue.

58. Speech or Toast

```
Write a [duration]-minute [speech type: wedding toast, retirement spe
ech, award acceptance, commencement address] for [occasion]. Relation
ship to honoree: [describe]. Key stories or memories to include: [lis
t]. Tone: [heartfelt/humorous/inspirational]. Include a memorable clo
sing line.
```

Data and Analysis Templates

59. Excel Formula

```
I need an Excel formula that [describe what it should do]. My data is
 in [describe columns/rows]. Example: [give a specific example of inp
ut and desired output]. Explain the formula step by step so I can mod
ify it later.
```

60. Data Summary

```
Summarize the following dataset. Identify: total count, averages, min
imums, maximums, and any notable outliers or patterns. Present the su
mmary as a concise table followed by 3 key observations.

[paste or describe data]
```

61. Dashboard Design

```
Suggest a dashboard layout for tracking [business area: sales, market
ing, HR, operations]. Key metrics to include: [list]. Audience: [who
will view this]. For each metric: suggest the best visualization type
 (line chart, bar chart, KPI card, etc.) and explain why. Organize in
to logical sections.
```

62. SQL Query Help

```
Write a SQL query that [describe what you need]. Database structure:
[describe relevant tables and columns]. Expected output: [describe wh
```

at the results should look like]. Include comments explaining each pa
rt of the query.

63. Chart Description

I have a [type of chart: bar, line, pie, scatter] showing [what it di
splays]. Here is the data:

[paste data or describe]

Write a 3-paragraph analysis: first describe what the chart shows, th
en identify the most important trend or finding, then explain what ac
tion should be taken based on this data.

Technical Templates

64. Bug Report

Help me write a clear bug report. Application: [name]. What I expecte
d to happen: [expected behavior]. What actually happened: [actual beh
avior]. Steps to reproduce: [list steps]. Environment: [OS, browser,
version]. Severity: [critical/high/medium/low]. Include any error mes
sages.

65. Technical Documentation

Write user documentation for [feature/tool/process]. Audience: [techn
ical level]. Structure: Overview (what it does and why), Prerequisite
s, Step-by-step Instructions, Configuration Options, Common Issues an
d Solutions, and FAQ. Use clear, simple language.

66. Code Review Checklist

Create a code review checklist for [language/framework]. Include cate
gories for: functionality, security, performance, readability, testin

```
g, and documentation. Include [number] items per category with brief
explanations of what to look for.
```

67. API Documentation

```
Write API documentation for [endpoint]. Method: [GET/POST/PUT/DELET
E]. URL: [endpoint URL]. Parameters: [list with types]. Request body:
 [describe]. Response format: [describe]. Include example request and
 response, error codes, and rate limits.
```

Marketing Templates

68. Email Campaign

```
Write a [number]-email sequence for [campaign goal: welcome series, p
roduct launch, re-engagement, nurture]. Audience: [description]. For
each email: subject line, preview text, body copy, and call to actio
n. Spacing: [days between emails]. Tone: [brand voice description].
```

69. Ad Copy

```
Write [number] ad copy variations for [product/service] on [platform:
 Google Ads, Facebook, LinkedIn]. Target audience: [description]. Key
 selling point: [USP]. Include: headline (under [character limit]), d
escription, and call to action. Tone: [urgent/professional/playful/au
thoritative].
```

70. Content Calendar

```
Create a [duration: one week/one month] content calendar for [brand/c
ompany] on [platforms]. Content pillars: [list, e.g., educational, be
hind-the-scenes, promotional, community]. Posting frequency: [how oft
en per platform]. For each post: date, platform, content type, topic,
 and a brief description.
```

71. Brand Voice Guide

```
Help me define a brand voice for [company/brand]. Our target audienc
e: [description]. Our values: [list]. Our personality traits: [3-5 ad
jectives]. Create a voice guide that includes: voice characteristics,
 do's and don'ts, example phrases, and sample copy for [email, social
 media, website].
```

72. Landing Page Copy

```
Write copy for a landing page promoting [product/service/offer]. Targ
et audience: [description]. Key benefit: [main value proposition]. Su
pporting benefits: [list]. Social proof to include: [testimonials, st
ats, logos]. Include: headline, subheadline, body sections, and CTA b
utton text. Optimize for conversion.
```

Strategic Thinking Templates

73. Problem Definition

```
Help me clearly define the problem I am facing. Here is my situation:
 [describe situation in detail]. Help me: distinguish symptoms from r
oot causes, identify the stakeholders affected, quantify the impact,
and articulate the problem as a clear, specific problem statement.
```

74. Brainstorming

```
Generate [number] creative ideas for [goal/challenge]. Context: [rele
vant background]. Constraints: [limitations to work within]. For each
 idea: one-sentence description, potential impact (high/medium/low),
effort required (high/medium/low), and one key risk.
```

75. Stakeholder Analysis

```
Help me map the stakeholders for [project/initiative]. For each stake
holder: identify their role, their likely position (supporter/neutral
```

```
/resistant), their level of influence (high/medium/low), their key co
ncerns, and the best strategy for engaging them. Present as a table.
```

76. Scenario Planning

```
Help me think through [number] scenarios for [situation/decision]. Fo
r each scenario: describe what happens, assess the probability (likel
y/possible/unlikely), identify the impact on [my goals/organization],
 and recommend a preparation or response strategy.
```

77. Lessons Learned

```
Help me create a lessons learned document for [project/event/initiati
ve]. What went well: [list]. What did not go well: [list]. What surpr
ised us: [list]. For each item, identify the lesson and a specific, a
ctionable recommendation for next time. Format as a structured templa
te.
```

78. Elevator Pitch

```
Write a [30-second/60-second] elevator pitch for [product/company/ide
a/yourself]. Audience: [who you are pitching to]. Key problem you sol
ve: [description]. Your unique approach: [what makes you different].
Desired outcome of the pitch: [what you want them to do next]. Make i
t conversational, not scripted.
```

Tips for Using These Templates

1. **Customize aggressively.** The brackets are starting points. Add your own context, constraints, and details for better results.
2. **Combine templates.** Use the brainstorming template to generate ideas, then the action plan template to develop the best one.
3. **Iterate.** If the first result is not right, tell Copilot what to change rather than starting over.

4. **Save your best prompts.** When a customized template works well, save it for reuse. Build your own personal prompt library over time.
5. **Match the mode to the template.** Simple templates work fine in Quick Response mode. Complex analysis templates benefit from Think Deeper mode.

Appendix C: Troubleshooting Common Issues

This appendix covers the most common problems you will encounter with Microsoft Copilot and how to resolve them. Issues are organized from most common to least common.

Copilot Gives Vague or Generic Responses

The problem: You ask a question and get a response that could apply to anyone, with no specifics relevant to your situation.

The fix: Your prompt is too vague. Add specificity: - Include your context (industry, role, audience, constraints) - Specify the format you want (table, list, essay, bullet points) - Set a word count or length target - Provide an example of what a good response looks like

Before: "Help me with my presentation." **After:** "Create a 10-slide outline for a 20-minute presentation about our Q3 marketing results. Audience: senior leadership. Include a slide on budget vs. actual spend and one on recommendations for Q4."

Copilot Refuses to Answer a Question

The problem: Copilot declines your request, saying it cannot help with that topic or redirecting you elsewhere.

Possible causes and fixes:

- **Content filters triggered.** Copilot has safety filters that block certain types of content. If your legitimate request was filtered, try rephrasing. Remove any language that could be interpreted as requesting harmful content.

- **Too close to a restricted topic.** Medical diagnoses, specific legal advice, and certain other topics may trigger cautious responses. Frame your request more generally: "What are common symptoms of…" rather than "Do I have…"
- **Unclear intent.** If your prompt is ambiguous, Copilot may err on the side of caution. Be more explicit about what you need and why.

Copilot's Response Is Too Long

The problem: You wanted a brief answer and got a five-paragraph essay.

The fix: Specify length constraints in your prompt: - "Answer in three sentences or fewer." - "Keep this under 200 words." - "Give me a one-paragraph summary." - "List only the top five – do not elaborate on each."

If you already received a long response, follow up: "Condense that to three bullet points."

Copilot's Response Is Too Short

The problem: You need a comprehensive answer and got a surface-level overview.

The fix: - Ask for more detail: "Expand on each of those points with examples and evidence." - Use Think Deeper mode for complex questions. - Specify minimum length: "Write at least 500 words." - Ask multi-part questions: "For each item, explain what it is, why it matters, and give an example."

Copilot Loses Context in Long Conversations

The problem: After many exchanges, Copilot seems to forget earlier context or contradicts itself.

The fix: - Summarize the current state: "So far we have covered X, Y, and Z. The key decisions are A and B. Now let us work on…" - Restate critical constraints when they

become relevant again. - Start a new conversation if the context has become too cluttered. Copy key outputs from the old conversation into the new one. - Keep conversations focused on one topic. Do not mix unrelated tasks.

Copilot Gives Incorrect Information

The problem: Copilot states something as fact that turns out to be wrong (hallucination).

The fix: - Always verify important factual claims through independent sources. - Ask Copilot to cite its sources. Check that the sources exist and actually say what Copilot claims. - Ask "Are you certain about this? What is the source?" Sometimes this prompts Copilot to be more cautious. - For critical information, use Copilot's web search capability to ground responses in real sources. - See Chapter 25 for a detailed discussion of hallucination and how to handle it.

Copilot in Microsoft 365 Apps Is Not Available

The problem: You do not see the Copilot button in Word, Excel, PowerPoint, Outlook, or Teams.

Check the following: 1. **Licensing.** Copilot in Microsoft 365 apps requires a Copilot Pro subscription (for consumers) or a Microsoft 365 Copilot for Business/Enterprise license. The free tier does not include in-app Copilot. 2. **App version.** Make sure your Microsoft 365 apps are up to date. Copilot requires recent versions. 3. **Account.** Confirm you are signed in with the Microsoft account that has the Copilot license. 4. **Admin settings (business users).** Your IT administrator may not have enabled Copilot for your account or your department. Contact your IT team. 5. **Platform.** Copilot in Microsoft 365 apps is available on Windows, Mac, web, and mobile – but feature availability may vary by platform.

Copilot Cannot Access My Files or Data

The problem: You asked Copilot about a document or email, and it says it cannot find it.

Check the following: - **Are the files in OneDrive or SharePoint?** Copilot can only access files stored in Microsoft's cloud services, not files on your local hard drive. - **Do you have permission?** Copilot can only access files you have permission to view. If the file is in a SharePoint site you are not a member of, Copilot cannot see it. - **Is the file type supported?** Copilot works with common file types (Word, Excel, PowerPoint, PDF) but may not support every format. - **Is Microsoft Graph connected?** For organizational data access, your account must be properly connected to Microsoft Graph. Contact your IT administrator if you suspect a configuration issue.

Image Generation Is Not Working

The problem: Copilot will not generate images, or you have run out of image generation credits.

Check the following: - **Credits.** Image generation uses "boosts" (credits). Free users get a limited number; paid users get more. If you are out of boosts, you will need to wait for them to refresh or upgrade your plan. - **Content restrictions.** Copilot will not generate images of real people (by name), violent content, explicit content, or content that violates Microsoft's usage policies. - **Specificity.** If Copilot is generating images that do not match your intent, be more descriptive in your prompt. Include details about style, colors, composition, and mood.

Copilot Is Slow

The problem: Responses are taking a long time to generate.

Possible causes: - **Think Deeper mode.** Extended reasoning takes longer by design. If you are using Think Deeper for a simple question, switch to Quick Response or Auto. - **Server load.** During peak times, responses may be slower. This is temporary. - **Complex prompts.** Very long prompts with extensive context take

longer to process. - **Internet connection.** A slow internet connection can delay the display of responses.

Copilot in Edge Is Not Showing

The problem: The Copilot sidebar is not appearing in Microsoft Edge.

Check the following: 1. Update Edge to the latest version. 2. Click the Copilot icon in the toolbar (top right) or use Ctrl + Shift + . (period). 3. Check that Copilot is not disabled in Edge settings (Settings > Sidebar > Copilot). 4. If you are using Edge at work, your organization may have disabled the Copilot sidebar. 5. Restart Edge.

GitHub Copilot Is Not Suggesting Code

The problem: You are typing in your editor but not seeing inline suggestions from GitHub Copilot.

Check the following: 1. **Extension installed?** Verify the GitHub Copilot extension is installed and enabled in your editor. 2. **Signed in?** Make sure you are signed in to your GitHub account with an active Copilot subscription. 3. **Subscription active?** Check that your Copilot Free/Pro/Pro+/Business/Enterprise subscription is current. 4. **Language supported?** Copilot works best with popular languages. It may be less active in obscure or domain-specific languages. 5. **Settings.** Check that inline suggestions are enabled in your Copilot settings (in VS Code: Settings > search "Copilot"). 6. **Network.** GitHub Copilot requires an internet connection. It will not work offline.

Copilot Gives Different Answers to the Same Question

The problem: You asked the same question twice and got two different responses.

This is normal. AI models have an element of randomness (called "temperature") in their response generation. This means responses vary even for identical prompts. If

you need consistency: - Copy and save responses you want to reference later. - Use more specific prompts with tighter constraints to reduce variation. - In some enterprise configurations, temperature and other parameters may be adjustable.

Copilot's Formatting Is Messy When I Paste

The problem: When you copy Copilot's response and paste it elsewhere, the formatting does not look right.

Fixes by destination: - **Word/Google Docs:** Use "Paste and Match Formatting" (Ctrl + Shift + V) to strip Markdown syntax and match your document's style. - **Email:** Most email clients handle pasted formatted text well. If not, paste as plain text and reformat. - **Spreadsheets:** For table data, try pasting into a plain text editor first, then copying from there into your spreadsheet. - **Plain text editors:** Copilot's output includes Markdown formatting characters (`#`, `,` `|`). **These are normal – they just will not render in plain text. -** Use Copilot in the app directly.** The best formatting experience comes from using Copilot within Microsoft 365 apps, where output is automatically formatted for that application.

General Troubleshooting Steps

When all else fails, try these in order:

1. **Refresh the page or restart the app.**
2. **Clear your browser cache** (if using web Copilot).
3. **Sign out and sign back in** to your Microsoft account.
4. **Check the Microsoft 365 Service Health page** for outages.
5. **Try a different browser or device** to isolate the issue.
6. **Check the Microsoft Copilot support page** at support.microsoft.com for known issues and updates.
7. **Contact support.** Microsoft 365 business and enterprise customers can contact Microsoft support directly. Consumer users can use the Microsoft support community.

Appendix D: Glossary of AI Terms

This glossary covers the most important terms you will encounter when using Microsoft Copilot and reading about AI. Definitions are written in plain language – no computer science degree required.

Agent / Agentic AI. An AI system that can take actions on your behalf, not just generate text. Agentic AI can browse the web, execute code, interact with apps, and complete multi-step tasks autonomously. Copilot's agent capabilities are expanding rapidly.

AI (Artificial Intelligence). A broad term for computer systems that can perform tasks that normally require human intelligence – understanding language, recognizing patterns, making decisions, and generating content.

Alignment. The process of training an AI model to behave in ways that are helpful, honest, and safe – aligned with human values and intentions. Alignment is one of the biggest challenges in AI development.

Bias. Systematic errors in AI output that reflect imbalances in training data or design choices. For example, an AI might associate certain professions with specific genders because its training data did. See Chapter 25.

Bing Search Grounding. Copilot's ability to search the web through Bing to provide current, cited information. This helps Copilot answer questions about recent events and reduces hallucination for factual queries.

Chatbot. A software program designed to have conversations with humans. Copilot is a chatbot, but the term undersells its capabilities – it is more accurately described as an AI assistant.

Commercial Data Protection (CDP). Microsoft's guarantee that data from business and enterprise Copilot users is not used to train AI models. This is a key privacy feature for organizational deployments.

Completion. In AI, a completion is the text generated by a model in response to a prompt. When you ask Copilot a question, the answer is the completion.

Context Window. The total amount of text (measured in tokens) that a language model can process at once. This includes both your input and the model's response. Larger context windows allow for longer conversations and larger document analysis.

Copilot Pages. A collaborative canvas within Microsoft Copilot where you can save, edit, and share AI-generated content. Pages allow multiple people to work with and refine Copilot's output together.

Copilot Studio. Microsoft's platform for creating custom Copilot agents and plugins. Organizations can use Copilot Studio to build AI-powered workflows tailored to their specific needs.

DALL-E. An AI image generation model created by OpenAI. Copilot uses a version of DALL-E (through Microsoft Designer) to generate images from text descriptions.

Deep Learning. A subset of machine learning that uses neural networks with many layers to learn complex patterns. The large language models powering Copilot are products of deep learning.

Designer (Microsoft). Microsoft's AI-powered image creation and design tool, integrated into Copilot for image generation.

Embedding. A mathematical representation of text (or images, or other data) that captures its meaning. Embeddings allow AI systems to find and compare similar content. Microsoft Graph uses embeddings to help Copilot find relevant documents in your organization.

Enterprise Data Protection. Extended data governance features available in Microsoft 365 Copilot Enterprise, including eDiscovery, advanced compliance, and custom data residency controls.

Few-Shot Prompting. A prompting technique where you provide the AI with a few examples of the input-output pattern you want before asking it to perform the task. "Here are three examples of good product descriptions. Now write one for this product."

Fine-Tuning. The process of further training a pre-trained model on a specific dataset to improve its performance for a particular task or domain. In GitHub Copilot Enterprise, models can be fine-tuned on an organization's codebase.

Foundation Model. A large AI model trained on broad data that can be adapted to many tasks. GPT-5.4, Claude, and Gemini are all foundation models.

Generative AI (GenAI). AI systems that create new content – text, images, code, music, video – rather than just analyzing or classifying existing content. Copilot is a generative AI tool.

GPT (Generative Pre-trained Transformer). The family of language models created by OpenAI that power many of Copilot's capabilities. GPT-5.4 is the current frontier model.

Grounding. The process of connecting AI responses to real-world data sources to improve accuracy. Copilot uses Bing Search grounding (web data) and Microsoft Graph grounding (organizational data).

Guardrails. Safety measures built into AI systems to prevent harmful, inappropriate, or dangerous outputs. Copilot has content filters, safety protocols, and behavioral guidelines that act as guardrails.

Hallucination. When an AI generates information that sounds plausible but is factually incorrect or completely fabricated. See Chapter 25 for detailed coverage.

Inference. The process of running a trained AI model to generate responses. When you send a prompt to Copilot, the inference happens on Microsoft's servers.

Large Language Model (LLM). An AI model trained on massive amounts of text data that can understand and generate human language. GPT-5.4, Claude, and Gemini are all large language models.

Machine Learning (ML). A branch of AI where systems learn from data and improve through experience, rather than being explicitly programmed for every task.

Microsoft 365 Copilot. The AI assistant integrated into Microsoft 365 applications (Word, Excel, PowerPoint, Outlook, Teams). Available in Business and Enterprise tiers.

Microsoft Graph. Microsoft's data layer that connects all your Microsoft 365 data – emails, documents, calendar, contacts, Teams chats, and more. Copilot for Business uses Microsoft Graph to access organizational data.

Model. In AI, a model is the trained system that processes inputs and generates outputs. Different models have different capabilities, strengths, and weaknesses.

Multimodal. An AI system that can process multiple types of input – text, images, audio, video. Copilot is multimodal: it can accept text and images as input.

Natural Language Processing (NLP). The branch of AI focused on enabling computers to understand, interpret, and generate human language.

Neural Network. A computing system inspired by the structure of the human brain, consisting of interconnected nodes (neurons) organized in layers. Neural networks are the foundation of modern AI.

Parameter. A tunable value within a neural network that the model adjusts during training. Larger models have more parameters and generally exhibit more sophisticated behavior. Modern large language models have hundreds of billions or trillions of parameters.

Plugin. An extension that adds new capabilities to Copilot. Plugins can connect Copilot to external services, databases, or specialized tools.

Pre-Training. The initial phase of training a language model, where it learns from a massive dataset of text. Pre-training gives the model its general language understanding and knowledge.

Prompt. The input you give to an AI model – your question, instruction, or request. The quality of your prompt significantly affects the quality of the response. See Chapter 19.

Prompt Engineering. The practice of crafting effective prompts to get the best results from AI models. This includes specifying roles, providing context, defining formats, and setting constraints.

Prompt Injection. A security attack where malicious text embedded in a document or webpage attempts to manipulate the AI's behavior, potentially causing it to ignore its instructions or reveal information it should not.

RAG (Retrieval-Augmented Generation). A technique where the AI retrieves relevant information from a knowledge base before generating a response. This improves accuracy and allows the AI to reference specific, up-to-date information. Copilot uses RAG when it searches Bing or Microsoft Graph data.

Reinforcement Learning from Human Feedback (RLHF). A training technique where human evaluators rate AI responses, and those ratings are used to train the model to produce better outputs. This is how AI models learn to be helpful and safe.

Responsible AI. A framework of principles and practices for developing and deploying AI systems ethically, including fairness, transparency, accountability, and safety. Microsoft has published Responsible AI principles that govern Copilot's development.

Sensitivity Labels. Microsoft Information Protection labels (Confidential, Internal, Public, etc.) that classify documents by sensitivity level. Copilot respects these labels and will not surface restricted content to users without appropriate permissions.

Sycophancy. The tendency of AI models to agree with the user or tell them what they want to hear, rather than providing honest, accurate, or balanced responses. Modern models are trained to reduce sycophancy, but it still occurs.

Temperature. A setting that controls the randomness of an AI model's responses. Higher temperature produces more creative, varied responses. Lower temperature produces more focused, deterministic responses.

Think Deeper. Copilot's extended reasoning mode, which gives the model more time to work through complex problems before responding. Best for multi-step reasoning, analysis, and problems that benefit from careful thought.

Token. The basic unit of text that language models process. A token is roughly equivalent to three-quarters of a word. "Microsoft Copilot is helpful" is approximately five tokens.

Training Data. The dataset used to train an AI model. For large language models, this includes books, websites, articles, code, and other text sources. The training data affects the model's knowledge, capabilities, and biases.

Transformer. The neural network architecture that powers modern large language models. Transformers process text by attending to relationships between all words in a sequence simultaneously, enabling sophisticated language understanding.

Zero-Shot Prompting. Asking an AI to perform a task without providing any examples – just the instruction. “Translate this sentence to French” is a zero-shot prompt. Compare with few-shot prompting, where you provide examples first.

Appendix E: What's New in 2025-2026

Microsoft Copilot has evolved rapidly since its initial launch. This appendix provides a timeline of the major milestones, feature releases, and strategic shifts that have shaped Copilot into the product covered in this book.

2025 Timeline

Q1 2025 (January - March)

Copilot Vision Preview. Microsoft introduced Copilot Vision as a limited preview feature, allowing Copilot in Edge to see and understand what is on your screen. Initial capabilities focused on browser content, with the ability to answer questions about visible web pages and help users navigate complex websites.

Think Deeper Launch. Copilot gained extended reasoning capabilities with the Think Deeper mode, powered by advanced reasoning models. This allowed users to tackle complex multi-step problems that required sustained logical reasoning, such as math problems, strategic analysis, and detailed planning.

GPT-5 Integration. Following OpenAI's release of GPT-5 in late 2024 and early 2025, Microsoft began rolling out GPT-5-powered experiences across Copilot products. The upgrade brought improved instruction following, better factual accuracy, and more natural conversational abilities.

Copilot Pages General Availability. After a preview period, Copilot Pages became generally available, giving users a collaborative AI canvas for saving, editing, and sharing Copilot-generated content. Pages bridged the gap between disposable chat responses and persistent, editable documents.

Microsoft 365 Copilot Expansion. Microsoft expanded Copilot availability across more Microsoft 365 applications, including deeper integration with OneNote, Loop, and Planner. The goal was to make Copilot available wherever Microsoft 365 users work, not just in the core Office applications.

Q2 2025 (April - June)

Copilot Studio Enhancements. Microsoft significantly expanded Copilot Studio, the platform for building custom Copilot agents. New features included more sophisticated workflow automation, better integration with third-party data sources, and improved no-code/low-code building experiences. This positioned organizations to create AI agents tailored to their specific business processes.

GPT-5.2 Rollout. OpenAI's GPT-5.2 model began powering Copilot experiences, bringing improvements in coding, reasoning, and reduced hallucination rates compared to the initial GPT-5 release.

GitHub Copilot Multi-Model Support. GitHub Copilot introduced multi-model support, allowing developers to choose between different AI models (initially GPT and Claude) for code completion and chat. This was a significant strategic shift, acknowledging that different models excel at different tasks.

Copilot for Mobile Improvements. The Copilot mobile app received major updates, including improved voice conversation capabilities, better camera integration for visual analysis, and a more intuitive interface for on-the-go productivity.

Enterprise Analytics Dashboard. Microsoft launched enhanced analytics tools for Microsoft 365 Copilot administrators, providing insights into adoption rates, common use cases, and productivity impact across the organization.

Q3 2025 (July - September)

Agentic Capabilities Expansion. Copilot gained increasingly autonomous capabilities, moving beyond simple question-and-answer interactions toward the ability to complete multi-step tasks with minimal user intervention. Early agentic features included automated email triage, meeting scheduling, and document workflow management.

GitHub Copilot Free Tier. GitHub introduced a free tier of Copilot, offering 2,000 code completions and 50 chat messages per month at no cost. This dramatically expanded access to AI coding assistance and positioned GitHub Copilot as an essential tool for developers at all levels.

Copilot in Teams Enhancements. Teams Copilot gained the ability to participate more actively in meetings – providing real-time summaries, suggesting follow-up questions, and drafting action items as conversations unfolded rather than only after meetings concluded.

Microsoft 365 Copilot Price Restructuring. Microsoft adjusted its Microsoft 365 Copilot licensing structure, introducing more flexible pricing options to accelerate enterprise adoption. The changes made Copilot accessible to a broader range of organization sizes and budgets.

Q4 2025 (October - December)

GPT-5.4 Release. OpenAI's GPT-5.4 model – including the GPT-5.4 Thinking variant for extended reasoning – became the primary model powering Copilot. This represented a significant leap in capability, with notable improvements in complex reasoning, coding, and creative tasks.

Copilot Vision Expansion. Copilot Vision expanded beyond browser-only use, gaining the ability to understand content from more applications and screen contexts. Privacy controls were refined to give users granular control over what Copilot could see.

GitHub Copilot Pro+ Launch. GitHub introduced the Pro+ tier at $39/month, offering access to frontier models with higher rate limits, advanced agent capabilities, and pull request summaries. This created a clearer differentiation between individual and professional developer needs.

Gemini Model Added to GitHub Copilot. GitHub Copilot expanded its multi-model support to include Google's Gemini, giving developers three major model families to choose from: GPT, Claude, and Gemini.

Year-End Adoption Milestones. Microsoft reported that Microsoft 365 Copilot had reached significant adoption across Fortune 500 companies, with measurable productivity gains. GitHub Copilot crossed major thresholds in developer adoption worldwide.

Q1 2026 (January - March)

Conversation Modes Refinement. Copilot streamlined its conversation modes to three clear options: Quick Response (fast, concise answers), Auto (intelligent mode selection), and Think Deeper (extended reasoning for complex problems). This replaced earlier, less intuitive mode naming.

Enhanced Privacy Controls. Microsoft introduced more granular privacy controls for all Copilot tiers, including clearer opt-out mechanisms for data usage and improved transparency about how conversations are processed and stored.

Copilot in Education. Microsoft rolled out education-specific Copilot features, including integration with Microsoft 365 Education plans, age-appropriate content controls, and tools designed specifically for classroom use. Institutions gained better administrative control over student AI access.

GitHub Copilot Tier Consolidation. The five GitHub Copilot tiers (Free, Pro, Pro+, Business, Enterprise) were clarified and stabilized, with clearer feature differentiation between tiers and more flexible enterprise licensing options.

Performance and Reliability Improvements. Across all Copilot products, Microsoft focused on speed, reliability, and consistency. Response times improved, especially for Think Deeper mode, and uptime targets were increased for enterprise customers.

Looking Ahead

The pace of change in AI shows no signs of slowing. As this book goes to press, several developments are on the horizon:

- **Deeper agentic capabilities.** Copilot is moving toward more autonomous task completion – handling complex, multi-step workflows with less manual intervention.
- **Improved personalization.** Copilot is learning to adapt to individual users' preferences, communication styles, and work patterns over time.

- **Broader multi-modal support.** Video understanding, more sophisticated image analysis, and richer audio interactions are in development.
- **Tighter Microsoft ecosystem integration.** Expect Copilot to appear in more Microsoft products and to work more seamlessly across the entire Microsoft 365 ecosystem.
- **New model capabilities.** As foundation models continue to advance, Copilot's underlying capabilities will improve in areas like reasoning, factual accuracy, and nuanced language understanding.

The features described in this book reflect the state of Copilot as of early 2026. For the latest updates, visit the Microsoft Copilot blog (blogs.microsoft.com/copilot) and the GitHub Copilot changelog (github.blog).

Appendix F: Resources and Further Reading

This appendix collects the most useful resources for continuing your Copilot journey beyond this book. Resources are organized by category, with brief descriptions to help you find what you need.

Official Microsoft Resources

Microsoft Copilot - Copilot web app: copilot.microsoft.com - Copilot blog: blogs.microsoft.com/copilot - Copilot support: support.microsoft.com (search "Copilot")

Microsoft 365 Copilot (Business and Enterprise) - Adoption hub: adoption.microsoft.com/copilot - Admin documentation: learn.microsoft.com/copilot - Microsoft 365 Copilot plans and pricing: microsoft.com/microsoft-365/copilot

GitHub Copilot - GitHub Copilot home: github.com/features/copilot - GitHub Copilot documentation: docs.github.com/copilot - GitHub blog (Copilot updates): github.blog - GitHub Copilot pricing: github.com/features/copilot/plans

Microsoft Learn - Free training modules on Copilot: learn.microsoft.com (search "Copilot") - Microsoft 365 Copilot learning paths for end users, administrators, and developers

Copilot Studio - Documentation: learn.microsoft.com/copilot-studio - For building custom Copilot agents and plugins

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The AI for Everyone Series from Finnoybu Press

This book is part of the **AI for Everyone** series by Finnoybu Press, designed to help real people use AI tools effectively. Each title follows the same practical, authoritative style as this book.

Beginner Guides

- **ChatGPT: The Definitive Guide (2026 Edition)** — A complete guide to OpenAI's ChatGPT, covering Free through Enterprise tiers, GPT-5.x models, Agent Mode, Deep Research, DALL-E image generation, Sora video, voice mode, Custom GPTs, and the full ChatGPT ecosystem.
- **Claude: The Definitive Guide (2026 Edition)** — A comprehensive guide to Anthropic's Claude, covering all tiers and models, Projects, Artifacts, extended thinking, vision, writing, coding, and Claude's distinctive approach to safety and reasoning.
- **Gemini: The Complete Guide (2026 Edition)** — A complete guide to Google's Gemini, including Gemini in Google Workspace, Gemini Advanced, AI Studio, multimodal capabilities, and the Google AI ecosystem.
- **Copilot: The Definitive Guide (2026 Edition)** — *This book*. A complete guide to Microsoft Copilot across the entire Microsoft ecosystem.
- **Perplexity: The Definitive Guide (2026 Edition)** — A practical guide to Perplexity AI for research, discovery, and information synthesis.

Power User Guides

- **ChatGPT: The Power User Guide** — Advanced techniques for experienced ChatGPT users: prompt architecture, chain-of-thought reasoning, multi-turn mastery, reusable prompt systems, advanced content production, API integration, and building professional workflows.
- **Claude Code: The Power User Guide** — The definitive guide to Claude Code, Anthropic's agentic coding tool. Covers installation, code generation, debugging, testing, multi-file operations, Git workflows, hooks, MCP servers, IDE integrations, and team workflows.
- **Gemini: The Advanced Guide** — Advanced Gemini techniques for power users across Google's AI ecosystem.

- **Copilot: The Power User Guide** — Advanced companion to this book, covering Copilot Studio, custom agents, Power Automate integration, enterprise deployment, and developer workflows.

Topical Guides

- **The AI Systems Playbook** — A strategic guide to evaluating, selecting, and deploying AI tools across an organization.
- **AI Prompt Engineering** — A deep dive into prompt engineering techniques that work across all major AI platforms.
- **AI for Developers** — A practical guide to integrating AI into software development workflows, from coding assistants to CI/CD pipelines.
- **AI for Business** — A practical guide to AI-powered productivity for professionals, teams, and organizations.
- **AI for Students** — A guide to using AI tools responsibly and effectively in academic work.
- **AI for Educators** — Strategies for teaching with and about AI in the classroom.

All titles available at press.finnoybu.org. For publisher inquiries: press@finnoybu.org.

AI News and Analysis

The Verge – AI Section theverge.com/ai-artificial-intelligence Accessible, well-reported coverage of AI developments and products.

Ars Technica – AI Section arstechnica.com/ai In-depth technical coverage with excellent analysis.

MIT Technology Review – AI technologyreview.com/artificial-intelligence Thoughtful long-form journalism on AI's impact and trajectory.

Ben Thompson's Stratechery stratechery.com Paid newsletter with excellent strategic analysis of technology companies and AI trends.

One Useful Thing (Ethan Mollick) oneusefulthing.org A professor at Wharton who writes practically and thoughtfully about AI's impact on work and education. Highly recommended.

AI Ethics and Safety

Partnership on AI partnershiponai.org Multi-stakeholder organization focused on responsible AI development and deployment.

AI Now Institute ainowinstitute.org Research institute focused on the social implications of AI.

Microsoft Responsible AI microsoft.com/ai/responsible-ai Microsoft's responsible AI principles and practices.

Stanford HAI (Human-Centered Artificial Intelligence) hai.stanford.edu Academic research and policy work on AI's impact on society.

Learning Resources

Microsoft Learn – AI Skills learn.microsoft.com Free, structured learning paths for Copilot and other Microsoft AI tools. Includes hands-on exercises and certifications.

LinkedIn Learning linkedin.com/learning Video courses on Microsoft Copilot, Microsoft 365, and AI productivity. Many courses are updated regularly.

YouTube – Microsoft Mechanics Channel youtube.com/@MSFTMechanics Official Microsoft channel with demos and explainers for Copilot features.

YouTube – Microsoft 365 Community Product demos, tips, and how-to videos from Microsoft and community creators.

Communities

Microsoft Tech Community – Copilot techcommunity.microsoft.com Official community forums for Microsoft Copilot discussions, questions, and feature requests.

Reddit – r/MicrosoftCopilot Community discussions, tips, and experiences with Microsoft Copilot.

Reddit – r/github (GitHub Copilot discussions) Developer community discussions about GitHub Copilot.

GitHub Community Discussions github.community Official GitHub community for GitHub Copilot and other GitHub products.

Prompt Engineering

Microsoft Copilot Lab copilot.cloud.microsoft/prompts Microsoft's official prompt gallery with categorized examples for Copilot in Microsoft 365 apps.

Learn Prompting learnprompting.org Free, open-source guide to prompt engineering. Not Copilot-specific, but the techniques apply broadly.

Anthropic's Prompt Engineering Guide docs.anthropic.com/claude/docs/prompt-engineering Excellent guide to prompt engineering from the makers of Claude. Many techniques transfer to Copilot.

For Developers

GitHub Copilot Documentation docs.github.com/copilot Official documentation covering setup, features, best practices, and troubleshooting.

VS Code Documentation – Copilot code.visualstudio.com/docs/copilot Documentation specific to using Copilot in Visual Studio Code.

GitHub Copilot Trust Center github.com/features/copilot/trust Security, privacy, and IP information for GitHub Copilot.

For IT Administrators

Microsoft 365 Copilot Deployment Guide
learn.microsoft.com/copilot/microsoft-365/microsoft-365-copilot-setup Step-by-step deployment guidance for rolling out Copilot in an organization.

Microsoft Purview Compliance learn.microsoft.com/purview Data governance and compliance tools that integrate with Copilot.

Microsoft Entra ID (Identity Management) learn.microsoft.com/entra Identity and access management for controlling Copilot access in organizations.

Books

Co-Intelligence: Living and Working with AI by Ethan Mollick (2024) An accessible, practical book about how to work with AI effectively. Written by the Wharton professor behind the One Useful Thing newsletter.

The AI-Powered Workplace (various authors, 2025-2026) Multiple titles covering AI in professional settings. Check your preferred bookseller for the most current options.

Resources and URLs were verified as of early 2026. In the fast-moving AI landscape, specific URLs may change. When in doubt, search the site name directly.